

Gospel Faith and Theology

Twelve Lectures, Delivered at the University
of Copenhagen in the Winter of 1849–50

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Copenhagen: C. A. Reitzel, 1850

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Preface

“If one assumes that all the many pastors here and abroad who deliver and write sermons are believing Christians, how is it then to be explained that one never hears or reads the prayer that lies so near at hand, especially in our times: God in heaven, I thank Thee that Thou hast not required of a human being that he should comprehend Christianity; for if it were required, then I should be the most wretched of all. The more I seek to comprehend it, the more incomprehensible it appears to me, the more I discover the possibility of offense. Therefore I thank Thee that Thou requirest faith alone, and I pray that Thou wilt increase it in me further. This prayer would be entirely correct as orthodoxy, and, granted that it were true in the one praying, it would at the same time be correct irony over the whole of speculation. But is faith to be found upon earth!”

These words of a Christian psychologist who knows “The Sickness unto Death” I use as a preface to the present writing, partly because they have gripped me deeply, partly also because they may best help me to a distinction without which my lectures, in spite of all protests and deprecating assurances, will hardly escape misinterpretation — I mean the distinction between striving for faith and disputing about faith.

To strive for faith is divine; to dispute about faith is human, indeed in part worldly. The reader will thus already be able to discern from this why the above words are not placed as a motto, but are simply set up as a preface: an ingenious motto awakens an expectation; but this preface stands just here in order to turn an expectation away.

However much I have striven in these lectures to avoid everything that could in any way have the appearance of a merely personal quarrel between man and man, I have nevertheless not been able to avoid coming so close to the established order that the reader might, from his point of view, have a kind of right to construe something personal in it. However much I have striven in these lectures from first to last to make it comprehensible that Christianity does not will to be comprehended, I have nevertheless not been quite able to avoid the appearance of setting a concept against a concept, a theory against a theory. For to explain why one cannot explain is after all always to entrust oneself to an explanation; to give grounds why no grounds can be given is, after

all, nevertheless to engage in a grounding.

The present lectures must therefore, in accordance with their design and execution, naturally put up with being reckoned among that sort of attempt in which one does not so much strive for faith as, properly speaking, dispute about faith.

But to dispute about faith is, after all, only human; to strive for faith — that is in truth divine. The latter must on no account be confused with the former; in order to forestall such a confusion, the distinction ought to be brought out as definitely as possible.

As I now sat pondering this distinction and sought a telling expression, those words came to my mind: *“I thank Thee, God in heaven, that Thou hast not required of a human being that he should comprehend Christianity!”*; and the words stirred in my memory and formed for me an image, a speaking image, the image of a Lutheran pastor holding prayer in his congregation.

Since I then wished to present, as in an example, what difference there is between disputing with grounds against grounds and forgetting all finite grounds in a single decisive *personal* ground; between disputing with explanations against explanations and keeping all explanations in a single all-explaining thought; in short, what difference there is between disputing about faith and striving for faith: it then seemed to me that I could choose no better example than the example of this praying pastor, who assuredly will not dispute with anyone about faith, but will strive in all inwardness — and yet with all the world — for faith.

That the striver’s prayer must appear to an outside observer as a “correct irony over the whole of speculation” is comprehensible; it is, after all, no church prayer for “Christian science,” no prayer-day prayer for “the critical introduction”: the irony is then not in the words either, but in the deed, not for the one praying, but for the reflecting observer. The prayer itself is a simple and to that extent also “unscientific” prayer in faith for faith; but the reflecting onlooker hears it at once, where the words of the one praying as it were involuntarily betray a secret acquaintance with “the whole of speculation.” How else should the pastor know within himself that he would be “the most wretched of all” if it were required of him that he should comprehend Christianity; how should just this pastor, among so many ratiocinating, criticizing, aestheticizing pastors who otherwise carry the Church’s “dogmatic” speculations without anyone’s being able to notice on them that the burden weighs; how — I ask — should just this one be able to feel so deeply that on speculation’s terms he would have to become — “the most wretched!” — if he had not himself, and at his own risk, also once allowed himself to look into “the Concept,” and then looked so deeply that with horror he saw — “the possibility of

offense.”

If, then, there really were everywhere by all pastors and in all congregations such striving in faith for faith; if those days returned when the question of the blessed life was the race’s highest question; if the Church’s great jubilee year were now so near that it rang in our ears, as though we already heard the peal of the bells that are to ring it in: yes, then our awakened ones could easily enough dismiss a merely “theoretical school-quarrel,” and refer to life’s “ordeal by fire” those who — “instead of acting accordingly!” — only write about it, insofar as they write about faith. “But” — adds the Christian psychologist — “is faith to be found upon earth!”

If, however, in order to be rid of the “school-quarrel” together with its investigations, one wishes to give the matter a more sober turn and declare that the dispute of principle here announced does not after all signify much, since the victory — if we are finally to be quite candid — has at bottom already been decided beforehand in another place: then from my present standpoint I can of course have not the least objection, but can only rejoice that with so fine a candor one is at last disposed to give truth the honor.

The struggle in which the principle of faith can, with the most intensive power of reflection, make war on dogmatizing speculation has assuredly been fought out in a quite other and higher productivity than the one that can be offered in these discourses. The victory that under the conditions at hand can be won over the age’s aesthetic, metaphysical, systematic, world-historical “delusions of sense” has — so far as I can judge — really already been won by another, and that in the deepest silence, and that so comprehensively, so completely, and on so extensive a scale, that he who won such a victory might surely with right say to himself: “we have more than conquered.”

All the same, there is here still, I suppose — so far as I can see — “ein Aber dabei.”

For with wars and victories things stand somewhat otherwise in the spiritual than in the sensuous world. If a man in the world of the senses has been bodily slain, anyone can easily convince himself that the fallen one really is dead. But in the world of spirit it is otherwise. In the world of spirit a man can sometimes be struck so mortally, and yet so deftly, that not even he himself (much less so many others) rightly notices that anything has actually happened to him. This will be the case precisely in proportion to the greatness of the superiority before which the vanquished has fallen. In the bodily sense it may indeed be ridiculous enough to treat a living man as a ghost, even though rumor has falsely reported him dead; since sensuous appearance is of course the most striking proof that the person is still alive. But in the world of spirit it is otherwise. In the world of spirit, outward appearance and phenomenal well-being stand, not so very

seldom, in an — alas! — entirely inverted relation to the individual's inner health and essential vital force; here, then, what experience will also teach us holds above all: that appearance deceives.

Since now the deceptive appearance is undeniably truth's most dangerous enemy, it becomes in the world of ideas sometimes necessary that one not merely strive for truth and right as in soundless silence, but that one also, with a somewhat louder (and just for that reason somewhat coarser) kind of weapon, dispute at the same time about who it actually is that has conquered in the struggle. If one neglects this last too much, it might easily happen that the higher ideal plenitude of power were — at least for a time — bungled, and a confusion arose in the invisible republic, a confusion far more dangerous to the highest and holiest interests than the confusion that arises in the visible when a besieged fortress lacks a commandant.

So I conclude from this that it might not yet be so entirely without significance to offer a dispute about the principle of faith-knowledge, and I therefore beg the well-disposed reader to be content with my contributions.

How precarious my task nevertheless shows itself to be, everyone must surely admit who thinks the matter over a little more closely.

If there really is to be a dispute here about who it is that has conquered in the struggle, how near at hand does not the misinterpretation lie that the alleged interest in the conception of a principle may after all serve only as one of those pretexts with which a selfish passion would embellish a presumptuous vanity.

Should this misinterpretation (which, however, I do not assume) prove able to force its way through and establish itself as the authentic interpretation: then I must ask that the accusation be advanced so openly and so entirely without all *reservatio mentalis* that it can expressly fall upon me alone.

I put forward this request not in order to affect a heroism I do not possess, but because I regard it as my duty to attempt everything that can in any way contribute to keeping this cause as clean as possible.

That a person who has hitherto lived peaceably, quietly, contentedly, as one who had enough in what was his own, should suddenly rush out and begin to make a noise; that a man who is not otherwise known to have overstepped the bounds of propriety should suddenly appear in motley dress, and in borrowed plumes, and as one who is about to triumph; that an otherwise sober author, to whom the authorities of literature have hitherto not denied a certain cultivation, composure, and thoughtfulness, should all at once take it into his head to comport himself as though he had either been stung

by a fixed idea or else were so far possessed by the demon of vanity that, for want of being something himself, he had to fashion himself after another: that such a thing can happen, how sad, how lamentable! that such a thing really does happen, how sad, how lamentable for the one to whom it happens; but — when it really does happen — it does not after all corrupt the cause, otherwise serious, that such a prostituted person imagines himself to be championing.

If, on the other hand, an author with a somewhat sounder sense set about treating a matter of faith, and yet nevertheless (be it from presumption or from clumsiness) got the higher so entangled in the lower, the religious in the worldly, the matter of principle in the personal, that he not only vexed the established order by his loud-voiced objections (which in the old forms might perhaps otherwise still preserve much that is both noble and good), but even attempted to draw into this relative squabble, in itself utterly subordinate for the religious, “another” as well — “another” who is otherwise never present where trumpets are blown, “another” who otherwise declines every outward advancement, “another” who otherwise by no means covets to be distinguished in wars, if only he may be unnoticed in peace, “another” who otherwise so urgently prays that he as an irrelevance may always be forgotten, and that the thought, only the thought, be remembered: then such an unpleasant proceeding ought assuredly to be rejected from both sides with energetic protest, and every word in the unwarranted attempt annulled, as the court annuls an abusive word.

This and much else I have now discussed and weighed as best I could; but with all this I must still (at least provisionally) confess myself to the opinion that one ought still — *propter iniquitatem temporum!* still — as matters stand *in republica litterarum!* still ought to make an attempt and dispute about faith.

Should it at length come to the point that one did not even find it worth the trouble to dispute about faith, would that then also be a good sign? Would it not rather be a sign that one despised this human struggle because at bottom one did not respect the divine one either; a sign that one found it still less worth the trouble to strive for faith: a sign that faith was no longer to be found upon earth?

The author of the present writing candidly confesses that he does not yet rightly understand, either in word or in deed, how to strive for faith as one ought; but in the hope that the divine may one day fall to his lot, if only he does not, in all too sensuous security, all too much neglect the human, he has wished — if not indeed for the instruction of many, then at least for his own strengthening — to express himself in these lectures concerning the manner in which, at the present time, one — disputes about faith.

Copenhagen, 17 February 1850.

R. Nielsen.

First Lecture

Introductory considerations. Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

It is the relation between the faith of the Gospel and theology that is made the object of these lectures. Instead of saying “the faith of the Gospel,” we may at once say “Christianity”; on the other hand, we cannot without further ado make “theology” equivalent to “science.” The question of the relation of the faith of the Gospel to theology thus points provisionally to another and more general question, namely that of Christianity’s relation to science.

As is well known, this relation is conceived very differently at different times and in the different schools, now as a relation of conflict, now again as one of reconciliation.

In the conflict between Christianity and science there are some who go so far as to demand, in the name of science, that Christianity be extirpated, while others, on the contrary, in their zeal to advance Christianity, preach crusades against free science.

With the feeling that there cannot possibly be conflict in the essence of truth, and that the kingdom of truth cannot be divided against itself, men have then again labored to reconcile the contending parties and to bring about a reconciliation by little by little making Christianity scientific and — what comes to the same thing — science Christian.

Which of these endeavors are we now to grant our approval? That is not so easy to say. The whole matter seems so involved that we cannot approve any single one of the attempts indicated here without approving them all, nor reject any single one without rejecting them all. For if those who want the conflict are right, then those who want the reconciliation must be right too. To invite to reconciliation is here the same as to presuppose conflict and to incite to conflict; and conversely, to proclaim conflict is here the same as to invite to reconciliation.

This obscure speech will perhaps clear up and become intelligible when I now set forth my thesis, the two-sided fundamental thought about which these discourses are to move, the thesis, namely, that *Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the*

Gospel heterogeneous with theology.

The first member of this thesis is hypothetical; the last is categorical.

That Christianity is higher than science cannot be established by any universally valid proof whatsoever. A universally valid proof of this would have to be a scientific one; but a scientific proof that Christianity is higher than science is a contradiction.

In hypothetical form, on the other hand, the proposition can be expressed thus: “if Christianity is what it says itself to be, a revealed truth, then this truth must belong to a sphere higher than the one to which science can raise itself”; and conversely: “if science’s sphere is the highest sphere of the highest truth, then Christianity is lost, and faith abolished.”

That science’s sphere must necessarily be the highest sphere of the knowledge of truth, science cannot prove; for in undertaking to conduct the proof it begins precisely by presupposing the very thing it meant to prove, and does not get outside its own circle.

Since science, then, can neither prove nor disprove Christianity’s truth, we may with every reason combine our two hypothetical propositions in the categorical assertion that Christianity in any case falls outside science, or in other words, that Christianity is heterogeneous with science.

Should this assertion — it is as yet, of course, only an assertion — prove defensible, then three things follow at once:

a) that the vehement conflict between Christianity and science must rest on a misunderstanding; for between heterogeneous powers there can, properly speaking, be no direct conflict. Science as science cannot possibly will to offend Christianity, any more than Christianity can will to hamper or affront science, if it is true that they move in wholly different spheres.

b) that the reconciliation aimed at between Christianity and science must derive from a great misunderstanding. If the conflict is an illusion, the reconciliation must be an illusion too; for a real reconciliation presupposes a real conflict.

c) that the only condition under which science can come to offend and affront Christianity is that it draw Christianity into its own sphere and make it homogeneous with itself; and that theology is consequently, among all the sciences, the only science that can in real earnest offend and affront Christianity.

However offensive this last assertion may perhaps be to many, it follows with unmistakable consistency from the thesis set up. Our investigation thus fastens on the single question whether Christianity really is heterogeneous with every science, by whatever name it may be called, or not.

Christianity proclaims itself, like Judaism, to be a supernatural revelation. God speaks, the miracle happens: with that revelation begins. This beginning is of an unscientific or, if you will, of a supra-scientific nature, and can never become an object of rational grounding.

What Jehovah says and does in the Old Testament is incommensurable with human understanding, and cannot be scientifically grounded; what the Son, “the Only-begotten,” says and does in the New Testament is incommensurable with human understanding, and cannot be scientifically grounded. Moses and the prophets, Christ and the apostles are unscientific, that is to say: supra-scientific figures. None of them comes in the name of science, but they all come forward, and speak and act, in the name of the revealed God.

The miracle is in its essence above, and therefore in its appearance against, the law of nature, and cannot become an object of scientific treatment. Moses strikes the rock, and the spring gushes forth: this fact natural science cannot use, it does not concern it at all. Christ, “the Son of Man,” who goes to meet his suffering and crucifixion, says in the prayer that he had glory with the Father before the world was; this speech philosophy cannot fathom, though it may well see and understand that, if the speech is true, then it must be a supra-scientific, a divine speech.

If revelation is in its principle heterogeneous with science, how then should they come into conflict with one another?

Revelation meets with natural science. Natural science now assures us that if miracles have happened, then they must have happened against the order of nature; but the very same thing is taught by revelation as well. Let natural science then investigate things and discover the laws; let it convince itself in continued inquiry that in nature’s kingdom there is no leap, in the system of laws no place for the supernatural facts; let it go further still, let it with ingenious sagacity gather the manifold analogies of its rich experience in order to make these facts as unreasonable, as improbable, as possible: it will nevertheless still not come to offend Christianity; for Christianity by no means asserts that its facts should accord with the analogies of sensuous experience. Natural science may quite certainly assure us that Christianity’s fact cannot be explained from the connection of natural forces; provided only that it does not assure us of more (and more it is surely not entitled, as science, to assure us of): then it does not offend Christianity. It may even, if it finds itself called upon to do so, take one step further and say that the phenomena of revelation are so contrary to the laws of nature that they appear even absurd in relation to natural phenomena; provided only that it does not say more (and more it is surely not

entitled, as science, to say): it still does not offend Christianity; on the contrary! precisely in this respect there is here the very best understanding between natural science and Christianity, since they both, each in its own measure, at bottom say the very same thing.

Revelation next meets with philosophy, and the horizon widens. Natural science and Christianity can still more easily preserve their heterogeneity; only as it were in passing does natural science graze the precincts of the supernatural, and it feels seldom tempted to press deeper in. It is otherwise with philosophy, which, in testing all things, makes even Christianity itself an object of scientific testing. But is this then permitted? Of course! So liberal is Christianity that it does not even refuse to become an object of philosophy's severest investigation (were it to refuse this, it would offend science). So liberal is Christianity that philosophy is thus allowed to do with it what it will, to declare it comprehensible if it can justify that before science, to reject it as incomprehensible if it can justify that before science, but — be it noted — on one condition: that philosophy with all this does not at the same time take it into its head to want to make itself homogeneous with Christianity.

If this condition is inviolably kept, then there is surely no danger, either for philosophy or for Christianity. If philosophy declares that it has now at last comprehended, or is at any rate well on the way to comprehending, Christianity, there is still no danger, provided it is said only in the name of science. Because Christianity, *scientifically understood*, now and then shows itself to be comprehensible (or at any rate nearly comprehensible), it can for that very reason, *Christianly understood*, be just as fully what it is and what it has always been: wondrous, inconceivable, for us sinful human beings incomprehensible. And because philosophy now and then flares up and wants on science's behalf to remonstrate with the cultivated world that Christianity has now at last shown itself in its true light, as incomprehensible, absurd, and meaningless, there is here nevertheless no real danger, for here at bottom there is no real conflict. No, far from it! Philosophy is now, without perhaps in the heat of it rightly noticing so itself, just now on the way to the very best understanding with Christianity. Christianity has, after all, never promised that it would ever let itself be comprehended (or at any rate nearly comprehended) by philosophy. Christianity is so far from being anxious about this philosophical discovery that on the contrary it congratulates science on the discovery, since it is so glad to see that philosophy, which seeks the truth, should at last come to the knowledge of truth, i.e. to the knowledge that it is heterogeneous with Christianity.

So it is strange enough with this relation between science and Christianity. They quarrel, are reconciled, and quarrel again. According to the prevailing way of seeing

things, one is much troubled about the conflict and ponders deeply on the reconciliation; and the conflict would be still harder, and the reconciliation awaited still more ardently, if the world had not already grown so clever that, with the feeling that at bottom not much comes of either the one or the other, it had already begun to grow a little embarrassed by the whole thing.

Here the matter stands otherwise. Instead of being troubled about the conflict and hoping for the reconciliation, as if it were self-evident that both the conflict and the reconciliation had true validity and exceeding significance, we are now on the contrary so placed that we cannot rightly see what all this fuss actually leads to, since the whole seems to rest on a misunderstanding.

There must, however, be a ground for this misunderstanding; there must be a medium in which the heterogeneous powers meet one another, and engage one another in such a way that they at least acquire the appearance of being homogeneous: where now is this ground? which is this medium? — the existing human being!

In human existence, i.e. in the existing human being, heterogeneous magnitudes are bound into unity. The sensuous and the spiritual, the temporal and the eternal, the natural and the supernatural meet here. It is the human being's general task to relate himself differently to what is different. But when revelation enters in, the difference and the opposition become so strong that the human being, even though he feels within himself that truth is only one and can only be one, is nevertheless led into so deep a dualism of truth that in this existence he must relate himself in entirely different ways to two truths so heterogeneous in existence as: *the truth of revelation and ordinary rational truth*.

From this it is explained how the conflict between Christianity and science arises within Christendom,

The Christian becomes a naturalist; the naturalist is a Christian. Both heterogeneous determinations are combined in one consciousness. The task is that the individual concerned shall now understand how to relate himself Christianly to Christianity and scientifically to science, so that he does not derive conclusions for natural science from Christianity, or conversely draw consequences for Christianity from natural science. But since it is after all the same human being, the same consciousness, that is here to unite the heterogeneous in existential unity: how near at hand does not the temptation then lie to make the heterogeneous magnitudes a little homogeneous, to treat science Christianly and Christianity scientifically, to awaken the discord by striving after the reconciliation.

The Christian becomes a philosopher; the philosopher is a Christian. What matters now is to relate oneself Christianly to Christianity and scientifically to science. But since Christianity proclaims itself as the truth, and since science, *in specie* philosophy, investigates and tests the truth: how near at hand does it not then lie to make Christianity's religious knowledge homogeneous with the philosophical knowledge of Christianity, to reconcile faith with knowledge, and precisely thereby to awaken discord between faith and knowledge!

Natural science and philosophy are, however, with respect to principle and point of departure still so different from Christianity that one easily becomes aware of the heterogeneity, provided the conflict is only carried on consistently. But there is yet another science, a science far more intimately akin to Christianity, a science that with a certain self-regard calls itself the Christian one, a science that claims to have principle and presuppositions in common with Christianity, a science that will absolutely defend Christianity in order to defend itself along with Christianity, a science that presses so close up against Christianity that it is as though they were to live and die together; this science is theology: is Christian theology, then, also heterogeneous with Christianity? — Certainly! Theology as science is assuredly just as heterogeneous with Christianity as any other science. That the relation is here more ambiguous is explained quite simply by the fact that theology is itself an ambiguity.

How matters stand more closely with this ambiguity is not difficult to discover.

Faith cannot be without knowledge. The believer must know what it is that he believes, must be able to give an account, to himself and to others, of the content of his faith and of the communion to which he confesses. Insofar as theology now sets itself exclusively the task of finding out what the Christian is, of developing and explaining what it is that the Church believes and the believer confesses, to that extent theology as theology is doubtless homogeneous with the objective doctrine of Christianity; but this objective doctrine of Christianity is therefore by no means homogeneous with Christianity itself. Insofar as the theologian relates himself Christianly to Christianity, he does not relate himself scientifically; insofar as he relates himself scientifically to Christianity, he does not relate himself Christianly.

The old orthodox theology, which in all points would be conformable to the Church's doctrine, suffered from a great ambiguity. As the comprehensive, complete, and exact presentation of the Church's doctrine, this theology was at bottom nothing other than an articulated confession of the content of faith, and as such not yet science. It was at most only the scientific expression and form of faith-knowledge. But scarcely had it begun in

form to take on the stamp of science, and thus taken the first step toward a reconciliation of Christianity and science, before it also found itself placed in a hard self-contradiction. The content was Christian, the form scientific; this was the contradiction between form and content, a contradiction under which orthodox theology at length succumbed.

Orthodox theology presents every doctrinal proposition thetically, insofar as it presents it in the name of faith; this is the Christian element. But then it also treats every doctrinal proposition hypothetically, insofar as it treats it in the name of learning, investigation, and research; this, then, is the scientific element. Accordingly, every doctrinal proposition comes to be regarded from a double point of view. Christianly understood it belongs to the Church, is exalted above science, and defies every scientific attack. Scientifically understood it stems from theological research, theological discussion, and theological testing, and is thus forfeit to science, and must as such become the object of a new discussion, a new research, a new testing. Under the continued discussion, research now stands against research, testing against testing. If the research is to signify anything for Christianity, it must conform to the Church; if it is to count for anything in science, it must be free and independent of the Church. Theological testing must therefore at one and the same time be both free and unfree, both outwardly dependent and yet outwardly independent; that is a contradiction. The theological doctrinal proposition shows itself here as an ambiguous coin: on the one side, the sign of the Cross! on the other, Minerva's owl! Here it does not even help to say: render unto Caesar what is Caesar's; for this ambiguous coin belongs with equal right both to God and to Caesar.

Theology, which in the beginning would be one with the Church's doctrine, then gradually began, under free research, free discussion, and free testing, to free itself from its original relation of dependence and to transform itself from orthodox into heterodox: the more heterodox it became, the more scientific, and conversely: the more scientific, the more heterodox. Only in the last century has theology grasped itself as an independent science; only in the nineteenth century is it clearly seen that theology is heterogeneous with Christianity.

But Christianity is homogeneous with the faith of the Gospel.

Christianity is only for the believer; theology is only for the knower. The faith of the Gospel lives in the Church; theology lives in science. If they will go on relating themselves as homogeneous, they must work against each other, and will then soon work out their own mutual dissolution.

The faith of the Gospel lives in the Church. What, then, is the Church, and where is it? We answer with the Augsburg Confession: "*The Church is the communion of*

saints, in which the Gospel is rightly preached and the sacraments rightly administered” (*Ecclesia est congregatio sanctorum, in qua evangelium recte docetur et recte administrantur sacramenta*).

But theology, what is it? where is it? Theology is the science that undertakes to subject the Church’s Gospel to a historical-critical testing; the science that as time and occasion allow permits itself to reason for and against the Lord’s sacraments; the “ecclesial” science that may not indeed venture to make itself heard in the church, but may all the more freely make itself heard in the school.

The heterogeneity is now conspicuous.

The Church is that communion of faith in which the Gospel is *rightly preached*. But the Gospel is rightly preached only when it is preached as God’s Word. God’s Word is an infallible, definite, and authoritative Word. Therefore the free preaching of the Word in the congregation always goes back to the revealed original Word; the evangelical sermon must have its text: Holy Scripture supplies the text. The biblical text is read aloud for the congregation’s devotion; devotion is unscientific; devotion knows no criticism: the text read out is in every way infallible and trustworthy, as it ought to be. “So many are the words,” says the pastor, and then he adds a prayer. Thus the evangelical sermon does not begin with ratiocinating criticism, but with prayer and invocation, and only thus can the Gospel be rightly preached.

It is otherwise in theology; for theology is, after all, a science. Science, as science, cannot begin with prayer and invocation. If, then, the Church’s Gospel is to be tested in science, it must be treated in a quite different way. And so it is. In science “the critical introduction” sits with the Gospel before it and interrogates it as to whether it is genuine or perhaps spurious; and the longer one asks, and the more one interrogates, the greater the suspicion one acquires that this Gospel is perhaps after all — spurious. Then “hermeneutics” comes forward and will in the same Gospel scientifically separate the spirit from the letter, the idea from the outer garb, the truth from the representation; and the longer one sifts, the more acutely one separates, the less there comes to be of God’s Word and the more of the human word in the biblical text.

If any conclusion is to be drawn from this, it must surely be the conclusion that what the Church puts into faith, theology converts into doubt.

The Church is that communion of the Spirit in which the *sacraments are rightly administered*. But the sacraments are rightly administered only under the one decisive presupposition that the word of institution is an infallible, divine, miracle-working Word. The Church confesses that Baptism is a bath of regeneration by the Holy Spirit, and the

Lord's Supper the communion of Christ's body and blood for the forgiveness of sins to those who believe. The Church builds on the word of institution, but does not at all apply itself to comprehending the sacrament's mystery. As the Word sounds over Baptism, so it shall be believed — against understanding; as the Word sounds in the Supper, so it shall be believed — against understanding. The miracle, the wondrous efficacy of the means of grace, is not to be explained at all, not comprehended: the appropriation is only in faith.

It is otherwise in theology; for theology is, after all, science. As objective science, theology must of course make the sacraments themselves into critical objects, and then treats the means of grace as means for heightening the scientific luster of idea-knowledge. Then it becomes doubtful again, highly doubtful, how one is to explain to oneself the union of the supernatural with the natural. The difficulty is that one cannot explain it rightly, and yet would so heartily like to have it explained. The longer one goes on explaining, the more doubtful the explanation becomes.

If any conclusion is to be drawn from this, it must surely be the conclusion that what the Church puts into faith, theology converts into doubt.

That theology may in its own way be right in engaging in scientific investigations, and therewith also right in engaging with doubt, shall not be denied; but what must be denied in the most definite terms is that theology should have the right to confound its own task with the Church's. It is no accident that the Church lets everything be decided in faith; neither is it any accident that theology dissolves everything in doubt. The Church tears itself down when it doubts its own authority and gives up faith; theology denies itself when by an authoritative pronouncement it breaks off its investigations in order to arrest doubt.

As doubt cannot be nourished in the Church, so faith cannot be nourished in theology. The Gospel in the Church confirms faith, as faith the Gospel; but doubt in theology conflicts with the Gospel, as the Gospel with doubt.

If any conclusion is to be drawn from this, it must surely be the conclusion that doubt is the Church's enemy, and *the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology*.

Second Lecture

In its conception of the relation between historical and religious faith, theology must separate what in religion is inseparable, and therefore the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Positive revelation — in Judaism and Christianity — is a historical revelation. As revelation it speaks to the inward human being and presupposes subjective religious faith (*fides religiosa*); as historical revelation it works upon the natural human being's representation through a complex of supernatural but nevertheless actual facts, and thus presupposes at the same time a historical faith (*fides historica*).

He who now relates himself Christianly to Christianity can and may not separate the historical from the religious. In true and living faith both factors must work together without, however, melting together. Since now historical faith, considered by itself, is heterogeneous with subjective religious faith, while the believer nevertheless unites these two heterogeneous determinations in the unity of the faith of the Gospel: it is in consequence exceedingly difficult for the ratiocinating understanding to understand the religious man.

“The sacred facts do not become actual because I believe in them; but conversely, because I know that they are actual, are historical, therefore I believe in them. It has happened that God revealed himself to Abraham; it has happened that God in former times spoke many times and in many ways to the fathers by the prophets; it has all happened, as Scripture witnesses, and therefore I believe in it.” Thus speaks the religious man. — “‘It has happened that Jesus Christ, God's only-begotten Son, born of the Father from eternity, was in the fullness of time conceived by the Holy Spirit and born of the Virgin Mary; it has happened that he suffered under Pontius Pilate, that he was crucified and died and was buried and descended into hell and rose again on the third day'; it has all happened, as Scripture witnesses and the Church confesses; and since it has assuredly happened, I believe in it.” Thus speaks the religious man.

But for the ratiocinating understanding it is nevertheless very difficult to understand

this speech. It constantly looks as though the religious man were straightforwardly building his faith on a straightforward historical certainty. It looks as though revelation's facts had, in his opinion, so many outward, particular, finite testimonies that no one could reject these facts without rejecting all history. The religious man must then appear to the cultivated (especially the theologically and scientifically cultivated) as an unscientific, uncultivated, and simple person who has so much faith because he knows so little of doubt. Many a one would then perhaps say: "If only I knew that it had all happened as it stands in Scripture; if only I knew that this one thing had happened, that Christ, after he had really died and been buried, rose again on the third day; if only I now knew that this one thing had really happened: yes, then I should surely believe, and in faith become a new and better human being. But who will vouch for us that these narratives are genuine, are reliable and in every way trustworthy? The believer is so sure of his case because he does not know the difficulties at all: he should just begin with the investigations, he should know the objections, he should just try attending a theological course on the critical introduction, and he would then soon enough come round to other thoughts." — Thus judges the ratiocinating understanding; and yet it is a misunderstanding.

The religious man can, if it must be so, very well acquaint himself with the theological difficulties without taking harm to his faith. With "the critical introduction" there is no danger at all. If the three men could go unharmed through the fiery furnace, should the believer then not also be able to go unharmed through "the critical introduction"! If we then meet the religious man as he steps out of criticism's labyrinth, and ask him how his conviction now stands, he answers us that he has indeed now learned much that he did not know before, but that he has thereby only convinced himself the further of what he already knew beforehand: that human beings' doubtful thoughts must bow before God's revealed thoughts, that human beings' works avail nothing against God's works, and all human writings nothing against God's own Holy Scripture; and in speaking thus, he speaks precisely out of his subjective religious faith (*fides religiosa*).

But this speech too is, when we consult the ratiocinating understanding, exposed to misunderstanding. The believer who defies all in reliance on the revealed Word now shows himself as one who is so sure of the historical because he at bottom derives his historical faith from his religious faith. Many a one then perhaps thinks in his own quiet mind: "The believer is right. Nor does the long learned introduction signify much, if only one could believe from the heart. If only I could believe that Christ is risen, then he is assuredly also risen, risen for me. But what use is it to hold to the Gospel of the resurrection when this fact nevertheless stands as a distant and alien event that makes

no impression. If the event could become present to me, if I could get an immediate impression of the risen Savior, like Mary Magdalene when she met him in the garden, or like Thomas when he thrust his finger into the print of the nails and cried out: my Lord and my God! But that is impossible; with the outward fact one cannot begin. The historical is something past, and can no longer become present: one must begin with subjective religious faith.”

Thus judges the reflecting observer, as he as it were inclines toward faith without, however, being able to grasp faith. And yet this too is a misunderstanding. One can in truth as little derive historical faith from religious faith as conversely the latter from the former. When we one-sidedly begin with subjective faith, the religious man holds back, throws himself to the opposite side, and lays an infinite emphasis on the historical. “It has all happened as it stands written, and since it has happened, I believe in the fact.” — If we then take this historical element in and for itself, and let theological criticism shake the fact: then the religious man again strains against it with all his might, throws himself to the other side, appeals to the Spirit’s inner testimony, and now holds the historical fast with infinite passion in subjective, religious faith.

To want to derive religious faith from historical faith is a misunderstanding that leads to a Catholic extreme; to abandon the historical and hold to subjective religious faith is a modern Protestant extreme.

The Catholic Church would by a divine authoritative pronouncement forbid all freer criticism, and comes into conflict with science. By its authoritative pronouncement it shows precisely that it fears science, and is afraid that all is not quite right with the historical. This fear awakens suspicion; this suspicion undermines faith.

Modern Protestantism sets criticism free; criticism dissolves the historical, and undermines faith. For if “the critical introduction” is to have the least influence on religious conviction; if from criticism’s results one may draw a single conclusion for or against faith, then it is assuredly impossible for subjective faith, at least at that moment, to believe religiously in Holy Scripture.

Whence now does this come? Doubtless from the fact that in Catholicism as in Protestantism one has made *Christianity homogeneous with science, the faith of the Gospel homogeneous with theology*.

If Catholicism were conscious that Christianity and theology are heterogeneous, it would not need at all either to forbid or to restrict free criticism. If Protestantism fully saw that the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with science, the Church would not need at all to heed the critical dissolution.

The delusion maintains itself by the fact that the historical and the subjectively religious work together in the unity of faith, notwithstanding that the historical, as historical, is nevertheless heterogeneous with the subjectively religious.

Religious faith cannot draw a single breath without supporting itself on its historical presupposition. This Catholicism has seen quite rightly, and therefore it inculcates the historical. But now the Church's doctrine is at the same time to be theology, and theology is to secure the broad historical foundation (of Scripture and tradition) by historical testimonies and historical learning, is by scientific research to raise objective, historical certainty to absolute, incontrovertibly decisive certainty. That theology cannot do, it is far beyond its powers; so one takes refuge in the ecclesial authoritative pronouncement, and the Church tyrannizes over science.

In place of the ecclesial authoritative pronouncement, Protestantism sets free subjective faith (*fides religiosa*). The Protestant consciousness has seen quite rightly that the historical is heterogeneous with the religious, that everything at last depends on the Spirit, the living Spirit indwelling the congregation, and not on a greater or lesser sum of historical, long since past events. Against this general principle we make no general objection either; only it depends on how it is applied in practice.

The false application is that in the name of faith and on faith's behalf one separates what faith cannot and may not separate. — One takes the historical by itself and makes it the object of a critical-scientific treatment. "The Bible is a collection of various writings of antiquity, written at various times by various authors under various conditions." Thus "the critical introduction" begins. Against this there is nothing to object, if "the critical introduction," in beginning its historical-critical course on these "writings of antiquity," will then at once declare that the scientific investigation signifies nothing, nothing whatever, for the faith of the Gospel and the Church's doctrine. But that "the critical introduction" will assuredly not declare. It rather lets it be understood that these investigations are important, very important, not only — what we readily grant — for the sake of learned science itself, but also important, indeed in all their particulars and their whole prolixity highly important, for all the Church's future teachers, for the pastors to be. "The critical introduction" will therefore (mediately or immediately) have a voice in deciding what the religious conception of Holy Scripture ought to be.

"The critical introduction" thinks after this fashion: let us, with the reservation of a certain general faith, first get the purely historical critically settled, and then we can always afterward draw conclusions from it for our religious conviction. But this is an entirely false presupposition. The law is that historical faith point for point is to

be maintained and borne by inward, strong, subjective, religious faith; the law is that historical faith perishes on the instant when it is abandoned by the religious. This law is violated by the critical introduction. The proof of this is that criticism's objective, or rather half-objective and half-subjective, settlement runs out into endless doubt.

Historical faith is in its essence relative, and goes only upon the probable; but the merely probable can continually be converted and weakened into the improbable. Subjective religious faith is the decisive, the unconditional, the overreaching, which grasps the absolute. But in religious speech it nevertheless looks as though both were equally absolute; for the religious man does not separate them: only in reflection do they become separated.

The relation can therefore be expressed thus:

Subjective religious faith rests upon the historical as upon its foundation, but itself bears the foundation upon which it rests.

Having thus determined the relation in general, let us then go more closely into the particular, and consider, for example, *the theologians' dispute over the Apostles' Creed*.

If only one would be content to relate oneself Christianly to Christianity and scientifically to science, then the Church could at once, for its part, end the dispute by vouching for the historical validity of its confession of faith; but now one is (if for nothing else, then for theology's sake) also to relate oneself scientifically to the Apostles' Creed: now the critical introduction begins again. — "Can one then really believe so unconditionally in this symbol as the Church assumes? Does it then come word for word from Christ himself or from his apostles? Has it not rather formed itself gradually? Is not one article taken up against the Gnostics, another against the Apollinarians? Is "the descent into hell" genuine? Let us compare the various copies and recensions. Is not the recension found in Rufinus, after all, remarkably divergent from other corresponding recensions?"

Now a mass of difficulties arises, a mass of misgivings; now there is strife here as for life and death (for here the strife is about the Church's very foundation); now the theologians divide into two ranks; now it goes: with grounds — for and against, witnesses and testimonies — for and against, interpretations of these witnesses and these testimonies — for and against, interpretations again of these interpretations — for and against. A scientific vapor of opinions and pieces of reasoning envelops the contenders! It is an involved strife; for theology carries on not only the strife, but at the same time the history of the strife; whereupon strife can again arise about how the history of the strife ought properly to be presented and judged: it goes on into infinity!

What, then, is the Church now to do with all this strife? Is it to forbid it by an

authoritative pronouncement? That would be Catholic, and is besides in Protestantism entirely impossible. Is the Church then perhaps to expect some advantage from the strife's final settlement? No, by no means! If the Church at any moment supports itself on a scientific defense, it must also put up with suffering under a scientific attack. If the Church will share theology's victories, it must also put up with sharing theology's defeats; but this conflicts both with the Church and with Christianity. Rather, the Church shall quite calmly rely on its own authority, let the strife go its scientific course, and only see to it that science keeps to what is its own.

Scientific criticism is in no way able to deprive the Church of its confession of faith. The objections, when pressed to the very furthest, cannot after all carry it further than to establishing an improbability with respect to the symbol's genuineness. When criticism has said: this confession of faith's origin from Christ and the apostles is to me in the highest degree improbable: then doubting, contradicting criticism has said the last word, and can say no more. But about this alleged improbability two things are to be noted:

a) The highest degree of improbability, which is otherwise decisive for every other historical-critical testing (when *fides historica* is taken in and for itself), will in this case not suffice. In the communication of the confession of faith the supernatural is, after all, at work. The confession of faith has its origin from inspiration, and points to the miracle. But the miracle itself belongs to the improbable. To reject the symbol on the ground of an improbability is therefore a contradiction: the miracle will continually weaken and disturb the critical attack.

b) The criticism of attack is besides weakened in another way. Those who defend the symbol find just as many grounds and testimonies for their assumption as those who attack it. So the strife is in an unceasing fluctuation of probability and improbability; here there is no settlement, the settlement is religious: faith or unbelief. The Church, which speaks the language of faith, therefore does right in maintaining the confession without heeding scientific criticism.

If we now place the believer in the midst between criticism's doubt and the Church's confession, how will he then relate himself? Differently, of course, to what is different: Christianly to Christianity and scientifically to science.

The believer may well take part in the theologians' critical dispute over the symbol, and reason for and against, like all the other critics (for insofar as he relates himself scientifically to science, he is of course also a critic). But wherein does he as a believer then differ from the theologian? The theologian expects, after all, that at last in time some great Christian-ecclesial result is to be brought out of the long critical investigation; but

that the believer does not expect at all. In relation to the Church's earnestness, the whole prolix strife is to him only as a humanly entertaining play of thought. The Christian settlement is in faith, not in theology. This will also emerge from a consideration of the strife's inner character.

Those who attack the symbol bring forward, say, 3 grounds, 3 proofs against it (whereby improbability provisionally gains the preponderance). Then the defenders come forward with 4 grounds, 4 proofs for it (and at the same moment probability rises). After some time has elapsed the attackers find out 7 grounds and 7 proofs (improbability has the preponderance again), and so on.

The religious man, who sees and understands what comes of such proceedings, is after all perfectly right when he says to himself: if I am to wait until this dispute comes to an end, then I shall have to wait until doomsday; but if I am to break off at the 20th ground because a counter-ground follows, or at the 21st proof because a counter-proof follows, then I may just as well break off at the first and only decisive ground, namely the one that lies in the Church's testimony.

Who, then, is here the more intelligent, the believer or the theologian? I should think the believer, and I venture besides to establish it by a mathematical example. There are, as is well known, infinite fractions; to want by continued division to exhaust such an infinite quotient in finite numbers is proof of mathematical ignorance. But so naive is "the critical introduction" in all its acuteness that it supposes it can exhaust an infinite quotient in finite numbers.

Yet there is still a difficulty remaining, not for faith, not for the Church, but for ratiocinating reflection, for theology.

"Let us grant," one says, "let us just grant that the Apostles' Creed is according to its content — that is to say, according to its general content — both apostolic and fundamentally Christian; but then no one can deny either that this divine original Word is expressed in human words, articulated in finite articles and finite propositions. These articles and propositions can surely not, word for word, be entirely unimprovable or unalterable. Every time the symbol is translated from one language into another, the individual propositions and expressions do after all always undergo some alteration. The symbol is besides far from containing all the important chief propositions of faith, and an article more or less can therefore not possibly be decisive for one's eternal salvation. Or should a believing Christian not be able to be saved because he was baptized on a confession of faith from which the descent into hell happened to be left out?"

Thus reasons theological criticism. But however much prestige this reasoning may

procure for itself in science, it is nevertheless, in relation to the Church, an entirely subtle and sophistical piece of reasoning.

When the criticizing theologian asks whether a single article or a single word in the confession makes any difference one way or the other, we must involuntarily think of the sophist who asks whether a single hair torn out makes a man bald, or a single grain a heap. Instead of engaging in sophisms, the Church ought for its part immediately to stop the endless reasoning, and lead the principle-less investigation back to its principle. The question of principle is not this, how many letters or how many propositions or how many articles can be thought of as left out of the confession of faith without harm to salvation; the question of principle is whether a critical separation of the divine and the human in the Church's original Word can take place without danger to faith. This question has already been answered with a No. In the original Word of the confession, God's Word is not to be separated from the historical. — Thus runs the Church's language: "As no one can eat of bread in general, but of *this* bread, *this* consecrated bread, which we break; and as no one can drink of a cup in general, but of *this* cup, *this* cup of blessing, which we bless: so too can no one be baptized upon a Christian confession in general, or in a religious communion in general, or by a minister of the Word in general; but this is the original Word's decisive authority, that he who is received into the bosom of the congregation must be baptized upon *this* confession, in *this* communion, in *this* church, by *this* pastor, on *this* day. This is the original Word's decisive authority, that the eternal here unites itself with the temporal, the divine with the human, in indissoluble definiteness; here too it holds good: 'what God hath joined together, let no man put asunder.'" Against this language of the Church, theological reasoning is vain and powerless! What critic, pray, has authority to take away a single article of the Church's confession? and what theologian, pray, has authority to insert a single article into this confession? — The faith of the Gospel joins what theology separates, and why? *Because the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.*

Third Lecture

In its conception of the confession of faith and of Holy Scripture, scientific theology must consistently go on working against faith; for the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

To want at one and the same time, in one and the same instant, to relate oneself believingly and yet scientifically to one's confession of faith is a contradiction. Insofar as I am in the confession, I am outside science; insofar as I am in science, I am outside the confession. To be great in the confession is something quite other than to be great and distinguished in science. The fisherman from Bethsaida was nothing at all in science; but the fisherman from Bethsaida nevertheless became great in the confession when he bore witness to the Master and said: *Thou art Christ, the Son of the living God*. And Christ, who hears his confession and knows what a confession means, does not answer him either in the language of science, does not place himself in a critical-scientific relation to him, but strengthens his faith, rejoices over his confession and calls him blessed: "*Blessed art thou, Simon Bar-Jona; for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father, which is in heaven.*"

But — it is many years since the first confession of Christ was heard in the world; in these many, many years one has then gradually fallen into the habit of relating oneself scientifically to Christianity and theologically-critically to the confession.

When, then, the critical introduction now takes the confession before it, holds it up to science's light, and inspects it from every side, it acquires (besides the misgivings already adduced) yet another scruple, which we must here heed all the more since this scientific scruple at the same time seems to be a religious scruple.

One reasons roughly thus:

"If the believer may on no account separate the confession's divine content from the human word and letter, then he may not have any inkling either that this human word can be subject to any alteration whatsoever. Let one judge the critical investigation as one will: he who has once been touched by doubt cannot arbitrarily break off and

return to the first simplicity. If the religious man once learns that there is more than one draft, more than one recension of the Apostles' Symbol, and if he is nevertheless to be bound to the confession's word and letter: then he must live in constant anxiety that he has not yet found the right original text; who can then blame him for seeking by continued inquiry to arrive at the greatest possible certainty about the original, for taking an interest, say, in knowing whether "the descent into hell" is originally genuine or a later addition. Suppose that this article were spurious, suppose that Christ did not descend into hell, suppose that the representation of this descent into the realm of the dead were only to be understood figuratively of Christ's actual death; then the believer who clings to the confession's word comes to believe an untruth, comes in his blind zeal to hold fast to the apostolic precisely to accept an unapostolic representation." —

This solicitude and concern of criticism for the purity of the Church's doctrine is, however fair and pleasing it may look at first glance, nevertheless of a very subtle and sophistical nature. From fear that something might possibly have crept in here in the historical (in *fides historica*) that was not purely and genuinely historical; from fear that this something should then in turn corrupt the Church and harm faith, theological criticism will benevolently seduce both the Church and the believer into making a separation that annihilates faith, namely a theoretical separation of the divine and the human in the confession's original Word. The theologian will therefore help the believer! Yes, indeed he will help him; but the help is somewhat ambiguous, the help is such as if he would help him out of the water into the fire.

The danger that a spurious article should, despite the Church's vigilance, have entered into the confession of faith is, religiously regarded, nothing beside the danger of entering upon a ratiocinating separation of the inseparable, and thereby losing faith.

In reliance on the word of the Church and of the Gospel, the believer goes with his confession confidently through the world, into eternity, before that Judge who knows all things and judges righteously. And when the human being's soul then stands before that Judge who knows all, both the historical and the non-historical and the supra-historical: then it will surely appear where the danger is and wherein it consists. The mortal danger is then not that here, in the clarity of the light, it should suddenly be discovered that the confession had by a human error acquired one article too many. No, the danger is quite another, the mortal danger is that the human being has not lived in faith in his confession as he ought. If only he has lived in faith, striven for the confession and striven the good strife: then the Judge will surely not reproach him that there is one article too many in the confession with which he comes, but will take him into grace

and call him blessed, as he called his beloved disciple blessed when he first heard his confession. But woe to the soul that comes in doubt with a doubtful confession. “The critical introduction” cannot, after all, help him when the Judge demands a reckoning. Or what use would it be if this doubting soul now began to excuse itself and say: “Lord, there were so many editions and so many recensions of our ecclesial confession of faith down there, so many mutually divergent and differing recensions, that at last I did not know which I should choose; criticism then advised me to separate the divine from the human, in Thy confession as in Thy Gospel. And so I followed criticism’s advice, and so I entered into the scientific investigations, and by my scientific investigations I came further and further into doubt, and so my faith languished, for at last I no longer knew — alas! — what I really ought to believe.” Will not then the Judge of conscience answer this doubter and say: “Thou fool, why didst thou not believe the Church’s testimony, as it runs word for word? why wouldst thou not understand that my Word is an inseparable unity of divine and human word, as I myself am an inseparable unity of God and man?”

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If anyone will absolutely misunderstand this statement, let him simply give the matter the turn as though I were hereby aiming to make science hated and to outlaw criticism; for that is truly a great misunderstanding. So far is it from being the case that in this attempt I have intended to abolish criticism, that on the contrary I have wished to help theological science to a most needful and entirely indispensable criticism: the criticism whereby one separates the real danger from the imagined.

When Luther strove for his doctrine of the Lord’s Supper, ratiocinating criticism was already in full swing, and would with all its might make a divorce between the divine and the human in the word of institution. But Luther strove for his text, for he strove in faith. “These words of institution” — he says — “bring it about that the bread is his (Christ’s) body, and the wine his blood. He who now eats this bread, he eats Christ’s true body; whoever drinks this cup drinks Christ’s true blood, be he worthy or unworthy. That one shall firmly believe; for the dear Christians shall do God the honor of confessing that what God says, that he can also do, as St. Paul writes of Abraham that he did (Rom. 4:21). Whoever will be a Christian, he shall not do as our fanatics and mutineers, who trouble themselves about how it could be that the bread is Christ’s body and the wine Christ’s blood. They will measure and comprehend God with their reason, and because it does not accord with their reason, they suppose God cannot do it either. But what is this, that one has already troubled oneself about it so long? Though one tore oneself apart, one would still not be able to comprehend God with human reason; for our Lord God is not

such a God as lets himself be measured, comprehended, and grasped by human reason, and his works and words are not such works and words as should be subject to human reason.”

“Let us suppose that our text and understanding were also uncertain and dark, as it is not, just as theirs is (the Zwinglians’ text and understanding); then you still have the glorious defiant advantage that you can with a good conscience stand on our text, and say thus: If I must and am to have an uncertain, dark text and understanding, then I will rather have the one that is spoken by the divine mouth itself than have the one that is spoken by a human mouth; and if I am to be deceived, then I will rather be deceived by God, if that were possible, than by human beings; for if God deceives me, he will surely answer for it and give me redress. Human beings cannot give me redress, but lead me to hell. Such defiance the fanatics cannot have; for they cannot say: I will rather stand on the text that Zwingli and Oecolampadius utter in discord than on the text that Christ himself utters in concord.”

“Therefore you can gladly say to Christ both in your death and at the last judgment thus: My dear Lord Jesus Christ! There has arisen a quarrel about thy words in the Supper: some will have it that they are to be understood otherwise than they run. Since they teach me nothing certain, but only confuse me and make me uncertain, and can in no way either will or prove their text: so I have abided by thy text, as the words run. If there is anything dark in it, then thou hast willed to have it dark; for thou hast given no other explanation of it, nor commanded one to be given. Likewise one finds in no writing or language that is should mean *signify*, or *my body sign of the body*.”

“Should there now be a darkness in it, then thou wilt surely bear with me that I do not hit upon it, just as thou didst bear with thine apostles that they did not understand thee in many respects; as when thou didst proclaim thy suffering and resurrection, and they nevertheless kept the words as they ran, and did not make others of them. Just as thy dear mother also did not understand when thou saidst to her (Luke 2:49): I must be about my Father’s business, and she nevertheless simply kept the words in her heart and did not make others of them. So I too have abided by these words: *This is my body, this is my blood*.”

What a contradiction it is to want at one and the same time to relate oneself both Christianly and scientifically to Christianity becomes (if possible) still clearer to us when we look to the theologians’ involved dispute about Holy Scripture. Let us first consider the dispute in its generality, in order the better to be able to assess the principle that develops in its particulars.

That the Church has its Holy Scripture; that it regards this Scripture as a Scripture breathed in by God, inspired, so that Scripture's human words are at the same time God's Word, no one can deny who does not straightforwardly wish to deny the existence of the Church and of Christianity.

The Church therefore has its Holy Scripture, and posits a difference of quality between this holy, inspired Scripture and every other writing. Inspiration is Scripture's quality. This quality is inculcated with so great emphasis by the Reformers that the validity of our evangelical Church's confessional writings is even made straightforwardly dependent on Holy Scripture. The Augsburg Confession, which is after all regarded as our Church's palladium, is built upon Scripture; it is therefore not to hold in and for itself alone; but it is to hold *quia et quatenus*, *because* and *insofar as* it accords with the Word revealed in Holy Scripture.

The theologians, who at bottom wrangle about everything, dispute about everything and doubt about everything, are of course still in much doubt and dispute about how this *quia* and *quatenus*, this *because* and this *insofar as*, is properly to be explained.

If we consider the relation from the standpoint of the Church and of the faith of the Gospel, the explanation is easy to find out. When the evangelical Church confesses of its confessional writings that they are to hold only *insofar as* (*quatenus*) they agree with Holy Scripture: then it has by no means been the Church's meaning to abandon these confessional writings to theology's critical-scientific treatment. We know how it went with Melanchthon, who attempted to alter the 10th article on the Lord's Supper. Melanchthon was the most respected theologian of his time, indeed the man who had himself drawn up the Confession; but the faith living in the Church set itself against the theologian, and the theologian had to give way. The Church could not at any moment doubt that the confession must be true and trustworthy (how, indeed, should a church body be able to come forward with a confession doubtful by its own admission); the Church declares that the Confession stands fast *because* it accords with Scripture. In this *quia*, in this *because*, lies unconditional certainty; but in this *quia*, *because*, there is at the same time expressed the thoroughgoing difference of quality that obtains between Holy Scripture and the Confession. Scripture is inspired, the Confession is not. This difference does not bear most closely on the content (for the essential content must at bottom be the same in the Confession as in Scripture, since the Confession has its content from Scripture); but the difference of quality points to the connection between the divine content and the human word. In Scripture this connection is absolutely indissoluble, for Scripture is holy and inspired; in the Confession, on the other hand, the connection is

not absolute: the same content can be expressed in other, perhaps more adequate, words and propositions. Individual articles can be added or, in order to make the sense still clearer, expressed in other words, should the Church at some time under other conditions find itself called upon to do so. Thereby the expression *quatenus*, *insofar as*, acquires its significance. Of the relation between Scripture's word and Scripture's content, on the other hand, no *insofar as*, no *quatenus*, holds. In Scripture itself the connection of the divine and the human (content and form, meaning and expression) is in every way so perfect, so absolute, so infallible and unalterable that no separation can be thought: Scripture is holy and inspired; every word in the canonical Scripture is a Word of God, breathed in by God.

But when this conception is made to hold in all its strictness, everyone surely understands that it is a religious and not a scientific conception. The contradiction, the glaring contradiction that lies in wanting at one and the same time to relate oneself religiously and yet scientifically to Holy Scripture, shines out from orthodox theology's own history.

There is in our Church's history a period that has rightly been called the bibliolatrous period. Bibliolatry, idolatrous Bible-worship, is quite a telling expression for the unblessed attempt to relate oneself at one and the same time, in the same respect and in equal degree, both objectively-scientifically and subjectively-religiously to Holy Scripture.

For the objective scientific observer the Bible is an outward object; for the religious man it is a holy object: for the scientifically religious man the Bible is therefore an outward holy object, i.e. an object of idolatrous worship.

So there sits the scientific but nevertheless orthodox Protestant, and looks worshipfully at his Bible, just as the scientific but nevertheless orthodox Catholic looks worshipfully up to his Pope. It is of no use at all that a Protestant critic subjects the Pope to a scientific assessment and in this assessment lays bare his faults and sins: the orthodox Catholic believes in the Pope just as fully, the orthodox Catholic will be sure to defend the Pope's objective infallibility with objective grounds; for the orthodox Catholic worships the Pope. Just as little does it help that a Catholic critic — to the advantage of the one saving Church — sets about reasoning against the Bible and laying bare its human imperfections: the orthodox Protestant scientifically rejects every scientific objection; the orthodox Protestant will be sure to go on defending the Bible's objective infallibility with objective grounds; for the orthodox Protestant worships the Bible.

In Protestantism's orthodox theology the objectively scientific theory of inspiration was developed with bibliolatrous consistency. The Bible was not merely inspired, but

grammatically-linguistically inspired to the last dot and tittle. The Holy Spirit had expressly dictated to the holy men every word, every letter they were to write. The holy men were therefore also called “God’s scribes,” “God’s pens” (*notarii Dei, calami Dei*).

In the theory of inspiration, then, the faith of the Gospel and theology were to have found their essential and indissoluble point of union; but behold! in the theory of inspiration lay precisely the germ of their future separation.

In holding fast Scripture’s quality in the unity of the divine and the human effected by inspiration, the faith of the Gospel is at the same time willing to acknowledge the difference and to conceive Scripture’s human side as it factually shows itself. Faith does not at all aim at comprehending the relation, but thanks God that it can appropriate the content: faith relates itself subjectively to the inspired original Word.

But orthodox theology, which related itself objectively and scientifically, now wanted at the same time to draw scientific conclusions from the religious presupposition, and thereby brought about its own fall.

The religious unity of the divine and the human in Scripture’s word learned theology then in the first place conceived as a *grammatical* unity. Thus arose the dispute about the inspiration of the vowel points in the Old Testament (the Buxtorfs — Ldv. Capellus). In this dispute orthodoxy suffered a great defeat.

The religious unity of Scripture’s divine content and human form learned theology next conceived as a linguistic-aesthetic unity. “If the New Testament was breathed in by the Holy Spirit, then the New Testament’s Greek” — so the theologians supposed — “must also be the purest and most perfect Greek.” Thus arose the dispute about the Greek style of the New Testament (Seb. Pfochen, Siegm. Georgi — Thom. Gataker, Salmasius, Sturz and others). In this dispute orthodoxy suffered a great defeat.

With respect to the orthodox theory of inspiration we must therefore expressly note: a) that it dissolved in its own consequences; b) that it weakened the independence of the Church and of faith; c) that it paved the way for negative criticism.

Once criticism had first broken through orthodoxy’s theological rampart, it gradually tore down the Church’s remaining religious presuppositions, according as it found that they stood in its way. Under the pretense that the historical facts were at bottom inessential for faith, criticizing theology understood how by manifold turns of phrase to fob off the general feeling of piety, and could then all the more freely place itself in a purely scientific relation to Scripture.

The still moderate, half-scientific and half-consistent theology is a masked freethinking; resolute freethinking is theology’s scientific consequence.

In theology's dispute with the modern consciousness the theologians suffer day by day one defeat after another, come deeper and deeper into the difficulties, deeper and deeper into doubt.

Doubtless considered theology can still beat back many an attack that an over-heated criticism may have directed against the genuineness of one or another biblical writing; but what is thereby won? Can the theologian ever bring it to the point where he dares to say: "The genuineness of this disputed writing is settled, now at last settled once and for all"? — By no means! such an assertion is unscientific, and conflicts straightforwardly with the conditions of historical faith (*fides historica*). The theologian brings it at the very most only to a halt, a provisional halt: "this writing's spuriousness is not yet settled!" But if the genuineness is not quite settled either, then it is after all subject to doubt; but if it is subject to doubt, it is after all lost for faith; for faith goes out where doubt comes in.

So now the freethinker and the theologian contend — under the same presupposition, under the same scientific principle: only the language and the mood differ. The freethinker is resolute: "The spuriousness is settled!" The theologian is irresolute: "The spuriousness is not yet settled." The freethinker has in the name of science exchanged faith for unbelief. The theologian has in science lost faith, and is despite all scientific exertion no longer able to raise his doubt to faith. The freethinker relates himself non-religiously to Scripture; the theologian can never bring it to the point where he, as a scientific theologian, relates himself religiously.

If the theologian will hold to the Church, he must openly break with science; if he will hold to science, he must openly break with the Church: this is the final dilemma.

If the Church is to maintain its independence, it must guard itself in equal degree against the theologian's defense and the freethinker's attack. The negative weapon with which the Church defends itself is the fundamental thought *that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*

Fourth Lecture

For scientific theology the Bible is a historical document of antiquity whose heterogeneous constituents must submit to ratiocinating criticism; for the believing conception the Bible's wondrous content is exalted above criticism, since it is impossible for the observer to relate himself critically and ratiocinatingly to the miracle: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

The Bible, the Church's Holy Scripture, has in many ways been misunderstood, misused, and maltreated by human folly; but hardly has it ever before been so misunderstood, misused, and maltreated in principle as by theological criticism in recent times.

Many fanatics have misconstrued Scripture to their own perdition; but with all that they have nevertheless related themselves to it as to a holy Scripture. Many freethinkers have scoffed at Scripture — to their own perdition; but with all that they have nevertheless related themselves to it as to a holy Scripture. For is it not precisely the mark of the holy that it tempts the fanatic and provokes the mockery of unbelief? — Why does the fanatic take refuge in the Bible? Because from this “holy inspired” book he means to prove to us that he himself is inspired. — Why does the freethinker mock at the Bible? Because it is now so great an offense to him that this old book with its “many myths” and “holy fairy tales” should still be held and count as inspired.

In relation to the fanatic and the freethinker, then, the Bible still preserves its original quality; but not so in relation to criticizing theology.

“The critical introduction” will of course conduct itself neither as the fanatic nor as the freethinker. “The critical introduction” is a punctilious person who in learned caution has little by little taught itself to stand impartially *above all party*, and supposes it thereby preserves religious equilibrium in scientific many-sidedness. “On the one hand one cannot” — so it runs — “indeed deny that there are found in the Bible many spurious constituents, many mythical legends and superstitious narratives, which must straightforwardly be referred to the popular fantasy and limited circle of representations of that time. But on the other hand neither can one deny that there are found in the

Bible so many great and glorious thoughts, so many exalted examples and elevating traits of character, that the book as a whole must awaken the greatest reverence in every feeling mind, indeed that even the scientific man must confess that this Book of books surely cannot, on the whole, have been written without a special cooperation of God.” — Roughly thus reasons “the critical introduction.”

But what sort of relation is it, then, in which “the critical introduction” thereby places itself to the Bible? Yes, it is a highly ambiguous relation, a relation that is at one and the same time to be both religious and yet scientific, and precisely for that reason is neither the one nor the other.

And what does the Bible then become in this ambiguous relation? It becomes an ambiguous book, a book that both is inspired and yet is not inspired, a peculiar book that is both the one and the other, and therefore at bottom neither the one nor the other.

In this ambiguity, then, the Bible loses its quality; and therefore I say that theological criticism’s relation to the Church’s Holy Scripture — despite the aberrations of fanaticism and the blunders of freethinking — must be determined as the properly fundamental misrelation, as the misrelation that comes nearest to untruth.

Holy Scripture is no objective scientific book, and one can as a consequence not relate oneself objectively and scientifically to it either. What the Bible is cannot be settled once and for all in and for itself; it must each time be settled in and by the relation in which the reader places himself to the Bible.

As I myself am, so is my Bible, and as my Bible is, so am I myself.

If I now relate myself believingly to the Bible, then the Bible is also for me a book of revelations, a holy inspired Scripture that shows me what I am and how I am, and casts light over my whole existence. My understanding may now doubtless discover wondrous oppositions, indeed contradictions, in this holy book. The heterogeneous is here put together into unity: the outwardly historical and the inwardly psychical, the supra-worldly and the worldly, omnipotence and frailty, the holy and the sinful are found here together in singular mixture and most wondrous interaction. This may offend the unbelieving, but is nevertheless to true edification for the believer. In the believer’s life there is, after all, something corresponding: here too the heterogeneous is bound into unity; here too the outwardly historical comes to the inwardly psychical; here too the worldly man is to relate himself to the supra-worldly, the frail to the almighty, the sinful to the holy, he who is dust and ashes to Him who is from eternity and unto eternity. In the believer’s life too there are contradictions. Insofar as the believer now learns to understand the contradictions that are in his own life, he will also learn to

understand the apparent contradictions that are in the holy inspired Scripture; and conversely, insofar as he learns to understand the contradictions in Scripture, he will with the Spirit's assistance also learn to understand the contradictions in his own life. If those holy men, although they were God's elect, nevertheless had to go on believing with hope against hope, how much more must this not hold of the religious man, who may not so call himself God's elect! And when the religious man sees that in this world one must believe with understanding against understanding; when he learns to see that this law becomes stricter and stricter in proportion as the life of faith becomes more developed and more variously illuminated by reflection: should he then not also understand that those holy men walked as the Scriptures witness only because they walked in faith and in hope, because they walked as God's elect. The relation is therefore this: the more inwardly the religious man exists in faith and understands faith's conditions, the more inwardly does he recognize that the Church's Holy Scripture is an inspired Scripture.

Even were the believer otherwise to become so distinguished in human learning and insight that he could, if it came to that, criticize all the wise men of the world and set himself up as their teacher: never will he bring it to the point of criticizing Holy Scripture and setting himself up as its teacher; but the reverse relation will increase more and more, namely that Holy Scripture in an ever higher sense becomes his teacher, the comforter and disciplinarian who endures with him unto the end.

As I myself am, so is my Bible, and as my Bible is, so am I myself.

The believer can now provisionally abstract from his faith, enter into science, and place himself in an objective, literary, critical-scientific relation to the Bible. Against this there is doubtless, from the standpoint of cultivation, nothing to object. If the historical-philological critic were forbidden to relate himself critically and scientifically to Holy Scripture, then the philosopher would also have to be forbidden to relate himself speculatively and scientifically to Christianity. If biblical criticism were straightforwardly forbidden, then the philosophy of religion would also have to be straightforwardly forbidden; but that by no means follows from the principle set up here. We inveigh as little against a true scientific biblical criticism as against a true scientific philosophy of religion. There is nothing to prevent Christianity from becoming an object of dialecticizing speculation; but the speculative philosopher must then know what it is he is doing. In placing himself in a dialectical-speculative relation to Christianity, the philosopher is outside the relation of faith; for the relation of faith is qualitatively different from the speculative relation of knowledge. As the relation now changes its quality and becomes a quite different relation, so Christianity too changes its quality and becomes

something quite different. For the believer, Christianity is God's wondrous provision for the salvation and blessedness of sinners; for the speculating man, Christianity is a magnificent phenomenon, a phenomenon in which new and wondrous ideas have shown themselves, and the speculating man now seeks to fathom these ideas' essential, metaphysical relation to the whole system of world-ideas in which we live and breathe and think. — As it goes with the philosophy of religion, so also with biblical criticism. The religious relation of faith to Holy Scripture is qualitatively different from the literary-critical relation. As the relation now changes its quality and becomes a quite different relation, so the Bible too changes its quality and becomes a quite different book. For the believer the Bible is a holy inspired Scripture; for the literary critic it is neither more nor less than a collection of writings of antiquity in the history of religion, a document of antiquity which in principle is to be conceived from the same point of view from which we conceive, say, the Indians' Veda, the Persians' Zend-Avesta, the Muhammadans' Koran.

Here now a mass of tasks presents itself for learned science: to compare codices, versions, and readings, to communicate archaeological and philological information, and so on. That these tasks are of a purely scientific kind is seen from the fact that they can be treated by anyone without regard to confession of faith. What our learned critics and philologists have accomplished in this respect, what a Wetstein, a Griesbach, a Lachmann, a Gesenius, a Winer have achieved in this direction, has its validity and scientific warrant without regard to the standpoint of faith at which those learned men have found themselves. Whether the critical philologist belongs to the Reformed or the Lutheran Church, whether he is orthodox or a rationalist, indeed whether he is at all a believer or a non-believer, makes here no difference whatever to the matter. The learned critic does not, after all, inquire in the quality of a believer, but in the quality of a knower; here the question is only of talent and knowledge, not of religiosity. What the learned inquirer achieves is to be tested and judged by the experts in the school, but not by the believers in the congregation.

If it now stands fast that there is a double relation to the Bible, a religious and a scientific one, if it stands fast that the Bible as a consequence changes its quality with the changed relation: then it will surely also be necessary to reflect a little more closely on this change of quality before one entrusts oneself without further ado to the scientific guidance that is nowadays offered in "the critical introduction."

In accordance with the Bible's double quality, as inspired Scripture and as literary document of antiquity, biblical criticism must necessarily come upon tasks of the kind

that lie on the boundary of the religious and the scientific, and which we may therefore for the present call the mixed tasks.

To these we reckon: a) The settling of which books belong to the canon. This task has a religious significance; for on it depends how many books one is to take as inspired: the question of the canon thus becomes a question of faith. But conceived from the historical-critical point of view it becomes at the same time a learned scientific question, namely that of the books' genuineness (authenticity). Further: b) The investigation of the books' trustworthiness, insofar as this trustworthiness can be built on the mutual agreement of the accounts: the question of the harmony among the 4 Gospels is a mixed question. Finally: c) The settling of all those points in which the holy authors, with respect to the purely historical, diverge from the profane writers.

It is doubtless these mixed tasks that have led introduction-criticism to place itself in that relation of ambiguity to Holy Scripture spoken of above, a relation under which faith is neutralized with science. But in this relation the mixed tasks cannot be solved; for if the mixed tasks are solved in ambiguity, the solution must itself become ambiguous.

Before one attempts to solve these tasks, therefore, one must first of all be agreed with oneself as to whether it is really under faith's or under science's presupposition that the solution is to take place. For according as one chooses the one or the other of the qualitative relations, the solution too will have an entirely different outcome.

I. *Let us now first choose the relation of faith.* The religious factor is thus the decisive one, the historical varies. In order to see what lies in this, we choose, say, the investigation of the four Gospels' genuineness.

That the historical factor (*fides historica*) varies here everyone will grant who knows a little of criticism. It is possible that our Greek Gospel of Matthew was not written by Matthew, but by another author standing in nearer or remoter contact with the evangelist himself. It is likewise possible that the evangelist John did not himself edit the Gospel that bears his name, and so on. Here there is now room for a multiplicity of investigations, hypotheses, and explanations.

The religious factor, on the other hand, is not varying, but constant. For subjective faith (*fides religiosa*) it stands unshakably fast that the four Gospels (whoever may have written them) are inspired. This ecclesial presupposition faith cannot give up without at the same time giving up its principle.

If we now put both factors together, then the conditioned is determined by the unconditioned, the relative by the absolute, and the task's solution can then be expressed thus: the four inspired Gospels are written by four inspired authors; these authors are

named after Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. The Greek superscriptions *Κατα Ματθαιον*, *Κατα Μαρκον* etc. fit here in the most exact way.

The same procedure is to be applied when the question is of the four Gospels' mutual agreement (*harmonia evangeliorum*).

The historical factor varies. Between the four Gospels there is not only a remarkable agreement, but at the same time remarkable divergences and apparent contradictions (the genealogy of Jesus in Matthew, for example, criticism cannot get to agree with the genealogy in Luke). One little word, one small alteration, and the harmony would be there; but — the little word is lacking, even the happiest explanation is nevertheless only a subjective conjecture, and so hypothesis alternates with hypothesis again.

The religious factor is constant. As the accounts stand, so shall they remain standing with unalterable divine authority; here no reflection is made on any disagreement: the one account is for the believer himself exactly as infallible as the other.

If both factors are now put together in the unity of the faith of the Gospel, the result can be expressed thus: in the four Gospels the divine content is presented in such a human form that the essential agreement between the identical accounts has at the same time taken on the stamp of apparent divergences in particular inessential points.*¹ But since the Gospels are inspired, it is impossible for the believer to separate out the divine from the human; both moments must therefore go on working together until the day comes that clears up the harmony.

What has already been said of the confession of faith holds at the same time of the Gospels, indeed of all the canonical books in the Church's Holy Scripture: the danger is not that a single article or a single narrative should by a human error have crept in; but the danger is that a critical separation of the inseparable is made, whereby inspiration is abolished and faith disappears.

This solution, which is so satisfying for the faith of the Gospel, cannot possibly be satisfying for theology; for theology is, after all, a science.

II. *If we now choose the scientific relation*, and attempt from a purely objective point of view to solve the mixed tasks, the matter at once takes another turn. The religious factor then falls away, and the historical is forfeit to criticism. Here there is now nothing fixed, nothing unconditioned: suspicion and doubt know no bound. The explanation then ends with the result that not a single Gospel is genuine, indeed that these Gospels

*"The jurists say that a capital crime swallows up all the lesser ones — so it is with faith: its absurdity utterly swallows up the petty. Disagreements that would otherwise have a disturbing effect do not disturb here, and make no difference to the matter. On the other hand it makes a great difference to the matter if someone by a calculus of pettiness wishes to auction faith off to the highest bidder; for it makes so much difference that he never comes to faith." Johannes Climacus.

first received their present form one and a half or two hundred years after Christ.

This result, which has no significance whatever for subjective faith, is on the other hand in a critical respect decisive for historical faith, and shows plainly enough how the historical factor evaporates once it has stepped out of the right connection with the religious. But when dissolving criticism, after it has by this procedure undermined the historical foundation of faith in revelation, then supposes that it can at the same time undermine the faith of the Gospel, this is — as we have already proved^{*)} — a great misunderstanding. The believer does not let himself be disturbed by the scientific declaration that the biblical writings cannot stand before criticism's tribunal; he sees in this only a confirmation of the truth that the Bible's content is a supra-scientific content, a content to which he must relate himself religiously.

As I myself am, so is my Bible, and as my Bible is, so am I myself.

If the Bible is inspired, then it must have its quality in a miracle; but if the Bible has its quality in a miracle, then it is at the same time also settled that in this quality it permits no scientific-critical conception.

A scientific-critical relation to a miracle is nonsense. This holds not only of such an inward and psychical miracle as inspiration; but it holds at the same time of the more outward and, so to speak, more conspicuous miracles.

The miracle presupposes an interaction of heterogeneous factors, of the supernatural and the natural. If this interaction is a delusion, the miracle itself must be a delusion; but if it is true, everyone must surely easily be able to see how impossible it is to place oneself in an objective relation to an actual miracle, to become a spectator at a miracle as at a physical event, or to relate oneself scientifically and critically to a narrative of a miracle as to any other historical account.

If we consider, for example, the miracles that seem to intervene most in the sensuous, the miracle by which Moses makes the spring gush forth in the wilderness, and the miracle by which Christ feeds the hungry in the wilderness: is not the reciprocal relation of the natural and the supernatural recognizable enough?

Moses lifts up his staff and strikes the rock; that a spectator can see with natural eyes, for it happens naturally. And the rock "weeps," and the spring wells up and streams, and the Israelites come to slake their thirst: that a spectator can see with natural eyes, for it happens naturally. If the spectator will not believe his own eyes, he can besides attain an immediate sensuous certainty by himself bending down and drinking of the spring. But with all this the spectator has nevertheless not come a hair's breadth nearer

^{*)}P. 20. P. 24. Pp. 28–29.

to the miracle itself. There is in this event something that not even the most scientific observer would be able to discover, and yet it is precisely this something on which the whole conception essentially depends: it is the causal connection between the staff of Moses and the gushing spring. The condition is natural; but the efficient cause, what is it: natural or supernatural? If the spectator assumes the former, then the event stands for his imagination still only as a mere *mirabile*; if he assumes the latter, it is transformed into a *miraculum*.

Which of these two assumptions the observer is to prefer cannot be settled by scientific criticism. The actual miracle can bring the spectator to a point where he must say to himself: “if I am to believe my senses here, I cannot believe my understanding; if I am to believe my understanding, I cannot believe my senses.” But further than to this dilemma the phenomenon cannot bring any spectator: the objective miracle repels the observer from itself, drives him back into inwardness, and leaves the decision to depend on the judging subjectivity.

Holy Scripture now tells us not only of the many miraculous works, but at the same time describes for us the impressions these various miraculous works made on the various eyewitnesses. How various are these impressions! Some believe unconditionally, and are saved by faith; but faith is in subjectivity. Others are startled and terrified; but the utterance of terror is conditioned by subjectivity. In the people’s cry: “a great prophet is risen up among us!” — “God hath in mercy visited his people!” we perceive a hovering between mere astonishment and inward faith; but this hovering takes place in subjectivity. The crowd is curious, thoughtless, lost in the sensuous (thus the many who came to Moses and drank of the spring in the wilderness; thus the many who came to Christ and ate of the loaves in the wilderness); but this superficial curiosity, this thoughtlessness, this animal torpor is a sorry defect in subjectivity. Some are offended; from the passion of offense there then springs in turn the explanation of offense (as when the Pharisees said of Christ: “he casteth out devils by Beelzebub”); but offense is in subjectivity.

An actual miracle is really enough to make one take leave of one’s understanding. But human beings take leave of their understanding in two ways: partly in such a way that they straightforwardly go mad, partly conversely in such a way that they give up their understanding for something higher and precisely thereby escape madness. This is perhaps even, according to the Bible’s meaning, the most exact expression for the miracle’s divine purpose: that human beings are thereby to be brought to take leave of their understanding without, however, straightforwardly losing their understanding.

The believer who believes the miracle really does take leave of his understanding, insofar as he believes — against understanding. That he nevertheless preserves his sound understanding can be seen simply from the fact that, as regards merely intelligible matters, he speaks and acts entirely sensibly. The offended man who is offended at the miracle likewise takes leave of his understanding, insofar as in a kind of passionate derangement he attempts to explain away the inexplicable; but since the deranged explanation nevertheless always affords him a certain subjective relief, he nevertheless preserves his understanding in all merely intelligible affairs, and consequently does not go mad. The Pharisees' explanation of Christ's miracle was doubtless a deranged explanation of its kind; but the offense gave itself vent in the subjective outburst of subjective passion, and the offended kept their natural understanding.^{*)}

As it now stands with becoming an eyewitness to a miracle, so it stands also with having to narrate and describe a miracle. The miracle can be grasped and appropriated only in faith; it can be narrated, described, and rightly presented only by such as stand on faith's highest step, i.e. by inspired authors.

In the narratives of miracles the two heterogeneous factors will then again show themselves in their reciprocal relation; faith's subjective factor will again be the absolute, the constant one; the historical factor the relative, the varying one.

When, therefore, two evangelists narrate the same miracle in a somewhat different way, the divergence will not touch the miracle's religious kernel, but will touch only the phenomenal attendant circumstances and psychological nuances.

As it stands with having to narrate a miracle, so must it surely stand also with having to read, conceive, and appropriate a narrative of a miracle.

As I myself am, so is my Bible, and as my Bible is, so am I myself.

It is this leading thought that I have striven to the best of my ability to hold fast and develop in my writing *Gospel Faith and the Modern Consciousness*.

There are only two pure, qualitative relations to Holy Scripture, the believer's and the freethinker's.^{*)} The criticizing theologian's relation of faith is an unclear, ambiguous,

^{*)}If the miracles of which the Bible tells us really repeated themselves in our day, the theologians would — in accordance with the principle — without doubt be among the first who stood in line to go straightforwardly mad. This formation of the miracle's effect is entirely unknown in Holy Scripture. Scripture knows only the subjective ones: *faith and offense*, but madness it does not know. That the Bible does not know such as went straightforwardly mad over the miracle must surely be explained by the fact that it does not at all know such as have attempted to relate themselves scientifically and critically to the miracle, in order to get the miracle scientifically and critically justified.

^{*)}A doubtless orthodox pastor and much esteemed convention speaker has, as I see, been busy spreading the opinion that in my writing "Evangelietroen og den moderne Bevidsthed" I am supposedly on the way to establishing two mutually contradictory and yet equally warranted truths, and that this would surely show itself if this view of mine were otherwise given occasion to clarify itself. With so fleeting

and impure relation. For that reason I have in the said writing — however gladly I should otherwise have wished it — not been able to be so fortunate as to speak to the theologians' liking; for it is truly my conviction that *Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*

and, as it appears to me, so frivolous an expression of opinion I can of course not further concern myself; I permit myself only most respectfully to remark that if the esteemed speaker had not merely glanced into the book's preface, but had really taken the time and read the book itself, then he would without doubt have seen how here too, at the conclusion, it goes with the cunning "Caiaphas." The explanation that the World-Spirit (cf. VII. Jesus Christ is the Savior of the world) at last gives of the modern dogma that *everything must happen naturally* is, even if not exactly very edifying, at any rate sufficient to exhibit the consequences in which the freethinker's supposed *truth*, if it is otherwise given occasion to clarify itself, must at length end.

Fifth Lecture

Theological interpretation of Scripture misconstrues the peculiar character of revelation, and dissolves the content of faith into science's explanation; religious interpretation of Scripture reduces science to a means for a believing appropriation of the revealed Word: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

If the Bible, the Church's Holy Scripture, is not to be lost in theology's "critical introduction," the relation of faith must be posited unconditionally, and inspiration maintained.

But even then, when the Bible in the quality of holy, inspired Scripture has come safely through theological criticism; even then, when it has come so near to the reader that no learned hypothesis can force itself in between the reading eye and the text before it; even then, when the Bible lies before us as an open book in which the believer reads the word of revelation; even then there is still a difficulty to overcome, a difficulty that, far from being diminished, is on the contrary increased by theology's theological assistance: this difficulty lies in *interpretation*.

What use is it that a believer reads the Bible, word for word, if he does not rightly understand what it is that he is reading! To read without understanding is meaningless; to read oneself into a misunderstanding is worse than not reading at all: the Bible must therefore be construed, explained, and expounded, so that its divine content can be duly understood and rightly applied: the Bible must be interpreted.

To interpret a human writing, a writing in which a superior human mind has laid down a treasure of original thoughts, is already a great art; the task becomes harder still when such thoughts and ideas are not systematically presented in science's universally valid form, but take shape in the form of the imagination, in a multiplicity of characters and situations, in the form of life, where thought is colored by passion and language varies with mood.

If it is already a great art to enter duly into an original human writing and to interpret such a writing as it ought to be interpreted: what then shall we say of the task of entering

duly into the holy inspired Scripture and interpreting this Scripture as it ought to be interpreted?

If it must be granted that the Bible has a superhuman and yet human origin, a superhuman and yet human content, then it also follows from this that the Bible's right interpretation must be not merely a human art, but at the same time a superhuman gift.

Insofar as biblical interpretation is now a human art, it must be capable of being formed by science and built on scientific rules; but insofar as it is conditioned by a superhuman gift, science does not suffice: everything depends on "the Spirit's testimony."

If there is any point in Christian knowledge where faith and science touch one another, it must surely be the interpretation of Holy Scripture.

It is not with the science of interpretation as with introduction-criticism. "The critical introduction" with all its bother and quackery the believer can cast from him at whatever moment he will; these artificial hypotheses and hypothetical arts at bottom do not concern him at all; the Bible is once and for all what it is and as it is; we have no other Holy Scripture, so Luther's defiance holds: "God's Word they must let stand, and get no thanks for it."

"The critical introduction" has accordingly also only really been developed in the last century; it is a branch of science that recent theology has chiefly cultivated for its own scientific pastime. It is otherwise with hermeneutics and the guidance science thereby offers the religious interpreter of Scripture. This guidance no one may spurn who will make himself familiar with the Bible's human form and expression.

The faith that in this matter despises human guidance is no true and sound faith of the Gospel, but a self-willed, obstinate, arbitrary faith that easily degenerates into fanaticism. "This one thing" — says Luther — "exalts holy Christendom and the Church, that one understands Holy Scripture; this one thing depresses Christendom and the Church, that one does not understand Holy Scripture All other arts and crafts have their preceptors and masters, by whom one must let oneself be taught according to order and law; — only Holy Scripture and God's Word must submit to everyone's arrogance, conceit, obstinacy, and presumption, must let itself be mastered, twisted, and construed as each understands and wills after his own head; hence so many fanatical parties, sects, and offenses, God have mercy."

In order, then, to set a dam against subjective arbitrariness, one has — and rightly — treated the art of interpretation scientifically; and theology has then founded on this its "theological hermeneutics."

But as scientific hermeneutics has organized itself theologically, here too the de-

ception has crept in, the theological deception that the Christian is supposed to be homogeneous with the scientific, the theological deception that by continued scientific application of scientific rules one is supposed to penetrate deeper and ever deeper into Scripture's divine content. A sorry error! for before one knows a word of it, science has again gained power over Christianity, and is in full course of hollowing out faith's kernel.

For it is characteristic of hermeneutics that it can set up such rules as must be approved by all who will think about their Bible, such rules of interpretation as we must from science's general point of view accord general validity, without its being therefore in any way able to govern or determine the particular application that the individual interpreter in each individual case can and ought to make of these rules.

Scripture — it is said — *shall interpret itself*. This rule of interpretation was already pronounced at the Diet of Speyer in 1529, and is to that extent a genuinely Protestant rule. But when the rule is set up as a scientific presupposition, one can of course draw from it the most various, indeed entirely contradictory, religious conclusions. The orthodox theologian, the heterodox, the rationalist, the speculative theologian, the freethinker, they can all agree on the Protestant rule; but in applying the rule they nevertheless arrive at quite different results!

The particulars in Scripture — it is said — *must be explained from Scripture's whole: the analogy of Scripture is the supreme rule for interpretation*.

A genuinely Protestant rule! but when the rule is set up as a scientific premise, theology draws from it the most contradictory religious conclusions. The orthodox, the rationalist, the speculative, the freethinker, they can all agree on the rule in general, and even so each brings out his own particular view of Scripture's whole.

This disagreement is not accidental or merely transitory, but deeply grounded in the nature of the case. The conception of Scripture's whole is precisely conditioned by the conception of the individual passages in their mutual connection; but the conception of this connection is in turn conditioned by the emphasis one will each time lay upon this or that individual passage. In one place Christ says: "I and the Father are one"; but in another place: "the Father is greater than I." In some places Scripture speaks of the Holy Spirit as of a personal, independent Spirit (in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit); but in other places the Spirit is called merely "the power from on high," "the power of the Highest." — In some places an extraordinary weight is laid on human freedom: "work out your own salvation with fear and trembling"; but immediately thereupon human freedom and human works are again reduced to a pure nothing, a

nothing before God: “it is God who worketh in you both to will and to do of his good pleasure.”

These different statements stand sharply against one another; the one cannot be derived from the other, cannot be limited by the other, cannot be straightforwardly explained by the other; the understanding cannot mediate them, every attempt at mediation has shown itself to be a conceit, a self-delusion.

Religious understanding is therefore in an absolute sense dependent on subjective faith:

As my faith is, so is my interpretation of Scripture, and as my interpretation of Scripture is, so is my faith.

But subjective faith, which in reciprocal relation to the Gospel’s Spirit yields the highest and absolute principle of interpretation, is entirely heterogeneous with “hermeneutics” objective rules.

If the interpreters of Scripture will nevertheless make these heterogeneous factors homogeneous by drawing religious conclusions from scientific premises, or conversely scientific conclusions from religious premises: then it holds in truth, as Christ says, that what is revealed to babes is hidden from the wise and the scribes.

We do not need to go far to find examples; they lie only too near at hand, and are unhappily only too numerous. To name but one example, I will here recall the theologian *De Wette*.

The recently deceased theologian *De Wette* has assuredly distinguished merits both as a critic and as a scientific interpreter of Scripture. I should only dishonor myself if I here allowed myself to dishonor his memory by reckoning him among those who slight Christianity or treat Scripture frivolously. On the contrary! *De Wette* was doubtless, according to the present age’s way of thinking, as serious and upright as he was diligent and gifted an inquirer. But in a religious sense — I say it without reserve — in a religious-ethical sense his concept of revelation is entirely mistaken, and his theological inquiry, in relation to this, built on a misunderstanding.

Or is it not a misunderstanding when *De Wette* will deny the prophets that gift of the Spirit which Christ and the apostles ascribe to them? is it not — in a religious sense — a misunderstanding when he will have the prophetic predictions grounded chiefly on vague wishes and indefinite hopes?^{*)} Or is it not a misunderstanding when *De Wette* allows himself to criticize the prophet Ezekiel as one criticizes a mediocre author in

^{*)}“Weil die Idee in den Propheten durchaus vorherrscht, so sind ihre Vorhersagungen zum Theil nur als Hoffnungen und Wünsche, . . . und sind fast immer unbestimmt und schwebend.” Lehrbuch der historisch-kritischen Einleitung in die Bibel. 1. p. 256.

modern literature? when he, for example, censures this prophet's lack of depth and richness of spirit and of great thoughts? when he laments that Ezekiel's prophetic style is too low and too diffuse and sunk to a flat prose? when he dwells on the fact that the prophet does indeed by allegorical and symbolic inventions wish to raise himself above the ordinary, but usually lapses into the overloaded, the far-fetched, the confused?*) What scientific superiority, what critical self-confidence! Can a theologian then so master a prophet?

It is a sorry misunderstanding, occasioned by the fact that one will relate oneself scientifically-religiously to God's Word, and interpret the inspired authors like other writers of genius. Interpretation transforms itself into criticism: one exalts the one prophet and abases the other. And yet the concept of revelation is supposed to remain inviolate in all this, and the prophets all in a certain manner regarded as inspired. What a contradiction, what uncritical confusion!

If the prophets are not inspired, if hermeneutics and criticism can really vouch to us that the Bible's inspiration really signifies nothing at all: why then do the theologians not say so straight out, and give the freethinkers their due, as free scientific thinkers? But if the Bible is inspired, if the prophets are together inspired by God's Spirit: how then can theological criticism be so uncritical as to apply the same measure to inspired authors as to uninspired ones?

If the prophets are inspired: then the difference that with respect to style and presentation may possibly be found between an Isaiah and an Ezekiel must, in relation to inspiration itself, be an entirely inessential, a vanishing difference.

Theological science, which imagines that it speaks with earnestness and dignity of the beautiful, the lofty, the deep, that is supposedly to be found in the genuine Isaiah in contrast to the prophets of a lower manner of writing, offends Isaiah in a religious sense just as surely by its supposed praise as it offends an Ezekiel or a Daniel by its presumptuous censure.

The prophet does not at all have his quality in style's aesthetic excellences, but the prophet has his quality in this, that he is inspired by the Lord's Spirit. One shall believe the prophet's word and act accordingly; but one shall not reason about his style or at once declare him spurious because one cannot scientifically come to terms with his

*) Was bei ihm (Ezechiel) am meisten auffällt, ist seine levitische Gesinnung, vermöge deren er auf heilige Gebräuche einen hohen Werth legt, und sich selbst in Bildung von Idealen nicht darüber erheben kann. Daher auch sein Mangel an Tiefe und Reichthum des Geistes und an großen Gedanken Die prophetische Rede ist bei ihm zur niedrigen, weitschweifigen, matten Prosa herabgesunken; nur in symbolischen und allegorischen Dichtungen will er sich über das Gemeine erheben, verfällt aber gewöhnlich in das Ueberladene, Gesuchte und Verworrene. Op. cit. pp. 282—83.

manner of writing.

In order finally to remove this theological misunderstanding with the confusion flowing from it, one must in hermeneutics, as in introduction-criticism, sharply separate the scientific conception from the believing appropriation, and therewith also acknowledge that these conceptions are so heterogeneous that no direct transition can be made from the one to the other.

When the interpreter relates himself merely scientifically to the Bible, the Bible is to be treated philologically and historically like any other book of religion from remote antiquity. This scientific relation of the interpreter to the Church's Holy Scripture has been brought out in the most definite terms by L. I. Rückert in the preface to his commentary on Paul's Epistle to the Romans, where it is said among other things: "The interpreter of the New Testament . . . has, as such, no theological system at all and may have none, neither a dogmatic nor a system of feeling; he is, insofar as he is an exegete, neither orthodox nor heterodox, neither supranaturalist nor rationalist, nor pantheist, nor any — ist whatsoever that there might otherwise be; he is neither pious nor ungodly, neither moral nor immoral, neither tender-feeling nor unfeeling; for he has merely the duty of finding out what his author says, in order to hand this over as a pure result to the philosopher, the dogmatician, the moralist, the ascetic, and so on. — So as an exegete he may not have any other interest either than this one, to understand the apostle rightly, to grasp his thoughts purely without foreign admixture, and to lay them before the reader just as pure and unmixed. . . . For him (— the scientific exegete —) it must be a matter of indifference whether Paul speaks truth or falsehood, whether it is a moral or an immoral spirit that runs through his letters, whether his teaching is salutary or fundamentally pernicious; for he (the interpreter) is only to present what he (i.e. the author) says, what spirit pervades him, what doctrine he propounds."

Before Rückert (whose commentary on Romans appeared in Leipzig in 1831) several older hermeneuticians (G. L. Bauer, Bretschneider, Griesbach and others) had already inculcated the scientific freedom from presuppositions that ought to distinguish the unprejudiced interpreter of the Bible. "If one were" — it is said — "to assume the New Testament beforehand to be revelation, and accordingly to accept only that sense as the hermeneutically true one which seems worthy of a revelation, then one would be moving in a circle; — with equal right one would then expound every other document of revelation, such as the Koran or the Zend books, in this way, and could thereby establish its content as logically correct and true." —

Thus the theologians themselves were, in their zeal for an unbiased scientific inter-

pretation of Scripture, well on the way to giving up the theological element in theology. But since theology consists precisely in the contradiction of having to make the heterogeneous homogeneous, since theology cannot give up the religious without giving up its character, it followed of itself that that scientific consistency could not be carried through either.

Instead of holding fast to the principle and letting the scientific clarify itself in science, one of course began again with the usual pieces of reasoning about not going too far, then tried again to cover oneself behind the consideration of faith and to make some concessions to both sides, so that theology might after a fashion preserve a theological coloring.

One can hardly blame theology for not feeling any particular urge to kill itself. If theology cannot subsist except in halfness, inconsistency, and want of principle: what wonder, then, that considered theologians regard consistency as an exaggeration and the unconditional principle as a one-sidedness.

Thus it came about that many respected and pious theologians (among them Storr in Tübingen, Seiler in Erlangen, Stäudlin in Göttingen, Stein and others) in a manner as cautious as it was gentle endeavored to call faith's religious presupposition back to life, and with great circumspection began to mediate between "the historical and the religious interest."

The first scientific attempt to restore the alliance between hermeneutics and the doctrine of faith is however really due to F. Lücke (now professor in Göttingen). As a Privatdozent in Berlin, Lücke published a — as we grant — "in many directions stimulating youthful work (*Grundriß der neutestamentlichen Hermeneutik u. ihrer Geschichte*, 1817)"; a closer development of the concept of theological hermeneutics is found by the same author in "Studien und Kritiken" for the year 1830. The task of biblical hermeneutics is then determined thus: "*to construe the hermeneutic principles in such a way that the peculiarly theological moment can be united with them in a really organic manner, and likewise to form and fix the theological moment in such a way that the general principles of exposition retain their full validity.*"

What misdirection this otherwise well-meant endeavor labors under cannot well be sufficiently set forth in this hour, but will show itself gradually as we advance further in these discourses. Anyone who has any impression of what a scientific principle of interpretation means need only go through the commentaries that are chiefly laid out and executed according to the above principle — I mean the commentaries of Lücke himself, as well as of Tholuck and Olshausen.

There is in these commentaries a double defect, which affects partly the method, partly the principle.

As regards the method, so far is it from being the case that the religious element is here worked together into an “organic” unity with the scientific, that the religious rather has a disturbing effect on the scientific and, conversely, the scientific on the religious.

With all the prolixity of learning that distinguishes these half-edifying commentaries, one soon notices that the philological-historical apparatus takes up such a space that the religious-ethical development does not rightly come through, but must usually be content with some general propositions and interspersed remarks. Sometimes (especially in Olshausen) the reverse relation sets in, namely that the religious explanations and dogmatic excursuses spread out with such fullness that the philological and the historical suffer under it. The fundamental fault is that the heterogeneous tasks neutralize one another, that the conception becomes ambiguous, and the interest doubtful. This shows itself still more clearly when we look to the principle itself.

In the said commentaries the religious and the scientific tasks generally cross one another in such a way that the scientific principle continually weakens the religious. This is seen not only in the treatment of the miracles, where the interpreter must now in so manifold ways come to embarrassment with his half-scientific explanations (into what embarrassment has Olshausen not come, for example, with his interpretations of the healings of the sick in Galilee and his half-modern theory of the demons — an embarrassment from which Strauß has known how to draw the critical advantage); but it holds also of the interpretation of Christ’s words, especially of such as are expressly designed to humble the natural understanding. To recall but a single passage, the hard saying runs (John 6): “Except ye eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, ye have no life in you. Whoso eateth my flesh and drinketh my blood hath eternal life, and I will raise him up at the last day.”

Such passages of Scripture cannot be interpreted scientifically^{*)}; it is entirely impossible. For the scientific view they lose their sting and thereby their force, and transform themselves into merely figurative turns of speech. Instead of impressing on himself the religious character of “the hard saying” and making faith’s task recognizable, the theological interpreter gets into a tangle of contradictory explanations; and when he then feels that with all these explanations he can at bottom explain nothing, he is at last overtaken by the doubt that the Gospel of John may perhaps not even hold up.

In scientific interpretation the scientific relation holds, and therefore the interpreter

^{*)}Cf. *Evangelietroen og den moderne Bevidsthed* pp. 432–36.

ought here also to be consistent enough to relate himself scientifically to his Bible. It is this objectively-scientific relation that has been so clearly and definitely expressed by L. I. Rückert.

In religious-ethical interpretation the religious relation holds, and for that reason the interpreter ought here also to be consistent enough to relate himself religiously and ethically to the inspired Scripture. It is this consistency that I have everywhere had the believer hold fast in “*Evangelietroen og den moderne Bevidsthed*.”

With this the spheres are separated: science and faith have now each its own principle and each moves about its own center.

The eccentric circles can now for the rest touch one another, engage one another, indeed illuminate one another mutually, if only one does not forget that the principles are heterogeneous.

That there is a reciprocal relation between Christian and humane cultivation cannot be denied; but humane cultivation must not therefore be confused with Christian.

Humane cultivation, which grows up out of its own principle without admixture of the Christian, thrives, so to speak, by its own means, and reaches its ideal height in science as science. At this stage we find the learned-scientific interpreter of the Bible.

Christian cultivation will always presuppose the humane to a certain degree; but with this presupposition it develops for the rest out of its own principle, and in such a way that the same human being can stand at a relatively low stage of humane cultivation and yet at a relatively very high stage of Christian cultivation. At this standpoint we place the simple but unlearned interpreter of the Bible.

Finally, humane cultivation may have reached a certain scientific stage in a human being who is so gripped by Christianity that he now reduces this cultivation to a means for a principled and therefore “unscientific” development of the Christian life of faith. At this standpoint we place the simple but nevertheless learned interpreter of the Bible.

Insofar as the learned interpreter explains Holy Scripture religiously, he must essentially explain it in the very same way as the believing layman. But since the learned interpreter of Scripture has learning and scientific cultivation in advance of the layman, this cultivation and learning will enable him to interpret Scripture in such a way that he becomes, in a human sense, a true scribe, a teacher for the simple who have faith but lack learning.

But in a divine sense the interpretation of Scripture is a superhuman gift, and precisely thereby exalted above every human art. In virtue of this its double nature, interpretation strives after a double perfection, a formal and a real one.

As regards interpretation's formal perfection, he will be the best interpreter who has the most cultivation; but as regards the substance of faith-knowledge, he will be the best interpreter whose existence has the greatest inwardness in faith. In the first respect the scribe can instruct the layman; in the last respect the simple layman can just as well instruct the scribe as conversely be instructed by him. The humane element in Christianity is that the one can thus teach the other; but the Christian element, the absolutely divine, is that the one at bottom cannot teach the other at all.

Where, now, does the theologian mean to go with his religious-scientific interpretation? Religious-ethical interpretation of Scripture stands partly outside science, partly above science, but never in science!

If it is now really true that there is not and cannot be any intermediate sphere in which religious-ethical interpretation could be derived from, determined by, or governed by the learned-scientific: then this is a new proof that *Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*

Sixth Lecture

The theological interpreter of Scripture appeals to the Bible's inspiration in the whole, but may on no account acknowledge its inspiration in the particular. Since there is thus doubt about every particular, there must of course also be doubt about the whole: for the theologian the Bible's inspiration is an empty phrase. The evangelical interpreter of Scripture, who in accordance with the law of existence everywhere sees the whole concentrated in the particular, conceives every single passage of Scripture as inspired, under the ecclesial presupposition that the whole Bible is inspired: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

To interpret the Bible, the Church's Holy Scripture, is in other words to find out, fix, and present the essential relation between meaning and expression, spirit and letter (πνεῦμα and γράμμα). Inspiration here shows us its two-sided significance. In the inspired Scripture content and form are inseparably bound together; everything must be understood according to the letter: he who slights the letter offends the spirit. But the servant of the letter, who sees only the letter, offends the spirit too; for the letter killeth, but the spirit giveth life.

The hermeneutic task of determining the relation between spirit and letter has from theology's first beginning occupied the theologians through the Church's many centuries, without one's yet having been able to mediate the opposition that already early gave itself a scientific expression in the dispute between the Alexandrian and the Antiochene schools.

The allegorizing tendency with all the fantasticalities belonging to it has doubtless been more and more forced back by ever-advancing scientific rigor; but grammatical-historical interpretation has nevertheless been just as little able to fathom the spirit as to maintain the letter.

In a certain sense the grammatical interpreter can doubtless maintain the letter, insofar, namely, as he can by the method acknowledged above find out the text's literal meaning; but this literal meaning is then at the same time transformed into a purely

human meaning. "God himself surely did not, after all, think this finite thought, speak these finite words, construct these grammatical sentences!" But what then becomes of the spirit, together with the deeper divine meaning?

This religious question cannot be answered scientifically. For the scientific view the spirit in the individual words and sentences becomes a purely human spirit, the meaning a purely human meaning. The deeper, the superhuman, the divine meaning (insofar as such a thing is assumed at all) is not to be found in any single place. The deeper meaning first comes to view when one puts together a multiplicity of passages of Scripture and subsumes them under the idea's generality — that is, in other words, when one looks to the whole. The particular is human, the whole divine! So it is quite characteristic that theology in recent times has so exceeding a propensity to deify the whole.

If one lays before a theological interpreter of the Bible a definite passage of Holy Scripture, and asks him whether he now also dares to acknowledge this passage as an actually inspired passage, so that these words, these expressions, these sentences are all penetrated by God's Spirit: then he surely comes into great embarrassment. If, on the other hand, one will dispute with him about the passage's relation to the whole writing and the whole writing's relation to Scripture's totality, he shall at once be willing to acknowledge inspiration. Choose the Gospel of Christ's birth, this single definite Gospel as it is found in Luke; then ask the theologian whether in the name of science he dares to acknowledge this evangelical narrative as one inspired by God, as an in every way infallible and trustworthy narrative: he comes into great embarrassment, and attempts to evade the question; but if on the other hand anyone will reason with him about Luke in the whole, about the four Gospels in the whole, about the New Testament, indeed about the whole Bible in the whole: then the theologian shall be willing to defend both inspiration and the deeper meaning and the divine testimony, and his defense shall become the more vigorous the more it is allowed to spread out into the whole.

Only the particular wounds; the whole comes too near to no one. The whole is at a distance, only the particular is present; the whole is in hovering indefiniteness, only the particular is definite and decisive; the whole is for the scientific observer's objective imagination, the particular is for the believer in appropriation's inwardness.

The opposition between the theological and the evangelical interpretation can therefore, with respect to the relation between spirit and letter, be expressed thus:

According to the theological interpretation the particular is posited as a moment in the whole; according to the evangelical interpretation the whole is posited as concentrated in the particular.

To illuminate this opposition more closely I choose a definite example:

When anyone smiteth thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also (Matt. 5:39).

In these words of Christ there is not only unity of spirit and letter, but here there is at the same time difference. One may readily grant the scientific interpreter that this commandment cannot be taken straightforwardly according to the letter without the letter's killing the spirit; but it is then also certain that only religious-ethical interpretation is able to raise itself to the point where the spirit again unites itself with the letter, so that the ideal itself is seen in the literal.

If anyone takes the words straightforwardly according to the letter, and thus understands them spiritlessly, the misunderstanding will easily show itself; one surely needs no scientific guidance to see this. A human being can, when he receives a blow on the right cheek, readily turn the left to it without therefore being a Christian; just as conversely a human being can be a true Christian without therefore turning the left cheek every time he receives a blow on the right. That the believer should now make himself guilty of so spiritless, arbitrary a misunderstanding of the literal expression is by no means to be feared; on the other hand it is in a high degree to be feared that the scientific interpreter, who here comes so easily to a rational separation of spirit and letter, will explain the commandment away for us so spiritually that he entirely effaces Christianity's mark.

With such an explaining-away it goes as of itself. Once one has found out that Christ's commandment cannot be understood literally, what lies nearer than to draw a general morality out of the figurative expression, and to elucidate this general morality by a juxtaposition of several passages of Scripture belonging here. Let the general morality now be that a disciple of Christ shall know how to govern himself, show himself conciliatory and yielding, be willing to be reconciled with his adversary, overcome evil with good, and so on. As the scientific interpreter now expounds this general morality in all generality according to "the analogy of Scripture," it occurs to him that other moralists and wise men of antiquity have put forward similar moral precepts in similar figurative expressions; such classical passages, be they from Confucius or Pythagoras or Xenophon or Plato or Cicero or Horace or Seneca, or whoever it may be, ought then also to be cited. By citing such passages the interpreter not only shows his great reading and his learned survey, but the interpretation at the same time gains in scientific rigor: Christ takes his place in the ranks of the noblest spirits who have lived on earth, and the noblest spirits take their place in turn in the ranks with Christ; so the analogy of faith is widened, and Scripture's divinity is recognized in the whole.

Otherwise, indeed quite otherwise, does it stand with religious-ethical interpretation. The religious man, who in faith's inwardness strives to understand Christ's commandment, does not begin by scattering his attention over a multiplicity of passages of Scripture, does not give himself over to leafing through the Bible in order to entertain himself and others with an interesting comparison of "unfigurative" and "figurative," "prosaic" and "poetic" statements; still less does he lose himself in learned investigations in order to discover what other sages may possibly have said about the same thing; no, the religious man collects his mind and fixes his gaze on the one commandment that here aims precisely at him as a commandment of Christ; the religious man loses himself in the appropriation of the commandment's particularity. When he then reads the commandment and understands that this commandment concerns him himself in particular (as it concerns every disciple of Christ in particular); when he grasps and understands that as Christ's commandment it must be for him an unconditional commandment, a commandment according to which he is to live: then the figurative expression will at once teach him that the commandment has all the Christian marks.

"When anyone smiteth thee on thy right cheek": — yes, what is more natural than that thou, the ill-treated one, shouldst seek to avenge it on thine adversary; what is more natural than that thou, the wronged one, shouldst seek to obtain thy right, indeed shouldst involuntarily be tempted to take the law into thine own hands? — Never is self-love more dangerous than in the moment when it makes itself one with the sense of justice and incites to requital. As self-love now flares up, Christ's commandment comes and would strike it down. The first natural impression that the natural man receives when the commandment so instantly and unconditionally will annihilate the ennobled self-love, justified in the moment of anger, is — the impression of offense.

That one is in general and to a certain degree to deny oneself, that one is in general and to a certain degree to be conciliatory, yielding, and willing to be reconciled with one's adversary, that everyone can understand who has any moral sense: the Israelite can understand it, the noble pagan can understand it! but that such self-denial as Christ's commandment here enjoins should really be meant literally and in earnest — no, that only a believing Christian can understand, when in unconditional obedience he attempts to act accordingly.

The pagan ennobs self-love, but does not deny it (even in Moses it is said: eye for eye, tooth for tooth); only in Christianity is self-love judged, and self-denial posited as the inviolable condition for entering into the kingdom of heaven. This unconditional self-denial cannot be acquired by a merely human resignation. A pagan sage, a Stoic,

will by continued exercise be able to bring it to an astonishing degree of self-mastery; will perhaps be able to bring it to the point where he never acts rashly, is never taken unawares by an outburst of passion; will perhaps win such power over himself that he calmly receives the blow on the right cheek without changing a feature, without even finding it worth the trouble to strike back; but here too is the limit of resignation. If one goes beyond this limit, there shows itself the defiant arrogance, the ice-cold contempt that even condescends to play with injustice; as if the Stoic would not merely endure the blow on the right cheek, but, as proof that he did not regard it, would even as it were mock the mockery, and turn the left cheek to.

Such defiance and contempt, in which self-love secretly triumphs — such defiance and contempt is nevertheless so vastly different from Christian self-denial that a human being had better, in all frailty, requite the unjust blow and afterward repent his rashness than thus deify his own pride and harden himself in an inhuman arrogance.

When, therefore, Christ's commandment presupposes that someone could inflict an injurious wrong on thee, and smite thee on thy right cheek, then the commandment also presupposes that such a blow pains thee, that thou as a human being in flesh and blood bitterly feelest the injury and the mockery, indeed it presupposes at the same time that it even stood in thy power at that same moment to requite the injustice by requiting the blow. When, then, the commandment nevertheless not only forbids thee to strike back when anyone smites thee on thy right cheek, but even expressly commands thee to turn the left cheek to thine adversary: then this commandment is to natural reason an offensive commandment, a commandment of unnatural and inhuman severity.

For the believer, on the other hand, this commandment sounds as a divine commandment of love, a commandment that cannot indeed be fulfilled by the natural man, but is nevertheless to be fulfilled, because its fulfillment not only requires of the human being an unconditional obedience, but at the same time points to a superhuman assistance. Only Christ, who promises such assistance, can in earnest put forward such a commandment; but when the commandment is in spirit and truth conceived as Christ's commandment, the ideal too will be recognized in the literal expression. If Christ would inculcate self-denial in a definite example, where could an example be found more telling than this? How decisive, how unconditional must self-denial not be, when he who receives a blow on the right cheek is at once and as if without deliberation to turn the left cheek to! And what force of inwardness must that human being not possess who is to fulfill this commandment! for everyone who practices self-denial in such a way that the world understands that it is self-denial, and that the self-denial is reasonable,

nevertheless gets the reward that the world acknowledges him for a virtuous man (for so fair-minded is the self-loving world that it is glad to praise self-denial, if only someone else will practice it); but he who without resistance or complaint turns the left cheek to when he has received the blow on the right — what does the world say of him? Of him the world does not say that he is a reasonable and virtuous man; but it says of him that he must either be an intolerable, defiant human being who despises everything, or else a simple fool.

Thus this commandment has all the Christian marks by which it can literally be known that in spirit and truth it must be Christ's commandment. The whole is here concentrated in the particular; the whole of Christian ethics with all the works of love is compressed into the one commandment: *when anyone smiteth thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also*. If anyone will attempt to order his life according to this commandment, then the Gospel promises that God's Spirit will stand by him, and existence help him in principle to discover the whole of Christianity; but he who will not and cannot live accordingly can neither grasp what lies in the commandment; he understands it only in imagination, in possibility (as we at this moment doubtless understand it in imagination and possibility); but in actuality he does not understand it.

That the religious-ethical interpretation of the passage of Scripture here treated is entirely heterogeneous with the scientific can now easily be proved.

Insofar as the author relates himself scientifically to his text, and refers the significance of each individual passage of Scripture to the general categories of the totality, he cannot even in representation get so far as to touch existence; for existential thinking distinguishes itself from the scientific precisely in this, that at every point it touches particularity, the individual human being, the individual commandment, the individual relations and conditions under which the commandment finds its application, and so on. But even if one would reckon among the scientific that interpretation which converts the essential content into nothing but existential determinations, and assert that the sample we have here given of a religious-ethical exegesis could at bottom just as well be called scientific as the philological-historical: then this is a pure misunderstanding.

It is indeed true that religious-ethical interpretation, insofar as it is communicated in a lecturing discourse, has a certain likeness to the scientific — namely this, that it is lectured. But insofar as religious-ethical interpretation is lectured, it points at every point beyond itself, declares itself insufficient, and abolishes itself. The existence with which the lecturing discourse deals is namely no actual, but only an imagined existence. Therefore one cannot conclude either that someone is really religious because he has a certain

facility in putting forward religious-ethical explanations. In the form of a discourse the religious-ethical explanation is therefore still only an imagined explanation, an explanation that differs from the scientific merely in this, that it turns toward existence, requires existence, and makes the existential tasks recognizable.

Religious-ethical interpretation has its truth solely in actual existence; only in actual existence is it in earnest heterogeneous with the scientific.

In actual existence the believer who interprets his Bible is no imagined figure, but an actual human being, and the understanding of Scripture's word no imagined but an actual understanding. Actual understanding is only in actual application; the circumstances of life and the cases in which Christ's commandments find their application are then not imagined either, but actual; but the actual case is each time an individual, definite case.

If we now hold fast to this point of view, it follows that religious-ethical interpretation is not only different from the scientific, but at the same time so heterogeneous with it that it is even, in the strictest sense, impossible for the one human being to interpret the Bible for the other, since it is impossible for the one human being to put himself entirely into the other human being's existence. How far the believer in actuality understands and appropriates Christ's commandment: "when anyone smiteth thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the *other also*," depends solely and alone on how he lives, and this everyone must know within himself: the relation to God is a relation of conscience.

The self-denial that the commandment enjoins is unconditional; but every human being's life is subject to finitude's conditions. It is not granted to the human being to carry the unconditional through in every moment, and yet it demands itself of him in every moment. The unconditional can besides work in manifold ways in the different conditions. A human being can in countless ways exercise himself in religious self-denial, can in countless ways display this self-denial, sometimes even in such a way that the most inward self-denial shows itself outwardly as presumptuous self-will. Under such conditions it is entirely impossible for the one human being to advise the other: everyone must in faith advise himself. When this turning point sets in (and it sets in every time existence presses in with real earnestness), all mutual instruction falls silent; everyone grasps in his own bosom — after the understanding, everyone encloses the commandment within his own inner being, and shuts himself in, so to speak, together with the commandment, in order on his own responsibility to understand how this commandment in this given case can and ought to be applied.

As the earnestness of existence thus halts mutual instruction, admonition, and guidance, and separates human beings, so that everyone in the hour of decision must advise

himself, the meaning can nevertheless not possibly be that obstinate, arbitrary self-will should draw new advantage from this. On the contrary, so far is it from being the case that the individual is here referred to arbitrary self-will, that he now first fully understands how greatly he needs counsel, how impossible it is for him to advise himself. To natural self-feeling the human being cannot entrust himself, for self-feeling is in collusion with self-love; but here it is a question of self-denial. Reflecting understanding cannot solve the task for him either; for partly the understanding is bribed by self-love, partly it becomes entangled and caught in its own reflection. Instead of solving the task, reflection will only make it far harder still, by making it dialectical. On the one side an absolute self-denial is required, an unconditional self-sacrifice; on the other side it is required that the human being shall recognize his limit. A human being must after all always yield something to the outward circumstances at hand; one cannot, as it were, burst all existence's conditions at a single wrench in order to grasp the unconditional. For reflection the commandment comes apart, and divides into two mutually contradictory commandments: grasp the unconditional! and: recognize thy limit! This contradiction cannot be mediated by continued reflection: the longer one reflects, the greater the difficulty becomes; besides, in the moment of decision there is no time to reflect, for the moment is precious: what matters is to resolve and to act.

If the human being is now thus referred to himself without nevertheless being able to advise himself, then there would be no counsel for him at all if God's Spirit did not bear witness with his spirit in conscience, and prompt him as to what he should do in the decisive moment. So says the Gospel: the Spirit that teaches the human being the right choice in the hour of decision; the Spirit that determines self-denial in relation both to the outward conditions and to the abilities and cultivation of the human being concerned; the counseling and governing Spirit that lifts the human being above himself in the moment of self-denial; the Spirit of power that makes the wronged one become stronger than his adversary in that he — wondrously enough! — becomes stronger than himself; the Spirit that makes it possible for him who receives the blow on the right cheek to turn the left cheek to in the superiority of meekness and humility: could this Spirit well be any other than God's own Holy Spirit?

What in science is without significance and in theology an empty-solemn turn of phrase — *namely, that the Holy Spirit is the only right interpreter of Holy Scripture* — becomes an actual truth in the believer's existence; for the Holy Spirit is a Spirit of existence.

In actual existence the Spirit will always answer to faith, as faith to the Spirit. Dare to

believe, and thou shalt receive the Spirit's power to grasp the unconditional; dare to deny thyself, and thou shalt not only receive power to break with the considerations of worldly prudence, but also patience and wisdom to understand the conditions of finitude and frailty, for the Spirit of power is at the same time the Spirit of counsel and wisdom. This is the law, the revealed law of God, by which every human existence has to order itself: that he who has a strong faith receives a strong spirit, and understands Scripture's word in spirit and truth; but he who has only a weak faith receives a weak spirit, and understands the Word as through a shadow. This is the law, the inviolable law of the interpretation of Scripture: everyone who hears the Word and acts accordingly experiences the Word's power and is to be likened to a wise man who builds his house upon the rock; but if anyone hears the Word and does not act accordingly, then he can never recognize the Word's power either, but deceives himself by an imagined understanding and is to be likened to the foolish man who builds his house upon the sand.

The theologians' opinion that the Holy Spirit will surely engage with their learned researches and at length come to their aid with a true scientific interpretation of Scripture is grounded neither in science's nor in revelation's essence, but is, plainly said, neither more nor less than a theoretical confusion of heterogeneous tasks. This confusion expresses itself every time one looks at the particular; for the theologian, as theologian, never has the Holy Spirit in the particular, but always in the whole, never in actuality, but always in possibility, never in existence, but always in imagination.

But the Spirit that is thus in the whole without coming to view in the particular is a nebulous and hovering Spirit, a Spirit that assuredly offends no human being, but assuredly saves no human being either, a Spirit that founds turns of phrase as a poet founds imaginings.

Theological science's scientific defenders will without doubt find this assertion somewhat personal; to this I answer that the assertion is personal only because it is true, and I shall prove to superfluity what I say.

It is well known that not only the orthodox theologian, but also the rationalist, not only the speculative but also the unspeculative rationalist appeals, in interpreting Holy Scripture, to the Spirit's testimony in the whole (*testimonium spiritus sancti theoreticum*). From this one can now draw two conclusions: either the Holy Spirit, which thus gives its testimony in all these interpretations, is itself both orthodox, heterodox, speculative, unspeculative, and so on; or else the Holy Spirit's testimony must be exalted above these finite schools' finite oppositions. But whichever of these assumptions one prefers, the prevailing theology must perish. In the first case the theologians' Holy Spirit is a

self-contradictory and self-conflicting Spirit; but a science whose spirit is in essential conflict with itself cannot possibly subsist. In the last case the Spirit to whose testimony the theologians appeal is a supra-scientific Spirit, a Spirit in whose essence theology itself therefore has no share, since theology is and will be science.

As regards religious-ethical interpretation of the Bible, it is by no means “the theologians” that we need; but insofar as a human guidance in this direction is possible at all, an existential author is doubtless the guide we could greatly need, if only our theoretical conceits did not prevent us from understanding the guidance.

By an existential author I mean such a one as not only has a quite peculiar gift for exhibiting existence’s categories and the corresponding tasks in all possible relations, but an author who at the same time has the self-denial to be willing to sacrifice a life’s powers on working out these tasks; an author who in the earnestness of jest is not even afraid to work against himself, in order the more honestly to serve his idea; an author who, when it must be so, would rather bear the misinterpretations of the day than give up the understanding with an eternal truth; a poet in the immediate enamorment with which he looks upon the ideal; an ethicist in the strict understanding that it is precisely his own existence that the ideal will require; a religious individuality in the humbling recognition that he nevertheless cannot — what every human being ought to be able to do!

Thus, roughly thus, do I picture to myself the authorial existence that would surely be most nearly equipped to wage war against the present age’s “delusions of sense,” and to make Christianity recognizable to modern reflection.

That the theologians — I mean the genuinely scientific ones, especially the genuinely speculative-scientific ones — would of course prefer to overlook such an authorial existence, or, if the phenomenon in literature were now so striking that it could no longer, at least for conversation’s sake, be overlooked, would then interpret it as — an “unscientific” one-sidedness! — a “remarkable” one-sidedness! — a “brilliant” one-sidedness! — an “ecstatic” one-sidedness! is after all easy enough to understand — in conversation. This many-sided interpretation proves precisely that the theologians must have their own many-sided hermeneutics.

Let everyone then interpret it according to his hermeneutics as he will: I interpret it thus, *that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*

Seventh Lecture

In the treatment of sacred history — “the Life of Jesus” — the theologian will work against the freethinker; but the scientific criticism on which he proceeds shows plainly enough that in principle he is at one with the freethinker. The believer, who in his conception of the Gospels’ Christ holds exclusively to religious-ethical criticism, is in principle at one with the evangelists: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

As is well known, Germany’s theologians are at present eagerly occupied with their critical-scientific treatments of the life of Jesus (Das Leben Jesu). “The critical introduction” has to that end called up theology’s various powers — hermeneutics and dogmatics and ethics and apologetics, together with polemics and irenics — to work with united forces, so that one might thus with united forces work toward the common goal, the solution of the great task. The plan has accordingly been set in motion; but, it cannot be denied, the undertaking has hitherto had quite a peculiar fate.

The modern idea of a “life of Jesus,” which was conceived and born of a famous theologian, had namely the remarkable fate that immediately after its birth it was adopted by an acute philosopher, so that it might be all the better reared and formed in the spirit of modern science itself. It was the critic David Strauß who fetched the idea from Schleiermacher’s lectern, sent it to school with Hegel, and thereafter let it appear in his celebrated work “Das Leben Jesu” — to the terror and offense of theologians of every color. Never has theology suffered a more complete defeat, and never has negative criticism won a more complete victory, than precisely in this scientific collision. Many theological writings have gone forth, many theological plans of attack been attempted, much theological ink spilled for the scientific refutation of the great freethinker: — all in vain!

Doubtless Strauß has in several respects been corrected by his many opponents; among others the theologian J. H. A. Ebrard has in his “Wissenschaftliche Kritik der evangelischen Geschichte” (part 2) successfully pointed out a number of arbitrarinesses in “the destructive method”; but all this is of no help so long as the foundation on which

the Straussian criticism rests has not itself been destroyed. The point is that Strauß does after all have a principle, whereas theology is and remains without principle.

The Straussian principle is namely nothing other than the modern consciousness's own generally acknowledged fundamental principle: the principle of positing the idea of reason as the absolute, deifying the laws of nature, and raising science to religion. However many small alterations religious feeling and subjective humanity may otherwise make in this fundamental principle, it is nevertheless seen through all modifications and interpretations to be the very same.

The Straussian endeavor to raise science to religion cannot possibly be heterogeneous with the theological endeavor to raise religion to science; for both endeavors proceed from the presupposition that religion and science are homogeneous. But when the theologians in so essential a sense stand at the very same standpoint as Strauß, how then should the theologians be able to refute Strauß?

We see it plainly in Ebrard's relation to Strauß. Strauß proceeds from the presupposition that every belief in miracles is superstition, and then proves from this that all the miracle stories are myths, in the New Testament just as much as in the Old; Ebrard proceeds from the presupposition that God can work miracles, and then proves from this that the miracle narratives in the four Gospels are trustworthy; Strauß is a naturalist, Ebrard a supranaturalist; Strauß is unbelieving, Ebrard believing; Strauß tears down, Ebrard builds up: to that extent Ebrard doubtless stands at quite another standpoint than Strauß. But if we look more closely, it will soon show itself that the opposition is not after all so great as it seems at first glance, but that it can, as mediation says, quite well be abolished in a higher unity.

Despite all the disagreement that otherwise prevails between the two opponents, they are nevertheless both agreed on a very important and essential point; they are namely both agreed that in treating "das Leben Jesu" one must of course stand at science's standpoint. This presupposition the theologian shares with the freethinker, and with this presupposition the freethinker crushes the theologian.

A supranaturalist at science's standpoint is a contradiction; a scientific critic at the standpoint of belief in miracles is a contradiction; if Christianity is to be explained in science, then it is already explained, then it is already settled what it is: it is a mythology; if sacred history is to be criticized by science, then it is already criticized, it is already settled what it is: it is a chain of myths, one great myth.

"The divine" — says Strauß — "cannot have happened in this way; what happened in this way cannot have been divine — thus will the difference express itself, and when

interpretation strives to settle it, it will strive either to present the divine as not having happened in this way, thus denying the old sources their historical validity, or to show that what happened is not divine in this way, thus explaining away the absolute content of these books. In both cases the explanation can go to work partially or impartially; partially, when it is blind to the consciousness of the difference between the new cultivation and the old sources, and only imagines itself to be finding out the latter's original meaning; impartially, when it clearly recognizes and openly confesses that it sees what those old writers relate otherwise than they themselves have regarded it."

"The ancient, especially Oriental, world" — it is said further — "was, in consequence of its preponderantly religious tendency and its slight knowledge of the laws of nature, of the connection in earthly, finite being, something so loose that it was able to leap from any point in it over into the infinite, and at every single alteration in nature and the human world to regard God as the immediate cause. From this standpoint of consciousness biblical history too is written But the more recent age has a series of the most laborious researches, continued through centuries, to thank for the insight that everything in the world hangs together by a chain of causes and effects that tolerates no interruption This conviction has so become the consciousness of the more recent world that the opinion or assertion that a supernatural cause, a divine influence, has somewhere intervened immediately is in actual life regarded straightforwardly either as ignorance or as deception; and it has advanced to an extreme in the more recent Enlightenment's view, which, directly opposed to the biblical one, either removes divine causality entirely, or at any rate pushes it so far back that only in the act of creation would it be an immediate one — that is to say, that God would work upon the world only insofar as at the creation he gave it a definite arrangement. From this standpoint, which sees in nature and history a fixed web of finite causes and effects, the biblical narratives, in which this web is at countless places torn apart by an intervention of divine causality, cannot possibly show themselves as history."

One sees from this how insignificant it is to want to refute Strauß in the particular and to try one's hand at scientific counter-proofs against his destructive criticism. If in profane history it is already far easier for criticism to tear down than to build up, how meaningless then does the scientific attempt become of trying by critical proofs of probability to maintain the miracles in sacred history. Ebrard's theological venture has accordingly not been able to win the theologians' approval either. Let one read, for example, Bleek's review of Ebrard's writings, and one will get a very disheartening impression. The as acute as he is profoundly learned Bleek goes through Ebrard's assertions, and winces at

every step, like one walking on needles. “Hardly credible! — Improbable! — Unprovable! — Highly improbable!” are the exclamations that escape the otherwise so well-disposed reviewer at every moment. Meanwhile the reviewer Bleek is caught in exactly the same misunderstanding as the author Ebrard. The misunderstanding is that one will judge the miracles scientifically, and apply the measure of probability to that which by its nature is and must be the improbable.

The dispute with Strauß transforms itself on the instant into a dispute between religion and science. It is the critic’s merit to have given the matter so strong a push that it has precisely thereby been driven to this decisive turning point. The dispute of the faith of the Gospel with the Straussian criticism is a dispute of competence, a dispute of sovereignty, a dispute about the supreme power, the highest authority in the world of spirits.

If science is the highest instance, then Strauß is in principle right, then it is, frankly spoken and plainly said, all over with Christianity, then religion lies at its last extremity and awaits only a gentle dissolution — in humane culture.

If, on the other hand, Christianity is higher than science, if it has its own supernatural principle and moves in a sphere into whose depths no human knowledge penetrates, then it will also still, as before, rule with a sovereign’s authority in its own kingdom, and make every human being answerable for how he understands its authorization and its relation to science.

Science, as science, cannot possibly arrogate to itself the supreme authority. Insofar as science knows what it knows, it knows at the same time that there is something it does not yet know, and something it will never come to know in this existence. Science knows within itself that it exercises a magnificent and beneficent influence on humanity in leading the generations forward from enlightenment to enlightenment; but it also knows that it has, and can have, only a very mediate influence on actual human beings’ actual existence. Science knows within itself that the great events in world history — the oppression of peoples, the victories of revolutions, the wars of nations — are not settled by pure grounds of reason. Science knows within itself that there are powers, dark, terrifying powers in existence that never bow their necks under its dominion; science knows that the new thoughts, the new ideas, the new means that it offers the human race at every step must serve the evil as well as the good, the unjust as well as the just. Science knows within itself that the knowledge of truth that it bears and upholds in continually advancing development never reaches and never can reach so far as to answer for us the highest questions, the most important of all for human existence: is

there a God? is there an eternal life?

By no means do I assert that science, as science, straightforwardly leads to a denial of the ground of things or to a denial of eternal life. Far from it! Philosophy cannot live without the idea: when it misconstrues the idea, it misconstrues itself; when it dissolves and denies the idea, it dissolves and denies itself. For philosophy the idea is as God, God as idea: *the idea is divine*; for philosophy the eternal is as idea, the idea as the eternal: *the idea's life is an eternal life*. Higher than to this explanation philosophy has hitherto not come, and can never come either.

Philosophy's idea can now in manifold ways be developed, articulated, and formed in the dialectical formations of conceptual systems: otherwise by the one philosopher than by the other, otherwise by an Aristotle than by a Plato, otherwise by a Schelling than by a Hegel. Under these systematic formations idea-knowledge doubtless makes essential progress, insofar as the idea itself clarifies itself along with the clarified concept. But the idea's fundamental essence is and nevertheless remains through all the systems the one and the very same fundamental essence, just as philosophy too in all philosophies is and remains the one and the same philosophy. Plato's and Aristotle's God is also Schelling's and Hegel's God, that is: the absolute idea.

The great advances that philosophy in recent times is supposed to have made with Christianity's assistance are illusory. What philosophy has borrowed from Christianity it must give back again; this loan can never become its property: Christianity is heterogeneous with philosophy. Study the Hegelian philosophy, go through this great, rigorous, imposing conceptual system point by point from the beginning to the end; then put to yourself the question what philosophy has here at last fathomed about God's existence and the soul's immortality; hold fast to the concept, let yourself not be beguiled by the objective imaginative luster of the idea: you shall assuredly see that the Hegelian God with all his logical trinitarian movements is still the old Aristotelian world-God (*τὸ πρῶτον κινῶν, οὐ κινούμενον*), that first mover who is not moved, i.e. the absolute idea; indeed you shall see that Hegel, still in the nineteenth century after Christ, has not come a hair's breadth further with the immortality of souls than Plato already was in the fourth century before Christ.

The foundation on which philosophy erects its systems is the idea's foundation; but this foundation is ambiguous, like the idea itself. What, pray, is the philosophical idea? An amphibolous being! a being that does not itself know whence it comes and whither it will; a being that now points out beyond itself upward toward the personal God and the kingdom beyond, but now again denies the beyond, mocks the personal God, and

declares itself the divinity of the actual world.

The ambiguity rests on the fact that the idea looks otherwise to so-called pure thinking in relation to essence and possibility than it does to immediate experience in relation to existence and actuality.

Metaphysical thinking does not come to rest until it comes to rest in God as the wisdom that thinks itself and all things, wills itself and all things, explains itself and all things, of whom, through whom, and unto whom are all things: philosophy to that extent finds it both thinkable and possible that the absolute Spirit is a Spirit free and self-conscious in itself. Likewise the philosophical development of the idea can be laid out in so subjective a direction that the human I recognizes therein its inner infinity, its original power to conquer the barriers of existence, indeed of death, and to raise itself by the moral world-order to eternal freedom in ever-increasing perfection.

But what philosophy thus promises us in relation to essence and possibility, it recalls again when the idea is considered and tested in relation to existence and actuality. The philosophical idea cannot free itself from matter's barriers, and therefore cannot raise itself above this finite world either. The idea is in the existing things, as the things are in the idea. The idea has no independent existence: its reason is nature's reason, its powers the world's powers; it ferments in the ground of the elements, it awakens to life in the animal, to light and freedom in the human being. Individuals must die, the human being as well as the animal; only the idea lives in all generations: the idea splits apart in actual existence; for actual existence there is therefore no personal God and no personal immortality.

From this it must surely be possible to discern how the religious man who will support his faith on philosophy and science is deceived. A personal God, such as the one religion proclaims, is to science an offense; a personal immortality, such as the one Christianity promises, is to philosophy an offense! Science holds, as regards actuality, to the present, the natural; but religion points to the beyond, the supernatural.

The dispute between the believer and the freethinker can then be more closely determined thus: the freethinker is right in the assertion that religion and science do not suit one another; but on the other hand he is greatly wrong when he draws from this the conclusion that science can abolish religion. The possibility of a revelation science cannot deny; the actuality of a revelation science cannot confirm; the truth of a revelation science cannot test.

It has been supposed that such a separation of religion and science as the one I here set forth would occasion great confusion, since one would then have to believe blindly,

and might just as well take it into one's head to believe the false revelation as the true. Nothing but evasions! Let one only be so good as to reflect a little seriously on the difference between subjective knowledge and objective knowing.

It has been supposed that he who accepted a revelation without first testing its objective truth in objective knowing neglected a duty toward truth, for which ethics ought to call him to account. A poor argument, seeing that ethical truth cannot even itself be tested in objective knowing.

To want to convince oneself beforehand of a scientific truth — for example a mathematical or a logical one — before one accepts and applies it, is in order; but to want to be convinced beforehand of an ethical truth before one accepts and applies it is nonsense, since ethical truth refers to resolution and action. Pure scientific truth can be established by pure scientific thinking: I need do nothing whatever but think in order to get the truth proved. In ethical truth, on the other hand, the deed is itself a part of the proof, indeed the proof itself; but when the deed is itself a part of the proof, indeed the proof itself, then it is surely a pure folly to want to have the complete proof in advance of the deed.

Even if in deep scientific earnestness one has long since forgotten the man who would not go into the water before he had learned to swim, one ought nevertheless not to sink so deep into the depths of theological knowing that one entirely forgets what the warrior sings in "Wallensteins Lager":

Und setzet Ihr nicht das Leben ein,
Nie wird euch das Leben gewonnen seyn.

If Christianity is higher than science, then it surely follows of itself that evangelical history must also be higher than scientific criticism. If Christianity is only for the believer, then sacred history too is only for the believer; from which it follows in turn that the freethinker can as little refute the believer as the believer can refute the freethinker.

In imagination and possibility they may well understand one another, enter into one another's train of thought, and to that extent negotiate and dispute with one another; but in actuality the one cannot by any objective proof overcome the other or draw the other over to himself; each of them has his own existential footing: it is hard existence that sets them apart. The freethinker exists in unbelief; his conception of the life of Jesus is entirely consistent under the presupposition that science is higher than religion; the religious man exists in faith; his conception of the life of Jesus is entirely consistent under the presupposition that religion is higher than science. Between the two now stands the theologian — or rather, he does not stand at all; he at least does not stand firm (for he

has no existential footing), but sways and limps to both sides, now toward faith and now toward science. The theologian's conception of the life of Jesus is a conception without principle, in nothing but halfness and inconsistency; this halfness and inconsistency I call mediocrity.

A presentation of the life of Jesus can now be laid out in such a way that the freethinker with his "riper consciousness," the religious man with his "faith of the Gospel," and the theologian with his "mediocrity" join in going through the evangelical history and each expressing himself in his own spirit on each of the Gospels. Such a presentation is then to be characterized as an existential presentation, insofar, namely, as it aims not at a scientific juxtaposition of different theories, but at a living, passionate strife between different characters.

The existential presentation of the life of Jesus must in the strictest sense of the word be critical; but the criticism that here comes into application is, be it noted, not a scientific but an existential criticism. Criticism comes, after all, from crisis, and surely no one will deny that existence has its crises. The spirit that sets the strongest oppositions in motion is then also the highest spirit, a spirit that effects the deepest crises. When, then, a human being comes forward and proclaims himself God's only-begotten Son: what crises must such a one not call forth!

Thus Christ comes forward: a human being in outward lowliness, and yet a human being with divine authority; a human being who makes the seeing blind, and yet a human being who makes the blind see; a human being who in this world has not that whereon he may lay his head, and yet a human being who says to the dead: arise! and to the palsied: thy sins are forgiven thee! Who, then, is this human being? — The revealed God? The manifest deceiver? Here the crisis begins.

Evangelical history bears existential criticism in itself: it shows us Christ in relation both to the non-believing and to the believing.^{*)} The non-believing see him at once as a deceiver; the believing see him as God's Son; the great crowd changes its mind. These crises and this criticism accompany Christ uninterruptedly through his whole public life, from Galilee to Judea, from Jerusalem to Nazareth, from Capernaum to Golgotha. It was men of Galilee who became his first disciples and believed him on his word, that from now on they should see heaven open and God's angels ascending and descending upon the Son of Man; it was men of Galilee who in Nazareth's synagogue were offended at him, and thrust him out of the city to cast him down from the brow of the hill. It was Pharisees and scribes who hated him as a fanatic and a seducer of the people; it

^{*)}Cf. *Evangeltr. og den mod. Bevidsthed*, pp. 210–227.

was a Pharisee and scribe who came to him in the stillness of night as to a teacher of Israel. It was a robber on the cross who reviled him, and it was a robber on the cross who confessed him. It was a Roman who condemned him in Jerusalem when the Jews raged: Crucify, crucify! and it was a Roman who acquitted him on Golgotha, when the graves burst and the earth quaked.

The relation in which Christ by his first appearance places himself to his contemporaries is at the same time determined as the fundamental relation of principle in which he places himself to the whole human race through all times. On the one side there follow him the offended, who now would stone him, now thrust him down, and always mock him, because his word is to them a hard saying which no one can hear. On the other side there follow him the believing, who confess his name and cannot leave him, because in the confusion of the times they know no other way out than Peter, when he said: *Lord, to whom shall we go? Thou hast the words of eternal life.* About these characters moves the crowd, the surging crowd that comes and goes; the dependent crowd that is now stirred to awakening, now incited to offense; the restless crowd that cries and cries, today: Hosanna! tomorrow: Crucify!

Here we have, as in a silhouette, the original presuppositions and conditions on which the existential criticism of the faith of the Gospel must further be laid out. And now the world may go as far as it will, and become as old and as enlightened and as clever and as scientific as it will: it will nevertheless never get beyond these crises, it will never get beyond this criticism.

The existential presentation of the life of Jesus ought, according to the evangelists' direction, surely also to be pragmatic. But the pragmatism here in question is not the scientific one. In scientific pragmatism the particular is constantly posited as a fleeting moment in the whole. Hereby finitude's schema acquires so decisive a preponderance that the spirit disappears. So the whole is parceled out according to the various journeys and the various feasts; so the theologians cannot agree about the chronology; so one contends about the Synoptics, so one wrangles about the Sermon on the Mount, so one reasons about "the Easter reckoning"; so learned science has forgotten faith, and moves in nothing but finitude.

In evangelical pragmatism, on the other hand, the whole is posited as concentrated in the particular. In each single redeeming deed the whole Redeemer himself is present, in each single Gospel the whole evangelical history. Finite temporal sequence is hereby reduced to a vanishing moment in the grouping of the central events. The supernatural phenomena and extraordinary deeds in the life of Jesus follow one another so suddenly,

so surprisingly, and burst the ordinary connection of the temporal so entirely, that a finite pragmatism becomes impossible. No disciple could relate himself objectively to these events,^{*)} no spectator could pettily record every single trait, no apostle could, so to speak, keep a diary of Jesus' deeds (cf. John 20:30–31; 21:25).

The existential presentation of the life of Jesus can doubtless not be philosophical, but must nevertheless be laid out in such a way that the evangelical history is seen in the ideal's light, as an eternal and sacred history exalted above past and present.

The presentation of sacred history has then the peculiar determination of casting light over the world's history and making the ideals recognizable, so that everyone must judge himself when he judges of the revealed ideal that reveals the thoughts of hearts.

If there is no blessed life, then it is doubtless greater to take the city than merely to rule over one's own mind, and then Christ too is an offense; but if there is a blessed life: yes, then he who rules over his own mind is greater than he who takes the city, and then Christ is the Savior of the world. If there is in faith no eternal life, then the individual must seek his ideal in worldly society, and worldly society its ideal in the history of the race. The spirit of history then reveals the very highest ideal of kingdom and power and glory when the city is taken, when the heroic genius says *jacta alea esto* and crosses the Rubicon with his legions. But if there is in faith an eternal life; if the individual must buy it with self-denial, preserve it in patience, and consummate it in self-sacrificing love: then he who is crowned with thorns is surely also higher than he who is crowned with laurel; then the ideal's way does not go over the Rubicon to the Capitol either, but the way goes over the brook Kedron to the garden of Gethsemane; and then the highest watchword of resolution is not a *jacta alea esto* either, but the highest watchword is in the words of the prayer: Father, not my will, but thine!

^{*)}“To become a historical eyewitness is thus easy for the contemporary learner; the misfortune, however, is that to know a historical circumstance, indeed to know them all with the eyewitness's reliability, by no means makes the eyewitness a disciple — as one can see from the fact that this knowledge means for him nothing but the historical. It shows itself at once here that the historical in the more concrete sense is a matter of indifference; we can let ignorance enter in relation to it, and let ignorance as it were annihilate the historical; if only the moment still remains, as the point of departure for the eternal, the paradox is present. If there were a contemporary who had himself restricted his sleep to the shortest time in order to follow that teacher, whom he followed more inseparably than the little fish that follows the shark; if he kept a hundred spies in his service who everywhere spied out that teacher, and with whom he himself conferred every evening, so that he knew that teacher's description down to the least detail, knew what he had said, where he had been at every hour of the day, because his zeal let him regard even the most insignificant thing as important — was such a contemporary the disciple? By no means. He could wash his hands if anyone would charge him with historical unreliability, but no more than that either. If there were a contemporary who had stayed in foreign lands and first returned home when that teacher had only a day or two of his life remaining; if the contemporary were again kept by business from getting to see that teacher, and came only at the last, when he was about to give up the ghost — was this historical ignorance a hindrance to his being the disciple, if the moment was for him eternity's decision?” Johannes Climacus. *Philosophiske Smuler*, pp. 85–86.

Let everyone judge of this as he will: he judges himself. But this stands fast: if there is a blessed life, then Christ is the Savior of the world; if Christ is the Savior of the world, then Christianity is higher than science; but if Christianity is higher than science, then *the faith of the Gospel is indeed also — heterogeneous with theology.*

Eighth Lecture

The half-philosophical image of Christ that the speculating dogmatician conjures up consists in a mystical fusion of the scientific and the religious, and is on that account so infinitely different from the evangelists' Christ that it falls even outside the religious-ethical horizon: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Although the theologians of course cannot accept what, in relation to the present age's enlightenment, they must call "the crude principle of inspiration," and are on that account in much doubt about the particulars of evangelical history and the genuineness of the four Gospels: they nevertheless console themselves that pious contemplation still rediscovers in each of the evangelists the same historical main features, the same fundamental religious view, the same image of Christ. The theological voice is never more moved and full-toned than precisely when the talk is of the leading thought, of the fundamental view, of the image of Christ. Even when one comes into embarrassment with all the particulars, one can still cheerfully hold to the fundamental view; even when science has transformed the evangelists' Christ into a half-philosophical fancy, one still always sees an image of Christ. — While the criticizing interpreter is chiefly interested in the historical particulars in the life of Jesus, the speculating dogmatician is particularly interested in the idea, in the fundamental view, in the image of Christ.

In the idea and the fundamental view the theologian now supposes he reconciles Christianity with science, in that out of Christianity's own content he develops a speculative knowledge, a knowledge that in all essential points is supposed to satisfy faith.

In order to discover the error on which this attempt at mediation, of great antiquity in the Church, rests, we will here dwell a little more closely on the often-touched opposition between scientific and existential knowledge.

In scientific knowledge the knower's particular mood and subjective state signify nothing; in existential knowledge everything depends on the knowing subject's peculiar state and mood. In scientific knowledge the knower must abstract from himself, forget himself, give himself over to contemplation's calm, and relate himself generally to the

general object. In existential knowledge the knowing subject must go into himself, place himself in a decisive relation to the object — for which reason everyone in this personal relation of subjectivity, inwardness, and interestedness rightly calls the object his object. Scientific knowledge, which moves in the general, is passionless, and ought to be so, since it is impersonal; existential knowledge, which moves about the punctual, the particular, the proper, is passionate, and must be so in the same degree in which it is personal.

From this it follows that the knowledge won in science has a direct significance only for science, and must change its character when it is applied to existence; and conversely, that the knowledge attained by existence's way has a direct significance only for existence itself, and must change its character when it is translated into science. Since now these two kinds of knowledge are in this way so heterogeneous that they cannot be exchanged for one another, it follows in turn that they can neither relate themselves directly to one another nor be directly corrected by one another. Scientific knowledge cannot be directly corrected by existence, any more than the existential by science.

What has here been said has (as Aristotle already points out) a great significance for rational ethics, but acquires a still higher and quite differently decisive significance for that peculiar sphere which in a stricter sense we must call the sphere of the faith of the Gospel. As regards the knowledge of Christianity, we must in the most definite terms hold fast to the rule that science cannot be corrected by faith, any more than faith can be corrected by science.

If we now apply this rule to our present theme, then the error in the attempt at mediation spoken of will without doubt also come to light.

In order to work out the christological idea and construe the so-called image of Christ, the speculating dogmatician goes to work in the following way. The christological main propositions on which the dogmatic development of the idea is to be grounded he does not borrow from any philosophy standing outside the Church; he fetches them all from Scripture and the Church's doctrine. Since now every main proposition must to that extent be said to be a proposition of faith, the dogmatician supposes that he thereby satisfies faith, builds on faith's ground, knows in faith and out of faith. But what knowledge is it, then, that he here strives after? Well, it is to be a scientific and, so far as possible, even a speculative, at least a half-speculative knowledge. Now the error begins. The ecclesial propositions of faith are converted into the form of objective knowing, and treated as general scientific propositions; as these scientific propositions are worked together into a scientific totality, the christological idea is then worked out, and the image of Christ shows itself.

That such a christology by no means reconciles faith with knowledge, but rather shows itself as an ambiguous fusion of heterogeneous constituents, a fusion that conflicts in equal degree with the nature of faith and of knowing, can be proved without difficulty.

As regards the dogmatician's half-speculative christology, it must at once awaken misgiving that it lays claim to a double acknowledgment, in that it will both be acknowledged as a product of faith and yet at the same time be acknowledged as a product of science; it is like an offspring that has faith for mother and science for father, and now with this its double nature makes a double claim, one on the mother's and one on the father's behalf. With this double claim one would now also expect that the christological idea was willing to submit to a double testing, namely a testing in faith and a testing in science; but nothing comes of this testing either. For if we apply faith's existential measure to the christological idea, it evades the test by referring us to science; if we then will apply science's strict measure, it again evades the test, and refers us to faith. In this way the dogmatician's christological idea can at bottom never be tested, unless it were before a tribunal that is higher than both faith and science; but where, then, is this tribunal?

The christological idea does not satisfy science; for what science is to acknowledge, it must also be able to test; but the christological idea science cannot test. For since this idea has its origin not from the natural system of reason in the present, but from revelation's kingdom beyond, it is of miraculous origin and has a constituent in it about which science can say nothing, since it cannot test it — namely the supernatural constituent. — Christ became man when he was conceived by the Holy Spirit and born of the Virgin Mary. Half-speculative christology can now doubtless put forward various things in general about what it calls the incarnation's "cosmic miracle"; but about *this* incarnation, about *this* conception and *this* birth science can nevertheless settle nothing, since science in no way sees itself able to test the miracle. — Christ is true God and true man. Half-speculative christology can now put forward various things about the God-man in general, about Christ's double nature and double will in general; but about the actual unity of the two natures, how it came about that Christ could really suffer and die on the cross although he himself in the moment of suffering and death continued to be the true God, the God who bears heaven and earth — of this science cannot judge, of this it can express itself neither affirmatively nor negatively. But if science cannot judge christology's content, how then should it be able to acknowledge the christological presentation. — Christ rose from the dead, ascended into heaven, and sat down at the right hand of the Father. There was a time when science in earnest supposed that it could deliver a judgment on this exaltation

of Christ: alas, what vehement controversies have the theologians not conducted about the ubiquity of Christ's body, about *ubiquitas absoluta* and *ubiquitas respectiva*, and what offenses have these controversies not awakened! When such theological controversies can no longer set science in passion, should this not be a proof that one has now at last come to consciousness that such things lie outside the bounds of human knowing; but what lies outside the bound of our objective knowing cannot possibly be treated scientifically.

Neither does the christological idea satisfy faith, and that for the simple reason that every proposition of faith loses its character when it is converted into the form of knowing. The so-called reconciliation of faith and knowledge begins involuntarily with the fundamental fault of placing faith on the same level as knowing, and thus moves in a circle.

To speak of knowing as of a free-standing concept independent of the knower is in order, since knowing is objective; but to treat faith as a general being, grounded in itself, independent of the believer, is unreasonable, since faith is subjective. Faith is only for the believer; the believer is an actual human being existing in subjectivity's inwardness; faith's category is existence's highest category, its knowledge existential. If one nevertheless commits the blunder of abstracting from the believer when one speaks of faith, just as one abstracts from the knower when one speaks of knowing, then one does indeed get the result that faith is objective just as much as knowing; but therewith one has at the same time killed faith, for faith dies in objectivity.

That knowing is objective is recognized from the fact that it is grounded on universally valid presuppositions, on objective proofs, and will have nothing to do with subjective grounds; that faith is subjective is seen from the fact that it is unconditionally grounded in subjectivity's inwardness, and therefore will know nothing at all of the objective grounds. As now he who supposes he is helping science by mixing subjective grounds into the objective proofs offends and bungles science, so one again offends and bungles faith when one attempts to support subjectivity's decisive ground by objective proofs.

In order to justify his half-speculative christology, the dogmatician is — characteristically enough — on the whole more attentive to the Epistles than to the Gospels, and, as regards the Gospels, more attentive to John than to the Synoptics. The reason for this is evident enough. The Gospels, especially the "synoptic" ones, keep at every point within existence, whereas the Epistles, on the other hand, which put forward the doctrine in greater generality, seem to come far nearer to scientific discourse. In the Epistles, therefore, especially in the Pauline Epistles, one has supposed one found the type for a

speculative christology, and the Apostle Paul has in this way been set up as a model for speculative dogmaticians.

That there really do occur in the Apostle Paul, as also in the evangelist John, many propositions and expressions that dogmatizing speculation can in its own way take to its credit shall never be denied; but from this it does not yet follow that these Johannine or Pauline propositions themselves rest on a speculative ground.

The Pauline doctrine of Christ is just as little speculative as the Johannine doctrine of the Logos is speculative. What John and Paul express in this direction they express not in the name of science, but in the name of faith, with faith's subjective assurance, with inspiration's divine authority. When it is said in John's Gospel: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. The same was in the beginning with God. All things were made by it, and without it was not one thing made that was made" . . . ; when it is said further (v. 14): "The Word became flesh and dwelt among us," and so on — then these propositions doubtless sound speculative to a speculative ear; but if we look a little more closely, it will soon show itself that such statements neither are nor can be speculatively meant.

If the Johannine doctrine of the Logos were to have speculative significance, then it would surely have to be laid out in such a way that it could be justified metaphysically; but this is not at all the case. The proposition *the Word became flesh* is no scientific proposition and can never become one. "The Word became flesh": the supernatural took on our nature, the supra-historical became historical; such a composition of such heterogeneous factors science cannot master, and what science cannot master it will not judge either. If science were to settle anything about the proposition *the Word became flesh*, then the law for the supernatural's interaction with the natural would first have to be discovered (as natural science has discovered laws for the interaction of natural things); but this law is to science a pure X, an entirely unknown magnitude: here no scientific test can be instituted; but what science cannot test, science will not judge either. If the Johannine proposition is to be grounded scientifically, then things look sorry indeed, both for John's Gospel and for Christianity; for the grounding is really entirely impossible. But if scientific grounding is in this case entirely impossible, then it is surely also, as regards faith, entirely superfluous.

The Johannine proposition is an existential proposition of revelation. When John says: "The Word became flesh and dwelt among us," he says it in the name of faith; the evangelist's faith cannot be separated from the evangelist himself: faith cannot be separated from the believer. In speaking out of his faith, the evangelist does not speak

about faith in general, but he speaks as a believer to believers: the relation is existential, not scientific. The others who would convince themselves of the truth in the evangelist's word cannot then be convinced by objective grounds in general either. The only ground on which the conviction can be built is that the evangelist is inspired; but that the evangelist is inspired cannot be proved by objective grounds either: it must be believed. If I am to believe the evangelist's word, then I must believe that the evangelist is inspired; if I am to believe that the evangelist is inspired, I must also believe the evangelist's word: the relation between the evangelist himself and all those who by the evangelist's word are to come to faith is again existential, not scientific.

From this one sees at the same time what one is to judge of the christological passages found in the Apostles' Epistles. Already the manner in which these Epistles came into being must in the highest degree warn us against scientific misunderstandings. How, pray, does such a letter come about? Confusion arises in a congregation; self-willed people, immoral persons, false teachers awaken offense. The report of this reaches the absent apostle and awakens his concern. With the zeal of one concerned, with his gaze fixed on the offenses taking place, with all the haste that the danger of the moment makes necessary, the apostle now sits down and writes his letter. In this letter, whose purpose is to punish, warn, admonish, instruct, encourage, and comfort, the christological propositions of revelation are now interwoven into the practical instruction, so that the one as it were involuntarily flows from the other; as for example when Paul (Phil. 2:1–13) will inculcate humility in the Philippians, and he then (v. 5–13) says: "For let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus, who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God, but emptied himself and took upon him the form of a servant, and was made in the likeness of men; and being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross. Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him and given him a name which is above every name; that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven and things on earth and things under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father. Therefore, my beloved," and so on.

But what the apostle thus writes in the danger of the moment, in the anxiety of concern, in the zeal of love, so that his heart burns — behold, this the theologians then in all scientific peace and leisure make the object of objective scientific contemplation: does one not then notice the disproportion! What faith's apostle writes to believers for faith's furtherance in faith's name — behold, this the theologians then suppose they can treat as half-speculative contributions to a half-speculative understanding of the half-speculative

relation between Christ's divine and human nature (κρύψις or κένωσις?), between the God-man's humiliation and the God-man's exaltation (*status exinanitionis* and *status exaltationis*); does one not then notice the disproportion!

If already the apostolic letter-form and the peculiar conditions under which these letters came into being must warn us against the speculative-scientific conception, how much more must we not be warned when we consider that these letters have streamed forth from inspiration's spring. The spirit that inspires the scientific author is not the apostolic one. If an inspired apostle arose in the present age, he would surely have something else to do than to be an author, and would then teach us something quite other than what we can learn from scientific books. Where religion's spirit has a power such as it must have in an apostle's life, the religious is far too jealous for itself and far too zealous for its proclamation for the inspired one to get peace for scientific contemplations and aesthetic enjoyment of ideas. An apostolic word is an apostolic deed; an apostle truly has no time to build theories; even when he writes his longest letter and communicates the doctrine in the fullest form, every word is seized out of his own life, and the communication point for point existential.

In half-speculative dogmatics the incarnation and inspiration are now regarded as the two great fundamental miracles that condition and explain one another mutually. He who does not accept inspiration cannot grasp the incarnation either; as one judges of Christ's apostles, so one judges of Christ himself: the true image of Christ must be seen in the light of the apostolic spirit. What dogmatics thus says in general we must also grant in all generality; but does this general concession nevertheless lead us into speculative contemplations?

As the principle of inspiration is a supra-scientific principle of existence that holds only for the believer in faith, so also the principle of incarnation is a supra-scientific principle of existence, and the relation between the two an existential, not a speculative relation.

The existential doctrine of Christ that can be derived from the Apostles' Epistles is at all points in agreement with the doctrine of Christ that lies in the confession of faith and in the Gospels; but the half-speculative christology that the theologians abstract from Scripture and the Church's doctrine will never rightly agree with the Gospels' Christ.

Theological christology will now, for example, either not let Christ be tempted at all, because his temptation in the wilderness seems to it so unreasonable (in this case the dogmatician then straightforwardly defies the evangelists); or else scientific christology does indeed grant a temptation, but without entering more closely into the temptation

of which the evangelists speak. The evangelical history of the temptation is not at all laid out for scientific treatment. What a half-speculative christology has to tell us about Christ's temptation in general is, on the other hand, when it is said most profoundly of all, precisely calculated to make a scientific impression. But this scientific impression — how different it is from the wondrous, repellent, offensive impression we feel when we read with a "critical eye" the Gospel of the temptation in the wilderness.

He who reads half-speculative christology gets an impression as if human understanding were now in the best understanding with the revealed fact, as if now everything, even the most wondrous of all, even the temptation in the wilderness, were quite near to being resolved into science's christological idea; he, on the other hand, who gives himself over to the impression of the evangelical history of the temptation feels involuntarily that he must either reject this temptation as an absurd fancy, or else take reason captive under faith's obedience.

If the Gospel now at all points makes the impression that one is to believe with understanding *against* understanding, while dogmatics at all points endeavors to produce the impression that offense's sting had disappeared in science, so that at speculation's present stage one should really only believe *with* understanding: then it is surely evident enough that the Gospel and dogmatics work — not with one another — but against one another.

Therefore the theologians have also, not only on historical-critical but at the same time on metaphysical-dogmatic grounds, always so much to correct in the four evangelists; it is so very seldom that an evangelist is so fortunate as to be able to suit them properly. In recent times the evangelist John, for example, has had to hear ill of it because, contrary to christology's scientific rule, he lets Christ pray aloud at Lazarus's grave. "Das Unpassende dieser Wendung" — says De Wette — "muß man anerkennen Denn in der That dürfen und müssen wir uns Jesu Bewußtseyn von Gott und seiner Stellung zu ihm als ein ununterbrochenes, nicht an einzelne Gebetsmomente geknüpfted denken."^{*)}

But suppose even that the dogmatician's half-speculative image of Christ were in all main features as like the evangelists' Christ as a copy can resemble its original — we should be no nearer for that. The dogmatic image of Christ falls under a quite different horizon, and is entirely heterogeneous with the evangelical Christ. The evangelical Christ stands in actual existence, and at every moment makes existence's demand of everyone who approaches to contemplate him; but the dogmatic image of Christ stands only in contemplation, and belongs to the aesthetic-scientific gallery of ideas, where

^{*)}Cf. *Evangeltr. og den mod. Bev.*, pp. 438–58.

everyone who has any “deeper sense” can go to enjoy the spectacle. To paint an image of Christ with words and thoughts is doubtless a greater art than to paint it with lines and colors; the task has accordingly not yet been solved by any speculative-Protestant dogmatician, as it was long since solved by the Catholic painters of the Middle Ages.

But even if the task were solved with astonishing success; even if there arose a dogmatic-speculative genius who succeeded in painting us an image of Christ with such philosophical profundity, such inwardness of piety, such purity in thought, such clarity in expression, that Christ now really stood before us in this image as “the immediate appearance of divine holiness on earth,” so that “the highest love and the heart’s humility and devotion in God were here seen to melt together into one with the expression, inspiring both fear and reverence, of a righteousness whose foundation nothing can shake, and with the mystical expression of a power that could bid all forces and all powers serve it”; — suppose that the solution of the task succeeded for the dogmatician on so extraordinary a scale: then such an image of Christ would nevertheless still be just as far from making a specifically Christian impression as the painter’s image.

For just as the painter’s image makes an aesthetic-artistic impression, and therefore gladdens and attracts all those who have a sense for sacred art without regard to whether they are in actuality believing or unbelieving, so the aesthetic-speculative image of Christ would make an aesthetic-speculative impression, and therefore in a high degree gladden and attract all those who have a sense for speculative imaginative intuition; but this image of speculation would nevertheless by no means stand before the beholder as “*the sign of contradiction*,” would nevertheless not have power to “*reveal the thoughts of hearts*,” would nevertheless not be “*mighty in word and deed*”: would nevertheless not be able to make a true evangelical impression as “*the Savior of the world*!”

If one cannot relate oneself aesthetically-speculatively to the Christ of the faith of the Gospel^{*)}, then neither can one relate oneself in evangelical faith to speculation’s image of Christ.

It can indeed sometimes happen that one or another comes forward and testifies that it is now really the dogmatic christology that has properly first grounded and clarified his faith for him, indeed that only in the profoundly speculative image of Christ has he really properly seen who Christ is; but with such testimonies one ought nevertheless to be cautious. It is unhappily only too true that we human beings in the nineteenth century are very inclined to confuse our aesthetic-speculative interest in the idea with the religious-ethical interest in the matter; how easily then may it not happen

^{*)}On this cardinal point let one read “*Philosophiske Smuler*” by Johannes Climacus.

that someone really supposes himself to be strengthened in Christianity, although he has, properly speaking, only been strengthened in an aesthetic-speculative love for an aesthetic-speculative image of Christ!

By many ways Christianity comes to human beings, by many ways human beings come to Christianity. We readily grant that theological christology can also in its own way become the occasion for a human being to go into himself and reflect on the Gospel; but we must therefore none the less make a distinction between the matter itself and the occasion of the matter.

One can with reason say that it stands with the dogmatic images of Christ in the Protestant Church as with the aesthetic images of the Madonna in the Catholic: various things are told of their power of conversion, but this power of conversion is somewhat ambiguous. In order to remove the ambiguity, let one resolve to give faith what is faith's, and science what is science's.

By this apportionment dogmatics' half-speculative image of Christ will, insofar as it consists in a mystical fusion of faith and knowledge, doubtless for a great part fade and vanish; but the Gospel's Christ will conquer and win, when it is recognized in truth and proved in deed *that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*

Ninth Lecture

Theology's half-speculative dogmatics cannot justify its ecclesial significance from the history of the Church, since the history of the Church proves, on the contrary, how dogmatic prejudices have in this respect harmed the Church, and what a thoroughgoing opposition there is here between theological and ecclesial dogmatics. Theological dogmatics must fall before the proposition that Christianity is a paradox: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

The series of objections advanced in these discourses, both against theology in general and in particular against the present age's theologians, will perhaps have a repellent effect on many — even to the degree that, without discussing the matter more closely, they at once reject the view here set up as a one-sided and arbitrary conceit.

The misgivings that press forward on this occasion are then doubtless not few either. To keep to but one question: “how should Christianity be able to tear itself loose from theology, since the Church cannot possibly do without its firm structure of doctrine, its dogmatics? Christianity is indeed a life, but it is also a doctrine, and it is the one only insofar as it is the other. It is the Church's requirement that the Word be taught purely and cleanly; but how should God's Word be able to be taught purely and cleanly when one casts contempt on the objective, systematic concept of doctrine? Doubtless the Apostles' Creed furnishes a type for the Church's doctrine in general, but the Church's history shows sufficiently why one could not stop at this first general foundation. Under continued controversies with the various heretical parties the Church soon saw itself compelled to articulate the Christian content in ever more definite expressions, in order thereby to ward off the un-Christian. Thus the symbols were formed at the ecumenical synods (at Nicaea 325, at Constantinople 381, at Chalcedon 451, at Constantinople 680) under vehement theological struggles. These theological struggles are to be regarded not merely as theoretical party controversies, but at the same time as the magnificent religious crises the Church had to go through in order rightly to take possession of its Christianity and secure objective truth against the arbitrariness of subjective opinions.”

“If from the beginning one has thus not been able to refrain from entering upon a learned scientific treatment of the individual doctrinal propositions, then it follows of itself that one has not been able to refrain from going through all the dogmas in their inner organic connection either — or, in other words, from treating the whole doctrine of the Church systematically.”

“As it went with the formation of the Catholic concept of doctrine, so it went later also with the formation of the Protestant. Scarcely had the Reformation’s religious breakthrough taken place before a scientific reworking of the Church’s doctrine also followed. Luther was more pastor than theologian; Melancthon was more theologian than pastor; Calvin was with equal distinction both theologian and pastor. From this one sees that theology is not an arbitrary conceit of individual learned men, but an organic product of ecclesial life.”

“Doubtless it is not necessary for the individual layman to procure systematic insight into the individual parts of the concept of doctrine; but it is nevertheless none the less necessary for the ecclesial teaching order. If the congregation cannot do without the confession and the Gospel, then the teaching order cannot do without the concept of doctrine and dogmatics either. Doubtless the chief Christian doctrines cannot be set forth for the congregation in their dogmatic connection or scientific grounding; but it is nevertheless none the less a truth that Christian preaching stands in an organic reciprocal relation to Christian dogmatics, so that one can therefore say: to such a dogmatics corresponds such a sermon, and to such a sermon such a dogmatics.”

“If it must now be granted that preaching presupposes dogmatics, and dogmatics theology: should there then not be contained in this a serious admonition as to how questionable it is to want to undermine theological science — assuming that one does not therewith at the same time intend to undermine Christian doctrine?”

We have now seen that there are misgivings. But however weighty these misgivings may appear to us at first glance, they are nevertheless, seen more closely, of far too fleeting a nature for one to be able to build on them any reliable defense of the prevailing theology. — It will hardly have escaped the attentive observer that such misgivings, occasioned by surveys of church history, always move in so vague a generality that they precisely thereby divert attention from the real question of principle. The church-historical considerations by which one might in this respect attempt to defend Christian science and re-establish the disputed authority of theological dogmatics can at once be given such a turn that they let themselves be used with the greatest emphasis for a direct attack on theology itself.

In order, then, to get away from the vague generality — back to the question of principle — I shall here permit myself to direct attention to some prejudices, which one might perhaps best designate by the expression *dogmatic prejudices*. Dogmatics lays claim to being treated systematically; I will this time comply with that, and treat its prejudices systematically. I place these systematic prejudices in a systematic relation 1) to heresy, 2) to Christian zeal for faith, 3) to higher scientific rigor.

1) When the Church makes use of an age's scientific forces to discover the Christian element in a disputed doctrine, it by no means lies in the Church's idea to let science, as science, settle what is Christian and not Christian. The Church uses science only as means and instrument in order to arrive at clarity about its own tasks. Science has the office of proposing various modes of expression and formulas for the doctrine's content; but the Church reserves to itself the choice among these forms of expression according to its own judgment: only the Church has authority to stamp the definite doctrinal proposition with faith's seal, to sanction it as dogma. When the doctrinal proposition is sanctioned, it is an object for believing appropriation, and has nothing further to do with science. This is the relation of principle between the Church and science.

But since science nevertheless had from the beginning to be set in motion every time a new dogma was coming into being, the blunder lay only too near at hand that science, while it worked for the Church, now also at the same time worked a little on its own account and speculated a little about the dogma, in order after all to make it a little comprehensible. So it came about that science became theology, and theology nourished heresy. — How does heresy arise? It arises from the fact that one will reason one's way to the dogma and reason about the dogma.

Had the Church been able to keep faith's principle pure, then the conflict between orthodoxy and heresy would from the beginning have transformed itself into a direct and open conflict between faith and unbelief; the heretic's unbelief would then have shown itself precisely in this, that he corrupted the doctrine because he reasoned about the dogma. Instead of reasoning with the heretics, the orthodox would then have had to confine themselves to preaching conversion to the erring. This principle the Church could not carry through; its teachers became theologians, and the theologians then shared with the heretics the error that the Church's doctrine ought in general to be an object of reasoning and speculating. The vehement heresy conflict thus did not become any pure conflict of principle between faith and unbelief, but was corrupted into a half-scientific conflict between a supposedly true and a supposedly false speculation, a supposedly true and a supposedly false theology.

This conflict then bore in itself the contradiction that is quite fitted to inflame the passions to the very utmost. Neither of the contending parties could here come to see its own wrong. The orthodox theologians felt within themselves that they had the Church and Christianity on their side, and that their theology consequently must be right in faith; but now the same theology was at the same time to be right in speculation: this prejudice inflamed the heretics. If there was to be reasoning and speculating at all, then the heretic held himself fully and firmly convinced that his own speculation was far more reasonable and far more sensible than the Church's. Far from seeing that it was he himself who was astray, the heretic now rather believed himself called to save the Church from a disastrous aberration, from a doctrine so unreasonable that it conflicted both with true speculation and with sound understanding.

"What one is to believe, one ought so far as possible also to see one's way to comprehending" was the orthodox theologian's principle; *"what one cannot comprehend, one ought not to believe either"* was heretical theology's principle. The one of these principles supports the other. Arius became a heretic, and why? because he could not comprehend that the Son had the same essence as the Father; although Athanasius did endeavor to make it comprehensible to him. Nestorius became a heretic, and why? because he could not comprehend that the two natures were one in Christ's person; although Cyril with all his adherents labored to make it comprehensible to him. Pelagius became a heretic, and why? because he could not comprehend how human freedom was resolved into divine grace; although Augustine summoned up all his profundity to make it comprehensible to him.

To touch on but one main point in the Protestant Church: how have the Lutherans and the Reformed not denounced one another as heretics in the dispute over the Lord's Supper, so sorry for both parties! Luther was right, he felt it deeply; it was this feeling that made him so strong in confession, so bitter in conflict. Yes, assuredly Luther was right; modern Christendom is hardly conscious of what the Church owes to the man who on this point stood so firmly on the text's word and defied a world with faith's Gospel. Yes, Luther was right — yet not as theologian, but as pastor. His conception of the Lord's Supper explains itself precisely from the fact that he originally saw the sacrament not with the theologian's but with the pastor's eye. What Luther as theologian has put forward about the doctrine of the Lord's Supper is significant only for his own time; his theologoumena are vanishing, but his pastoral testimonies will remain as long as faith is — faith.

Luther himself was not clear about the relation of principle between religion and

theology. The new doctrine needed science's assistance; Melancthon was a theologian, and the theologian then supposed that Calvin was right; for Calvin was also a theologian. But the Lutheran Church, which was unconditionally right in faith, would now at the same time also be unconditionally right in theology; so it went the longer the worse. Lutheran theology worked itself weary in unspeculative speculations, and has long had to see its favorite theories about *communicatio idiomatum* and *ubiquitas corporis Christi* abandoned to dissolving criticism.

The old dispute between the Lutherans and the Reformed has fallen asleep in the age's indifferentism, but wakes up again every time worldly prudence sets about burdening consciences with a union calculated on mere humanity. When, then, will the dispute end? It ends only in spirit and truth when both churches, the Lutheran as well as the Reformed, resolve to give up their theological-dogmatic prejudices and hold in faith's inwardness to the word of institution, to the Gospel's text.

2) Ecclesial zeal for objective orthodoxy has often been confused with true Christian zeal for faith; this confusion has chiefly its ground in a dogmatic prejudice.

The dogmatician relates himself objectively to Christian truth, and then supposes he is spreading Christ's kingdom by procuring for this truth a certain objective victory in the objective world. Here is the point where theological dogmatics coincides with the state church, whether this be otherwise Catholic or Protestant.

Orthodox theology's objective dogmas are put forward as pure objective truths, and in such a way that no one who accepts Christianity at all shall be able to avoid becoming convinced of these truths, unless he is either stupid or obstinate: now comes the self-contradiction. The Christian truths are assuredly objective; but they are not objective in the sense in which mathematical, philosophical — in short, scientific — truths are objective.

Scientific truths gain entry by conviction's objective way. It would here be as great a folly to apply compulsion as to show obstinacy. With the Christian truths it is otherwise. These truths can only make their way in by conviction's subjective way. If they are nevertheless to be inculcated as pure objective, general truths, they must of course meet with contradiction; this contradiction then becomes a sign of obstinacy, and against the obstinate one applies compulsion.

So it goes: orthodoxy's strict theologians discover a heresy; they summon the heretic to appear at a hearing, a colloquium, a disputation, so that he may be refuted by sound grounds and scientifically convinced of his dogmatic error. What happens? In the course of the disputation it shows itself that the heretic cannot be refuted, since he of course

has just as many grounds for his opinion as the orthodox have for theirs. Then passion comes to a boil, and the matter takes a subjective turn. The accused is now no longer regarded as a poor erring human being who lacks true insight because he lacks dogmatic grounds, but he is treated as a stiff-necked, hardened sinner who out of sheer obstinacy will not let himself be convinced. But convinced he shall be — by objective grounds. If science's grounds will not suffice, the state comes to the aid with its grounds; and behold, then the hardened heretic is also quite properly convinced subjectively — by objective grounds.

But what do we now call it, to treat a purely subjective matter as if it were purely objective? In relation to the scientific misunderstanding we call it stupidity; but in relation to the passionate zeal that prefers to work by outward compulsion, we call it tyranny.

That the Catholic Church so early became a church of compulsion, and as a church of compulsion gave itself over to tyranny in doctrine as in constitution, it has chiefly its theologians to thank for, for in its original idea this did not lie at all. That the Protestant Church, which strove for the right of consciences, so quickly became a church of compulsion that tyrannized over consciences, it has chiefly its theologians to thank for; for it was especially they who by their systematic concepts of doctrine made the subjective matter systematically objective.

“But” — one says — “these blunders were long since abolished. What crying injustice to blame orthodox theologians for what plainly lay in the spirit of the age!” — Let me not be misunderstood. I do not judge consciences; I speak only of the principle. As it ought to be remembered with gratitude that there were many orthodox theologians who in sincerity's strength pleaded the cause of Christian freedom in the face of the threatening state church, many orthodox theologians who in that sorry period of compulsion dared to repeat with Melancthon: *Tyrannis est inimica ecclesiae*; so it ought also to be dutifully acknowledged that there are to this very day orthodox theologians, theologians who in sincerity's strength defend the old strict concept of doctrine in its whole severity in spite of modern enlightenment. At a time when each and all plead freedom's cause, it is doubtless a grateful task to speak up for the Church's freedom too; but it is no grateful task at all to maintain the strict dogma and teach the present age's sensible people that one is to believe — against understanding.

Here, then, there can be no talk at all of the theologians' subjective conviction (for this would precisely be, once again, to transform a subjective matter into an objective one); but here there shall and ought to be talk of the theological principle. In principle, the

objective dogmatics that will help faith along by scientific grounds commits exactly the same blunder as the objective state church that will help faith along by civil compulsion: they fit together so exactly that he who will consistently hold to the first ought also to be consistent enough to hold to the last. If the Christian dogma is in actuality so objective that in relation to science it can be defended with objective grounds, then the state church is truly also so objective that in relation to religious upbringing it can and ought to apply civil compulsion: then let us have the old church discipline back!

3) As we now in conclusion consider the dogmatic prejudices in their relation to higher scientific rigor, we must first and foremost make clear to ourselves what it is that is really here in dispute, and then also what is not here in dispute.

Here it is not in dispute whether it is a need for the Church to have its Christian dogmatics; but here it is in dispute how the dogmas are treated in Christian dogmatics. Here it is not in dispute whether the Christian propositions of faith are objective or not; but here it is in dispute what the essential relation of the objective propositions of faith is to subjective faith. Here it is not in dispute whether a thorough scientific knowledge is a necessary presupposition for the systematic treatment of the dogmas; but here it is in dispute what the relation of principle is in which science, as science, ought to stand to the system of dogmas.

That the Church must have its dogmatics — insofar as by dogmatics one understands a thetically coherent presentation of the Christian dogmas — follows directly from its historical presuppositions and its reciprocal relation to the age's cultivation. In the present time, when the Christian propositions of faith have long since been explained away, construed, and misconstrued in so many ways that Christendom has almost forgotten what the Christian is, the congregation's teachers can undeniably profit from getting to see the Church's original dogmas once again in their right shape, and from receiving an impression of the imposing distinctiveness of the ecclesial structure of doctrine.

But the dogmatics that the Church's teachers thus need is assuredly not a half-speculative dogmatics, a dogmatics that must first be mediated with the age's ideas, and on that account must first be produced by some dogmatic genius or other. No, the dogmatics the Church needs is none other than the dogmatics the Church itself already has, insofar as it already has its dogmas. The whole labor then simply confines itself to the task of revising these dogmas and freeing them from speculations of every irrelevant kind.

But, it goes without saying, with this meager task theology of course cannot be

content; it demands a more, it demands that something be achieved here for science as well. So there prevails the dogmatic prejudice that every new dogmatician who writes a new dogmatics must treat the dogmas in a new and original way. This prejudice, which has by no means diminished but rather increased with theology's increasing scientific rigor, then in turn produces a remarkable opposition between ecclesial and theological dogmatics. Ecclesial dogmatics is in constant being, for Christianity is that which is, and the Christian has been found; theological dogmatics, on the other hand, finds itself in an unceasing becoming: it constantly looks as though one could not yet rightly find wherein the Christian actually consists, as though the true and complete concept of doctrine could never rightly be finished. Ecclesial dogmatics is essentially one and the very same, for the Church maintains itself in maintaining its type of doctrine; but theological dogmatics, which mediates faith's content with science's ideas, is in unceasing alteration, for here in the Protestant Church there come to be just as many dogmatics as there are original dogmaticians. — Either, then, Christian doctrine itself must be alterable, like theology's alterable dogmatics, or else one must confess that theological dogmatics is heterogeneous with Christian doctrine, as the alterable is heterogeneous with the unalterable.

“But” — one says — “there is nevertheless a third and higher thing, a medium in which the alterable and the unalterable are bound into unity: this medium is the idea. If the idea is taken away, dogmatics becomes spiritless; but the Church can surely not be served by having an idea-forsaken — that is, a spiritless — dogmatics.”

It is the modern notion of the dogma's scientific perfectibility that haunts the prejudice I shall now discuss. The theological dogmatician will of course not deny that the dogma is a proposition of faith, and as a proposition of faith most immediately an object for practical appropriation in faith; but then he asserts at the same time that the dogma is on the other hand an objective proposition of truth, a proposition of truth that as such must become an object for an ever deeper appropriation in objective knowing. As a proposition of faith the dogma is unalterable: the Church itself has only one dogmatics; but as a scientific proposition the dogma is at the same time alterable, insofar as it ferments in an ever-advancing process of knowledge, and develops in a multiplicity of different forms of the idea: the Church's theology has many dogmatics.

“It is therefore the same dogma that in the idea shows itself both as unalterable and as alterable; it is the same dogma that strikes root in the heart and unfolds its blossom in speculation; it is the same dogma that becomes an object for a double knowledge, a subjective one in faith, an objective one in knowing; it is the same dogma and the same faith that goes through a double development, a practical one in life, a theoretical

one in the school.” — Herewith I believe I have set forth the speculating dogmatician’s “fundamental view” as sharply and definitely as possible.

But if now the dogma that is an object for subjective knowledge in faith cannot in any way become an object for objective knowledge in knowing without at the same time altering its nature and thus ceasing to be the same dogma; if now the faith that is to develop practically in life ceases to be the same faith when it is set forth theoretically in the school; if now the presupposition that the Christian dogma is to be known objectively because it is itself objective shows itself to be a false presupposition: what then?

“*Christianity is the paradox!*” — sounds another voice — from another side. — The paradox! This word strikes school theology with a stunning blow. The paradox! But what, then, is the paradox? Well, it is precisely that which science cannot explain. Yet from science’s not being able to explain the paradox it does not yet follow that the paradox, as some suppose, is merely a catchword for paradox-mongers, an arbitrary cue of an “ecstatic” poet-thinker. From science’s not being able to explain the paradox it does not yet follow that it should be impossible to explain what the paradox is and wherein it consists. Paradox is a Greek word which, if that could serve to recommend it, is even found in the New Testament.

That I may here in my own way give a short explanation, I say: the paradox expresses the Christian object’s repulsion of the knowing subject, and consists in the tension under which the believer with inwardness’s infinite passion holds fast the object of faith.

Of all other objects it holds that the objective will be known objectively, and that there must therefore be an objective relation of attraction between the knowing subject and the object that is to be known; only the object of revelation makes an exception, for here the relation is as repellent as possible. All other objects — those of history, of natural science, of mathematics, of philosophy — let themselves be appropriated in objective knowing; the knower can come into direct understanding with these objects, can penetrate deeper and deeper into their essence; only with the object of revelation can the knower not come into direct understanding: understanding is in conversion, in continued conversion; understanding is in being turned about, in continued being turned about; the understanding is paradoxical. All other objects will be known objectively, *because they are objective*; only revelation’s object will, both before faith and in faith and after faith, be known subjectively, *although* it is objective. The miracle, for example, is an object, and yet I cannot relate myself objectively to the miracle in objective knowing; but the paradox is that I must relate myself subjectively to the objectively repellent miracle, and appropriate it in faith’s inwardness.

In the dialectical writings of our most recent literature the paradoxical relation between faith itself and faith's object is, so far as I can judge, presented with such assurance, such acuteness and precision, that one can see exactly that these factors must in an absolute sense be determined for one another: to faith as faith corresponds such an object, to such an object corresponds faith in its highest potency as faith^{*)}.

It is not unknown to me that the theological consciousness takes umbrage at the paradox, and regards it as a sign of a monstrous one-sidedness in the subjective. That I find in this quite a singular agreement between the theological consciousness and my own consciousness I must on the present occasion permit myself to remark, since it might perhaps cast light on one or another point in this involved matter.

The theological consciousness now tells us, in the year 1850, that the dialectical writings to which we here allude are doubtless exceedingly brilliant, piquant, and apt, but that the "fundamental view" nevertheless, when one looks a little more closely, betrays itself as a striking one-sidedness: the same thing my consciousness told me in the year 1843. The theological consciousness is offended at the paradox because it looks like holding out a while yet — perhaps even until the year 1853^{*)}; my consciousness became offended at the paradox because it came so suddenly, so strangely, with "*Fear and Trembling*" in the year 1813. The theological consciousness still sees in the present year, 1850, as clearly as before how "das winzige Paradox" lacks positive force, and therefore cannot hold its own against "positive theology"; remarkably enough, the same thing — let me say it without self-praise — the very same thing my consciousness also saw clearly until shortly before the year 1848. I therefore need — what in such a retrospect is besides an easy matter — only alter a single date, and I have the fairest agreement between the theological consciousness and my own humble consciousness, so closely are they akin.

What in later times may have so clouded my vision that I can no longer, as before, see the paradox's "evident one-sidedness" those theologians who have still preserved clear sight will surely know better than I. The only explanation I am able to give here is merely that from the year 1845 until now I have spent most of my time and diligence in studying — besides the German freethinkers and the theology dissolving itself in Germany with German consistency — the writings here alluded to. Whether I have in every respect understood these writings quite as the author himself will have them

^{*)}Since faith and faith's object are both equally paradoxical and consequently homogeneous, the relation between these homogeneous factors is again a direct and not a paradoxical relation. From this it is explained that the believer who lives in all simplicity does not notice the paradox.

^{*)}This date is admittedly given at random: yet it might, if only one will let oneself be instructed by "the signs of the times," perhaps in time acquire a "deeper" significance for those who have "deeper sense."

understood I cannot possibly say — one understands an existential author only insofar as one understands oneself — but studied them I have, and that with exceptional interest. Who knows? perhaps this is precisely the fault! who knows? had I not studied them at all, not guessed at these riddles, not lost myself in these regions, not stared at these sphinxes: who knows? perhaps my consciousness would then still have been, if not quite as clear, then at any rate nearly as clear-eyed as the theological consciousness; they do say that sharp light and much studying harm the eyes.

It is not unknown to me that the theological consciousness is dissatisfied with the paradox. Doubtless the “good forces” that are now beginning to stir (especially in the very youngest theology) would be able to knock “the paradox” over if it really had to be; but such a thing would after all always have to happen in a conflict, and “Christian wisdom” — prefers the blessing of peace. Doubtless the theological consciousness is inwardly dissatisfied with the paradox, but — the paradox has once for all been put in; the man who put it in observed the precaution of putting an existence in with it, and doing it so resolutely, so quickly, so deftly that theology noticed nothing at all until it was done. Now it is done, and the theological consciousness sees very well that what has happened has happened. Theology therefore lets the paradox stand for what it is, untouchable and untouched, and is then firmly resolved to chastise everyone who might otherwise presume to touch the untouchable.

The paradox is theology’s stone of stumbling; if theology stumbles over this stone of stumbling, it must fall and smash its dogmatics to pieces.

I have been reproached for changing my standpoint so suddenly — for the paradox’s sake; this reproach is undeserved. If I were to reproach myself for anything, it would surely have to be that I hesitated too long, and was not resolute enough to take my side at once and declare it plainly.

I have been reproached for attacking “so personally” one of our best theologians — for the paradox’s sake; as though I thereby wished partly to show the world what a sacrifice I was making for truth in thus changing my standpoint, partly to seize the opportunity of winning — even if only at second hand — a little victory over an otherwise talented man whom we must all nevertheless highly esteem as a distinguished and deserving teacher.

The first of these accusations I pass lightly by, since I know how groundless it is. I have in this matter made truth no sacrifice worth mentioning. I stood, in accordance with my position, outside theology, and could therefore break with theology without any particular self-denial; I bore no opinion, was not borne by any opinion, and consequently

was not made anxious by any finite regard for an opinion.

As regards the last surmise, on the other hand, it would grieve me deeply if it should really spread and win credence; for I can in this matter win no victory whatever, either at first or at second hand; nor have I ever felt any urge to win any victory whatsoever, either great or small, if I except only the victory I, *volente Deo*, am to win over myself. Before I began my so-called “conflict,” I first bound my hands: they are bound, I bound them myself, and cannot loose them again. So I contend as best I can, with bound hands; but he who contends with bound hands is surely a fool if he contends for an outward victory. I do not intend to stand in anyone’s way, and least of all to offend a man for whom I have personal goodwill; I wish only to make use of a permission that I give myself, and that surely no one can deny me: a permission to express my conviction, a permission to shed light on theological science, a permission to repeat my *cæterum censeo*, *that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology*.

Tenth Lecture

According to the method now in force, theoretical theology finds itself in an evident disproportion to religious practice; in order to maintain the principle of faith, the formation of pastors must emancipate itself from theory, for the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

It is well known how the Greek philosophers asked whether virtue was something that could be taught or something that could not be taught. When by exact examination they had found out that virtue could indeed in one respect not be taught, but in another respect could be, they then asked in turn how and under what conditions that in virtue which could be taught ought also reasonably to be taught.

If it is already a great question whether virtue can be taught at all, and how it ought to be taught, then the question whether and how far Christianity can be taught by human instruction, and how it then properly ought to be taught, is assuredly a still far greater and more difficult question. Recent theology is now so occupied with Easter reckonings and critical introductions, and on that account has doubtless only little time for a closer discussion of this question; but the question nevertheless retains its significance when what is at stake is the relation of principle between Christianity and theology.

Theology divides itself into the theoretical and the practical. Theoretical theology first forms the pastors-to-be into scientific theologians; practical theology is then next to form the young theologians into actual pastors.

If we now place our question in a definite relation to this two-sided task of theology, then practical theology undeniably seems to give us a quite different answer from the theoretical.

If Christianity were something that could be taught by human instruction, if it were possible by human art to form and educate human beings to understand Christianity — that is, to understand how under all life's circumstances they are to feel and think, be silent and speak, suffer and act, as Christians; indeed to understand how they, after having themselves learned Christianity, ought now also to teach it in turn to others: if it

were possible, I say, that Christianity could thus be taught to the last dot and tittle, who then was nearer to learning it thus than precisely the congregation's future teachers, the pastors-to-be? and if Christianity in this way let itself be taught, who then was nearer to taking charge of the teaching and the education than precisely that theology which has after all set itself the practical task of forming and educating the congregation's teachers.

If practical theology now really supposed in earnest that Christianity was something one could learn by thorough studies and methodical exercises: should one then not expect that this theology with all possible force and zeal took charge of the pastors' formation, and in every possible way endeavored to maintain its standing and answer to its fair name: pastoral theology.

But that practical theology should really have such high thoughts of itself is hardly probable — at least not here in this country, where it is content with so exceedingly modest a role. For what, pray, are the practical exercises at the pastoral seminary? even if one would count in the trial sermon, the catechetical test, and the bishop's examination, how utterly trifling it all is beside the great scientific forces that theoretical theology is able to sacrifice on its "Easter reckonings" and "images of Christ" and "critical introductions."

When, then, pastoral theology, which after all has most immediately to do with the Christian, withdraws so modestly, and on that account, far from plaguing its candidates with many studies and methodical exercises, rather commends them to their own subjective inventiveness, so that they must now go about and try themselves practically on their own to see whether they may here or there hit upon the Christian: must we not then draw from this the conclusion that Christianity is something that in pastoral theology's opinion really cannot be taught at all — just as Socrates in his day drew the conclusion that virtue must surely be something that could not be taught at all, when he saw how Pericles, who was himself so virtuous, neglected his sons' instruction and let them "go about like those animals that were consecrated to the gods, and graze where they would, until they might perhaps of themselves hit upon virtue"?

If we turn with our question to theoretical theology, do we not then come to the entirely opposite result — namely that Christianity is at bottom a learned matter, a matter that both can and ought to be taught, and taught thoroughly? — In the Protestant Church, where ordination has ceased to be a sacrament, one has then particularly felt a need to inculcate the ecclesial necessity of "Christian science," of theological learning, because theological learning is really the ideal mark that distinguishes the pastor from the layman. The pastor is a learned Christian, the layman an unlearned Christian —

behold, that is the difference, a difference that holds as a rule, although the rule has its exceptions.

In the state church's proper period of authority, when there was zeal for objective orthodoxy, the difference between learned and unlearned Christians was in an ecclesial respect a very considerable difference. What mattered was to get a subtle concept of doctrine, articulated at all points, developed in scholastic forms with scholastic consequences, and to purge out heresy. In order rightly to distinguish between true and false faith, the pastor necessarily had to be a theologian, and learned theology had to have the first voice in all ecclesial matters of faith. In later times theology has doubtless abandoned that strict orthodoxy in order to engage with a more sensible wisdom and keep step with advancing enlightenment; but insofar as theoretical theology has to that extent lost a part of its ecclesial standing, it feels itself all the more vigorously called upon to convince the state of its scientific standing, and to hold fast to the "fundamental view" that Christianity is a theory.

Theoretical theology doubtless grants that Christianity is a life just as much as a theory; but since the theoretical is and remains the most important thing in a theory, it is quite natural that theoretical theology holds to the theory. The proof of this we have in the great, decisive — indeed for a whole life decisive — emphasis that is to this very day laid on the so-called theological attestation, the pastors-to-be's theoretical examination. Or how should one explain to oneself the singular sight that the whole yield of several years' laborious studies could be tested so reliably in a few but significant moments, if theology were not in this very examination best able to gather the theoretical rays of the Christian light as into a single theoretical focal point? And how should one explain to oneself the singular sight that a scientific examination for the ministry, confined to a few hours, could still preserve — not indeed a sacramental, but assuredly so fundamental a significance in the state's eyes that it became decisive for the candidate's whole ecclesial-civil future: how, I say, was this possible if the state itself did not theoretically see that Christianity is a theory?

Let one judge of this as one will: so much is certain, that the formation of pastors among us is essentially a theoretical formation, in that it is exclusively a theological formation. One proceeds without further ado from the presupposition that a theologian can form a pastor; with this presupposition one then restricts practical theology and expands the theoretical: it is a remarkable procedure. Can a theologian, then, form a pastor? Practical theology shakes its head doubtfully and withdraws; theoretical theology steps boldly forward and takes over the whole formation. It looks somewhat strange!

Can a theologian, then, form a pastor?

Had Socrates lived, he would have seized on this question; he would surely have gone about and inquired — now of theologians, now of pastors, now of students, now of candidates (as occasion offered) — whether there was no one who would kindly tell him how it really comes about that a theologian can form a pastor.

That like can in general be formed by like, the homogeneous by the homogeneous — that, for example, a mathematician can be formed by a mathematician, a physician by a physician, a jurist by a jurist, a theologian by a theologian — would at once have been quite evident to Socrates, at least as evident as that like can be born of like, a human being of a human being, a sheep of a sheep, and so on. But how like can form unlike, and namely how a theologian can form a pastor, that would surely have been as troublesome for that questioning dialectician to get into his head as how the entirely like can be born of its unlike, the homogeneous of its heterogeneous, a human being of a sheep, a sheep of a human being.

It was in a way well that the old questioner died when he died! had he still lived, he would have caused “Christian science” much bother; had he still lived, he would have caused “Christian wisdom” many an anxious hour! for he would after all not have been able to refrain from instituting a hearing, he would after all not have been able to keep himself from plaguing and harassing the theologians, the candidates, the pastors, indeed perhaps the deans, until he had at length got the secret out of them, the great secret, *how a theologian can form a pastor*.

It is not necessary, however, that a Socrates rise from the dead to tell us how much lies in this question; everyone can tell it to himself once he has looked about him a little in a theological lecture room.

That the relation between teachers and hearers cannot be the same in theological science as, for example, in medical science strikes the eye at once.

In medical science theory and practice are most closely bound together. He who is skilled in medicine and communicates the theory is as a rule himself a practicing physician; the hearer who grasps the theory soon notices that in order himself one day to be able to practice, he must first of all form himself by the theory. Nor does the medically skilled teacher meet his hearers with the explanation that the art of medicine is something that properly speaking cannot be taught at all, but that one will nevertheless lecture both on the theories and on the critical introductions to the theories, because one must after all hold to medical science’s necessity and wishes to have scientifically formed physicians. No, the medically skilled teacher lays out his lecture from the start

in such a way that the hearer at every point notices that what is here communicated in theory is also something that can and shall be used in practice. The student who thus becomes a partaker in medical-scientific formation will then also soon notice in himself whether he is at all suited to be a physician, or whether he has perhaps mistaken his vocation — in which case he can withdraw in time and choose himself another course of study. Finally, the intimate connection of theory and practice that distinguishes medical science has this good in it too, that the young physician's civil future is not absolutely settled by academic examinations. The young physician for whom these examinations have in one or another respect had a less happy outcome can, if he feels strength and courage, still procure himself redress; by continued study and continued practice he can develop his talent and open a way for himself that tolerably answers to his individual ability.

How quite otherwise does it not look with theological science's relation to pastoral formation. The theories lectured in the theological halls are now so scientific, so learned, so objective that on that account they must of course keep as far from practice as is well possible. What is the consequence? That the formation begins in ambiguity, and that this ambiguity then in turn prevents the young hearers from understanding themselves. Here now, for example, sit two hearers side by side: they have both chosen the same course of study, and yet — how different! The one has brought with him a living sense — not indeed for learned science (for his scientific abilities are perhaps somewhat weak) — but he came with a living sense for the religious; he chose theology, he chose it with a good hope, for he so much wanted to be a pastor. He has reverence for theology, he listens attentively to the theologian's lecture, and as he listens — the learned material grows; he gives himself over with a certain love to theology, and now expects that the many explanations will at length explain to him what revelation is, what faith is, what love is: but it seems to him almost as if the many explanations were driving clarity away, for the theories contradict one another. Still he will not lose courage, but will work at the material and study his theology, for — he is studying to be a pastor. Learned criticism weighs on his memory and confuses his concepts; yet he will not yet give up hope, but will diligently study his theology, for he is studying — to be a pastor. But — if the theories nevertheless turn against him, humble him, reject him, and judge him on the day of judgment; if criticism makes it manifest that despite all his theological studying he will nevertheless never become a proper theologian, alas! then he has wasted his time and diligence, then he will surely never become a pastor either!

The other, on the other hand, brings with him no particular sense for religion as

religion, but he brings a quick, sound, and vigorous head, a faithful memory, a sharp understanding, an eye for the objective idea! — So he has presumably not come in order to study for the ministry, but in order to form himself into a scientific theologian? Do not disturb him with irrelevant questions! Of science's ideals he has not yet thought, any more than of the clergy's duties; but — he listens with pleasure, he reads with pleasure, he will in 3 years take his attestation with great pleasure. When that gust is over, the future stands open to him, and only then can there be any talk of recognizing his calling and choosing his vocation. If there is then a prospect of a theological teaching post, he can easily go the theoretical way; but if it turns out otherwise, if he is called to a practical-clerical activity, he will have nothing against going over into the Church and settling into — a good living.

We will for the rest readily grant that the majority of theology's young devotees combine a living religious sense with a quick scientific interest; we will at the same time grant that the extent of the mass of knowledge they have to work through is not greater either than what a tolerably gifted student can manage when he uses his time as he ought; but with this the disproportion between means and end is by no means justified.

When one rightly considers what it costs before a young man brings it so far that he passes his theological examination, and passes with honor: then one is surely also entitled to ask what yield these preliminary studies really give, and how far an academic preparation that has cost the family and the state so considerable a sacrifice now really benefits both the candidate and the state.

Our candidate is then a cultivated and knowledgeable young man, not merely cultivated in general, but in possession of a quite particular cultivation. When we now therefore ask about the yield that this cultivation gives, we are not asking in general about the general advantage that knowledge and cultivation always give; but we ask with the candidate, and he with us: how shall the so dearly bought theory now find in actuality its corresponding practice?

Our candidate is formed in the theologians' school. In the theologians' school he heard, then, the exegete's lectures on exegesis, the church historian's on church history, the dogmatician's on dogmatics, the critic's on criticism, and so on. And the exegete formed him after his own image into an exegete in miniature, the church historian after his own image into a church historian in miniature, the dogmatician after his own image into a dogmatician in miniature — in short, the theologians joined in forming him into a whole theologian in miniature. For it is certain that a theologian can form a theologian.

The practice that directly corresponds to the theory thus won would now directly be

this: that the young theologian, the theologian in miniature, should be further advanced in theological insight and theological learning, and then, when he had himself become a proper theologian, a theologian on the larger scale, should in turn work at forming others into theologians. Behold, that is the peculiar station in life that corresponds wholly and entirely to our candidate's peculiar formation.

But — we ask — is it then for such a station in life that theology's young devotees as a rule prepare themselves? By no means. Theological teaching posts are with us but few. Of 400 students who all study theology, there is perhaps one who goes through and becomes a theologian; the 399 seek other appointment.

But when our candidate cannot in the stricter sense become a theologian, what then? Well, then he shall assuredly learn how difficult it is to find a practice exactly corresponding to his theory. In the Church he does not find it; for the congregation has no need whatever to hear popular lectures either on church history in miniature, or dogmatics in miniature, or the critical introduction in miniature. If the candidate is to speak in the congregation, he must begin over again; if he is to speak the Church's language out of the Church's own train of thought, he must begin over again, and in beginning over again he has — much to forget, but little to remember.

Nor does his peculiar theory find any peculiar practice anywhere in the cultivated world. The questions in whose answering the young candidate has his real and true strength are not the cultivated world's questions; the leading thoughts with which he is in a particular degree familiar are not the cultivated world's leading thoughts. Our young candidate soon notices that he must constantly convert his peculiar theory into the age's general cultivation, and that to that extent he is wronged, since at no point can he come to operate with the powers peculiar to him. He then easily comes into a precarious position; for he comes only too easily into the unpleasant position that he must straightforwardly throw away his theory in order to find his practice: for the poet's words:

Was man nicht weiß, das eben brauchte man,
Und was man weiß, kann man nicht brauchen,

fit as though they were written for a theological candidate.

Many will perhaps think this depiction as one-sided as it is rash, since experience daily shows us that theological formation benefits the candidate in many ways. I imagine, then, that in favor of this view one might put forward the following:

“In order to work as a teacher of religion, whether it be in the church or in the school, the candidate must be in possession of the particular formation that enables him

to master his material and arrange his discourse according to the hearers' need. The teacher of religion ought, like every other teacher, always to possess far more than he can immediately communicate — if for no other reason, then because only on this condition can he possess what he communicates in a higher and freer way. It is an entirely unfair demand that the spiritual yield the candidate has from his learned formation should be demonstrable piece by piece in such a way that it could, like a material yield, a pecuniary advantage, be pettily reckoned up in rixdollars, marks, and shillings. One need only note what difference there is between the religious instruction a good seminarist can furnish and the instruction the confirmands receive from the able pastor; and one will without doubt grant that the higher theological formation has its significance."

"Doubtless a theological student learns much that he must afterward forget; but even if he can perhaps forget a part of the many particulars, he nevertheless preserves a scientific impression of the whole, and with this impression at the same time a freedom of mind with which he can all the more surely judge the religious life's various phenomena and find his way in practical circumstances."

"Doubtless one must grant that theoretical theology among us has at present a certain preponderance over the practical. But partly it is a one-sidedness that can with time be remedied; partly it is on the whole a questionable matter to restrict scientific formation too much. For one will not be able to deny that the practical formation communicated in clerical seminaries only too easily acquires a subjective, sickly, pietistic stamp when it lacks a firm scientific foundation."

"Doubtless scientific theology cannot form the clergyman so immediately and directly as the practical school; but it nevertheless forms him mediately and indirectly, it forms him objectively, and judges his formation by a fixed objective rule. This is especially of importance with respect to the state. For the state, which neither can nor may engage in any subjective assessment of individuals' subjective zeal for faith, can and ought on the other hand to have a fixed objective rule for filling the clerical offices."

I have thought it right not to overlook such considerations, which always look best when they are put forward in pure generality, and can therefore easily take it into their heads to present themselves as serious admonitions. If, however, we go into the matter itself, such considerations will hardly be able to uphold the theory's standing. One appeals to the necessity of a higher scientific formation. The significance of higher formation is here not at all called in question; but the question is whether such a higher formation could not be set in a far more intimate connection with the corresponding station in life than has hitherto happened. One appeals to the necessity of an objective

measure of the candidate's ability. The significance of such a measure is here not at all denied; but the question is whether the practical school were not able to furnish a fully as just a measure, if only one could get it laid out according to a plan answering to the idea, and become conscious of wherein the higher practical formation then really consists.

That the state has a measure — indeed a scale divided with mathematical exactness — in the qualifying examination now existing shall never be denied. But it is not merely a matter of having an exactly divided measure; it is at the same time a matter of having a measure that tolerably answers to the nature of the things that are to be measured with it. — If what is to be measured is far too heterogeneous with the measure, then it is of little use that the measure itself is exactly divided, like a graduated scale in inches and lines.

As regards the state, it can with respect to ecclesial affairs reasonably will nothing other than that the Church's servants shall in the best way look after the Church's needs. The question is therefore this: how far the theoretical preparation can now really make the candidate fit to take over a clerical office and in this his office look after the true needs of the Church and the congregation?

To discuss this question is a prolix matter; only a couple of words more before I conclude!

As a defense of theological dogmatics we have already heard that it is to stand in the most intimate connection with evangelical preaching: "to such a sermon corresponds such a dogmatics, to such a dogmatics such a sermon."

If we now hold to this theological presupposition, and add what is likewise undeniable, that theological science has many different, mutually contradictory dogmatics, then it follows that the congregation must gradually also get many different, mutually contradictory sermons to hear.

This is then also in practice a well-known matter. Every preacher as a rule preaches, if not exactly according to a definite dogmatics, then at any rate according to the theological tendency to which his academic formation belongs: the orthodox orthodoxly, the rationalist rationalistically, and so on. — In this way the ecclesial original Word is exposed to all the alterations that human knowing and human theories undergo; in this way the age's spirits force their way into the congregations, and make themselves little by little masters over revelation's Word.

We praise Luther and the Reformers for having cleansed the Gospel of the Middle Ages' manifold human, arbitrary additions (*traditiones humanæ*); but what shall we now

judge of the many mutually overturning dogmatic theories? do these not also contain *traditiones humanæ*? But if the evangelical Church has been freed from superstition's medieval corruptions only to fall forfeit to the scientific theories' manifold modern corruptions: how much is then, in a religious sense, gained by the exchange?

One does indeed now and then see how theoretical theology begins to pull itself together, and we must really acknowledge that in many ways, among us too, it strives to appropriate the Christian content and make the doctrine fruitful for the Church and the congregation. Yet the endeavor will not rightly succeed; "Christian science" is lawfully excused: one cannot demand of the theory what exceeds the theory's powers. — Every Christian theory that keeps within objective knowing will further be dissolved into a half-Christian one, and this in turn into an un-Christian one; and that for the simple reason that Christian theory is a contradiction.

Insofar as preaching goes on conforming to theory and theology, it cannot possibly withstand the spirit of the age. The weakening already showed itself in the last half of the previous century, when the newer enlightenment broke in over the old state-church dams. Instead of defying the modern consciousness and maintaining Christianity's Christian character, the pastors seized on the expedient of abating something in original Christianity's strict demand, so that "the enlightened" should not entirely disdain religion and wholly abandon the Church. With this accommodation Christianity lost its force, in losing its sting; but the theory of accommodation was itself an invention of theology.

In a religious sense Christianity is the absolute; where it cannot and may not be the absolute, it is not at all. In a religious sense faith is the absolute; where it cannot and may not be the absolute, it is not at all. Here, then, we stand again at the result *that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*

Eleventh Lecture

Theoretical theology must relate itself skeptically to Christianity's revealed truth; practical theology, which in imagined existence labors to solve the Christian tasks, must end by dissolving itself: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

That a religious science is a contradiction, that a science of revelation is a contradiction; that therefore any theology whatsoever (be it Muhammadan, Jewish, or Christian) is in this respect a contradiction, I have in the foregoing striven to show, in that from several sides I have endeavored to illuminate the opposition between religious knowledge and objective knowing.

But although in these lectures I have thus expressly protested against theology's Christian scientific rigor and scientific Christianity, I have nevertheless — be it noted — protested neither against an objective science about Christianity nor against a religious knowledge of Christianity. If one will now comprehend these two different kinds of knowledge under one designation, and use for it the ancient name hitherto employed, theology, I shall have nothing against it: about mere names we will not quarrel.

Theology will therefore, according to the view here set up, not be abolished; but it will alter its nature and its relation to Christianity. — Theology thus altered will then again divide itself into two main parts: the theoretical and the practical.

Theoretical theology we then characterize as science in the sense that it is an objective knowing about Christianity's facticity. This knowing about Christianity's facticity must be carefully distinguished from the so-called objective knowing of Christianity's truth. The fundamental error in the prevailing theology is, in my conviction, precisely this: that one throughout confuses the latter with the former.

With the false presupposition that in faith's name there is to be an objective knowing of Christianity's objective truth, theology has hitherto placed itself in a positive, affirming relation to Christianity itself, and undertaken its defense by objective grounds. The insufficiency of this defense emancipated reflection has discovered, and therewith the modern prejudice has forced its way in that the freethinker could make an end of

Christianity because he can in a certain sense make an end of theology.

If, on the other hand, we conceive theoretical theology as an objective knowing about Christianity's facticity, the point of view will instantly alter. Theological science will then no longer place itself in a directly affirming relation to Christian truth, but only in a direct relation to the Christian phenomenon. The theoretical task will therefore become a double one. In the first place science must strive to make clear to itself what the Christian is, whereby it is distinguished from the non-Christian — in general, how original Christianity appears to objective contemplation. Next, science must in relation to the Christian phenomenon thus clarified give an account of what proofs and objective grounds there are for the phenomenon's validity. — As science now comes out with all its grounds, the result will show itself that there are exactly as many grounds that speak *against* as there are grounds that speak *for* Christianity. Only when science sees this is it impartial, and only when it is impartial is it what it ought to be, a true objective science.

Accordingly: the science that from its investigations gets the result that there are more grounds speaking for Christianity than against it is *one-sided*; and likewise the science that supposes it can exhibit more and weightier grounds against Christianity than for it is *one-sided*. True science's true result is here a negative result, a *non liquet*.

Objective science is here to be presented under the image of objective Justice holding the balance in her hand: in the one scale are all the positive, in the other all the negative grounds: so the scales are held in equilibrium. In this equilibrium there is no decision; for the decision to come about, something else must be added: this something else is — either faith or unbelief. If I now take unbelief and lay it on the negative scale, this at once sinks, and the positive grounds lose their weight; if conversely I lay faith's infinite weight in the positive scale, then all the negative grounds are outweighed, and as easily as if they were not there at all. As Justice, who holds the balance, has her eyes bound so that she shall not be partial to either of the contending parties, so science too has in this respect its eyes bound, so that it shall not be partial to faith or unbelief.

That this is now not merely an image but at the same time a truth I believe I can establish by a consideration of theology's various disciplines. To avoid prolixity I confine myself to three: isagogics, hermeneutics, dogmatics.

Isagogics, free scientific biblical criticism, theology ought not to give up, but should rather work at carrying it through, so that it may reach the final and purest result. But everything now depends on what notion one is to form of the final and purest result. — So long as one persists in the prejudice that the result can in any way become decisive for faith or unbelief, biblical criticism will never be able to raise itself to a scientific

impartiality: the religious man will then always be too sparing, the freethinker too unsparing. There is surely nothing that in recent times has so inflamed freethinking as the ambiguity that biblical criticism, according to theology's own confession, was to be a free science, and yet could never become one so long as every theologian went on mixing his bit of faith into the purely scientific proceedings. If, on the other hand, we proceed from the presupposition that biblical criticism neither can nor shall settle anything for faith, but rather has the task of bringing it to the highest possible equilibrium of proofs of probability *for and against*, then science becomes impartial and therewith at the same time thorough.

Hermeneutics, the science of free interpretation, cannot be halted and ought not to be either. At every new stage that the science of interpretation traverses, the human spirit wins ever new scientific clarity about itself and its general relation to Holy Scripture. But everything again depends on what notion one forms of biblical interpretation's final and purest result. — If one imagines that scientific biblical interpretation will at length get so far that it will be able to settle how far the inspired Word is divine and how far it is human, then this science will never become impartial, and to that extent never thorough either. The religious man will always be too sparing, the freethinker too unsparing: the impersonal relation will at one stroke become personal, the scientific dispute unscientific.

A scientific theory of inspiration is a contradiction. Everyone who attempts to develop such a theory is by the force of the consequences continually thrown from the one extreme to the other, and thus tossed about as between Scylla and Charybdis.

Inspiration in the whole is an empty turn of phrase; inspiration in the particular is intolerable to science. If I begin by striking out the particulars, then it ends with there being — in the whole — nothing at all left. If, for example, I cannot believe the miracle of the Gadarene demoniacs, then neither can I believe the miracle of Peter's draught of fishes; then neither Christ's walking on the sea; then neither Christ's transfiguration on the mountain; then neither the angels' appearance at Christ's birth; then neither the angels' appearance at Christ's grave; then neither Christ's visible ascension; but let us now be a little consistent — then surely neither Christ's resurrection either; and then finally — for consistency's sake — neither Christianity.

If conversely I begin by positing a single narrative as inspired and infallible, then the one draws the other after it, and in such a way that the whole Bible with all its wonders at last becomes inspired. If, for example, I assume that Christ is risen by a miracle, then I must surely also assume that the angels may have appeared to the women by a miracle;

then also that they may have appeared to the shepherds by a miracle; then also Christ's transfiguration on the mountain by a miracle; then also his walking on the sea by a miracle; then also the miracle of Peter's draught of fishes; then also the miracle of the Gadarene demoniacs; then also — to be a little consistent — the miracle of Balaam's ass; then finally also — to be entirely consistent — every single miracle narrative in the whole Old Testament.

Here in these consequences of the theory of inspiration there is a fluctuation, a surf, a breaking of waves more terrible than the breaking of waves at the stormy headland. In such a breaking of waves it is entirely impossible to steer scientifically by science's compass; for the expedient of accepting some miracles, construing others differently, and rejecting others is nothing but an unscientific evasion, an evasion by which one nevertheless at last makes everything depend on a subjective judgment; but in subjective judgment science is dissolved.

As Holy Scripture the Bible sets itself in the most definite terms against every objective theory of inspiration; for as Holy Scripture it is only for the believing subjectivity. Scientific interpretation must consequently end with there being just as many grounds speaking against inspiration as there are grounds speaking for it; that is, in other words: science ends in skepticism, and can settle nothing whatever about the Bible's inspiration.

Dogmatics, as objective theological science, ought not to be abolished, but should rather be developed consistently to the point where the true relation between faith and knowing can show itself clearly and definitely. If one now conceives the relation in such a way that faith can in any way be clarified, grounded, and confirmed in knowing, then one is also compelled to grant that faith can likewise be darkened, confused, and weakened in knowing; if one grants that knowing can in any way be clarified, confirmed, and grounded in faith, then one must surely also grant that knowing itself can be darkened, confused, and weakened in faith. The believer then gets in this way a believing knowing, the unbeliever an unbelieving knowing, the half-believer a half-believing knowing. Knowing has then in this way lost its objective character; objective knowing courts subjective feeling, knowing enters second childhood: science is dissolved.

If science is to treat the dogmas scientifically, then it will surely show itself that every dogma has just as many repelling as attracting grounds, that at every dogma there stands "a cross for thought," that scientific reflection relates itself skeptically to faith.

The manner in which the scientific testing of the dogmas is undertaken can for the rest be various; but this stands fast, that the question of the dogma's comprehensibility and incomprehensibility must be settled impartially — that is, without any subjective

regard whatever to subjective conviction. — I am permitted to believe the dogma although I do not comprehend it — indeed that is precisely religion's demand, that I *shall* believe because I *cannot* comprehend —; on the other hand I am not at all permitted to act as though I could nearly comprehend a dogma because I should so much like to believe it.

When dogmatics develops with scientific consistency, it passes over into the philosophy of religion; but the philosophy of religion's final and purest result is, in relation to revelation's fact, to be expressed thus: *Science comprehends that it cannot comprehend.*

Thus all theoretical theology's disciplines now stand in the same negative, skeptical relation to Christianity's truth. All the same, this negative relation cannot be settled once and for all. Science does not let itself be dismissed by immediate protest; the not-knowing in which science is here to end must each time be attained by knowing's way. Theoretical theology can therefore to that extent be said to find itself in a constant advance, in that each time it runs anew the road from presupposed knowing to not-knowing, it at the same time rejuvenates itself and wins renewed clarity about itself and its relation to revelation's phenomenon.

As regards next practical theology, it is at once seen that it lies in quite another sphere than the theoretical. Theoretical theology is a free science independent of faith; practical theology, on the other hand, is no science; it is a school for Christian upbringing, for existential knowledge, knowledge in faith and out of faith.

As we now expressly remark that practical theology is no proper science, this remark will perhaps make on many the impression that this theology in its unscientific character must therefore necessarily stand at a far lower stage than the theoretical. That is a prejudice, a modern prejudice, that hangs together quite naturally with the presupposition that science as science must everywhere in knowledge's kingdom be the highest. But in relation to Christian upbringing, science as science is not the highest, and cannot possibly be so, insofar as Christianity itself is higher than science. — As a school for the higher Christian formation, practical theology ought as a rule to have the theoretical for its presupposition, i.e. for its negative foundation. Theoretical theology can then in this respect be regarded as a learned preparatory school, a scientific school of preparation for the practical.

That the matter must stand thus one can best convince oneself by setting the practical disciplines alongside the corresponding theoretical ones. — Insofar as theoretical theology occupies itself with Christianity's facticity and the Christian phenomena, it must necessarily also go on occupying itself with the Church and the ecclesial phenomena. But since all its investigations are hypothetical, its results too will dissolve into nothing

but hypothetical judgments.

“If Christianity has reality, the Church must also have reality.” — “If the Church has reality, it must be possible to show what it is and where it is, i.e. then the concept of the Church must be capable of being fixed with decisive definiteness.” . . . Conversely: “If the concept of the Church cannot be fixed with decisive definiteness, then the Church has no reality.” — “If the Church has no reality, then Christianity has no reality either.”

Thus theoretical theology moves among nothing but hypothetical judgments; but from these judgments it can nevertheless not come to draw a single definite conclusion, since it, as objective science, has no power over faith and unbelief, and therefore everywhere must lack the categorical minor premise. Only in practical theology is faith’s categorical minor premise put in, and the hypothetical judgments can then here furnish premises for hypothetical conclusions.

In practical theology one now infers thus:

“If Christianity has reality, then the Christian Church must also have reality;

Now Christianity has — for us, the believers — the highest, absolute reality;

Ergo: the Christian Church also has its true, fully valid reality.”

Further:

“If the Church has reality, then it must also be possible to show with definiteness what the Church is and where it is, i.e. then the concept of the Church must be capable of being fixed and held fast with decisive definiteness.

Now the Church has — for us, the believers — a true, decisive reality;

Ergo: the concept of the Church must also let itself be fixed and held fast with decisive definiteness.”

From this one sees how naturally theoretical theology introduces the practical, and therewith at the same time how different they are. By the hypothetical major premise both schools are connected; but the categorical minor premise fixes a yawning gulf between them. For theoretical theology the Church is a hovering magnitude whose reality is hypothetical; for practical theology the Church stands fast as a categorical authority, an objective power whose authority no one may doubt.

The Church is then now, according to its concept, to be determined as Christianity factually present, as that communion of the Spirit which in its Apostles’ Creed, in its sacraments, and in its Holy Scripture has preserved revelation’s inspired original Word.

But although the Church in this way presents itself objectively, it is nevertheless just as impossible to relate oneself objectively to the Church as it is, according to our foregoing, impossible to relate oneself objectively to Christian truth. If one now again attempts to

derive objective proofs for Christianity from the Church's factual existence, then one falls back again into theoretical theology's hypotheses, and must begin over. What the Church proclaims objectively, each individual believer must appropriate subjectively: the Church lives only in the congregation's believing subjectivity.

Practical theology therefore gets the great task of making clear the fundamental existential relation that thus obtains between the Church's objective essence and the congregation's subjective faith. To elucidate this by an example I refer again to Holy Scripture.

When with respect to the inspired Scripture we place the Church's objective authority in relation to subjective faith, the religious tension at once sets in. This tension is in its immediate appearance so strong that at first glance it looks as if all religious bonds of communion must at one stroke burst.

It is as though by the force of the consequences one were again thrown from the one extreme to the other, from the extreme of a Catholic compelling objectivity that crows freedom with "blind faith," to the extreme of a Protestant unbridled subjectivity that chooses and rejects in subjective arbitrariness. Superficially regarded, the relation must show itself thus; for we have in actuality set the very strictest objectivity against the highest subjective freedom.

What follows from this? By no means that the objective should now be softened in scientific mediation with the subjective, or the subjective enfeebled in speculative mediation with the objective. By such a mediation one assuredly attains no "organic union"; one attains only a neutralization in which one has neither the objective nor the subjective, but an unclear mixture in a "third and higher." The relation between the objective Church and subjective faith is existential, not scientific.

In the existential relation free subjectivity must strive its way forward in order to win faith; in this strife of faith the subject must, so to speak, wrestle with the Church's inspired Scripture, as Jacob in the valley wrestled with God. The subjectivity that in the wrestling is kindled with offense and rebels against God's Word becomes an enemy of Christ, a freethinker who mocks Christianity and hates the Church. The subjectivity that wrestles with Scripture and yet holds out in faith receives a new name and a blessing when the morning dawns; but the strong wrestling at the same time sets its mark on him: he limps his life through. — He who will hear a human word and listen to a human counsel must first be still; but he who is to hear God's Word and listen to God's counsel must be inwardly still.

In inward stillness, then, appropriation begins — not of the whole Scripture, for there

is surely no one who can begin with the whole at once — but of a single original word, a single passage, a single Gospel. If there is no passage at all, no original word, no event in all Holy Scripture that finds entry with subjectivity, then the individual still stands outside the Church, and here there can be no talk of any understanding. If, on the other hand, the Church and Scripture have a word that makes its way through the human being's inner life, but a single word, an original word that like "a two-edged sword pierces through, even to the dividing asunder of soul and spirit, and of the joints and marrow, and judges the thoughts and intents of the heart" (Heb. 4:12) — if the Church and Scripture have but a single such word: then faith has begun, and with it understanding.

Existential understanding is now not aimed at building a new theory of the Bible either on the Gadarene demons or on Balaam's ass or on Noah's rainbow or on the six days of creation in the beginning; such theories are now readily left to "the scientific," who always have time enough to dispute about the theories. The believer who is to appropriate the inspired Word has, as a believer, in faith no time to dispute: every moment he thus disputes away in time he has lost for eternity. The believer who is to appropriate revelation's Word has, as a believer, in faith no boldness to reason (the boldness to reason with the Church about the separation of the divine and the human in Scripture's word is now readily conceded to "the scientific," who in witty theories seek witty diversion); the believing subjectivity does not need theoretical diversion, but what he needs is — to save his soul, to collect his mind on the one thing needful.

As the many subjectivities now begin appropriation, each from its own point of view, there is here indeed a diversity and therewith at the same time a subjective freedom; but this diversity is not dissipating, this freedom is not arbitrary.

The believing subjectivities that, each in its own way, strive to appropriate Scripture's word all find themselves under the same presupposition; they have all bowed before the confession of faith and the sacraments; they have all humbled themselves under the Church's objective authority. The Christian spirit of communion with its holy ideals then rests over all these subjectivities, so bound in faith, so set free in faith. Each individual begins originally with his own particular, but each individual has in his particular at the same time the whole. Each individual has begun the appropriation from his own peculiar point of departure; but each individual strives nevertheless at the same time from his own peculiar point of departure toward the same goal, i.e. the full appropriation of the order of salvation. Each individual is a one-sidedness in his limited subjectivity, but the limited subjectivities have at the same time, each in itself, the original center, and therefore move together about the one common center, that is: about the congregation's

ideal subjectivity.

On these conditions it now becomes possible to lay the foundation of a biblical interpretation that exactly answers to the principle of the faith of the Gospel. Every attempt to explain away the wondrous and to efface the distinctive is here rejected as un-Christian. The Christian interpretation of the Bible's facts becomes recognizable in the particular by the Word's revealing power: here is the foundation for practical hermeneutics.

Here in the Church, in Christ's kingdom, are the Spirit's various gifts; here are the means of grace; here are possibilities and conditions for mutual instruction, admonition, and edification, as here are possibilities and conditions for a true development of freedom in existential appropriation of faith's Gospel.

In this communion of the Spirit, simplicity is compatible with the freest reflection. The relation between the congregation and the Church is a relation of faith; the relation between the congregation's members among themselves is a relation of faith: faith is in simplicity, as simplicity is in faith. But when reflection enters in, there is here at the same time required the highest intelligence, the strictest dialectic. The relation between the Church and the world is dialectical, in inversion: the Church is in this world, and is yet not of this world; the Church is visible in the world and yet not visible to the world; the Church is seen and yet not seen; this is the dialectical. The relation between the Church and the congregation is dialectical, in inversion. The congregation's subjectivity builds on the Church as on its firm rock, its objective foundation, but the Church is objective only for the congregation's faith. The believing subjectivity itself bears the foundation by which it is borne: subjectivity bears the Church insofar as it is borne by the Church; this is the dialectical. The relation between the individual and the congregation is dialectical, in continued inversion. The brothers' and sisters' faith strengthens my faith, their hope my hope, their love my love: I thank God, then, that I do not stand alone; for if I stood alone — in the Church, eternity's powers would terrify me, and holiness's ideals cast me down in the dust. But the brothers' and sisters' faith is nevertheless there for me only by means of my own faith; their hope is there for me only insofar as it is my hope; their love is there for me only insofar as I understand it in my love — therefore: the objective is there for me only insofar as I understand it subjectively, and I understand it subjectively only insofar as I understand it in inversion, and precisely thereby understand it as faith's objective. So I am in inversion everywhere referred back to myself, and, so to speak, driven into myself; so I shall myself bear the whole congregation's faith in my faith, the whole congregation's hope in my hope, the whole congregation's love in my love: so

I thank God, then, that I am to stand alone, quite alone, although I stand in the midst of the congregation; for only he who stands alone — before God, stands on freedom's ground; only he who stands alone before God becomes terrified before eternity's powers; only he who is terrified before eternity's powers and bowed down with terror is raised up and strengthened with confidence.

Regarded from this point of view, practical theology will have many and great tasks to solve; everywhere it comes upon the inverted relations of faith's existence, and yet these inverted relations are at the same time to be explained in such a way that they can be understood in all simplicity, for faith is the simple. However much dialectical art practical theology may for the rest summon up in order to solve these tasks: the last and most important thing in every solution is nevertheless always this, that it at the same time dissolves itself. Only in dissolving itself in the solution of the tasks does practical theology point to existence, actual existence, where everyone in particular is to solve his task on his own responsibility. If practical theology neglects this thorough self-dissolution, then the theory comes again, and with the theory scientific rigor, and with scientific rigor objective theology, and with objective theology the weakening of the faith of the Gospel, and then everything is in confusion. This confusion must then further be halted by a decisive protest; this decisive protest will then further sound still as before, *that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*

Twelfth Lecture

If practical theology does not understand how to remove its theoretical semblance, this semblance will mislead religious formation still far more than open theory does. Theoretical theology, which cannot deny its essential difference from religious practice, will, by furthering its scientific interests in the spirit of science, go on working fruitfully and formatively upon all who in the inwardness of faith recognize that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.

The present age asserts, and rightly, that there is a difference between learning and cultivation, a great difference between being in the strictest sense a learned man and being in the highest sense a cultivated man. This distinction between learning and cultivation ought then also to come into consideration when the talk is of theology's two-sided character and purpose. Theoretical theology has its strength chiefly in learning; the practical, on the other hand, must use learning as a means for personal cultivation.

As a learned science, theoretical theology then gets a double labor: partly to propagate and perfect itself, partly to prepare practical cultivation. In the first respect theological science, like every other science, has its purpose in itself, and ought to be cultivated for its own sake; in the last respect it is to be used as a means for a purpose lying outside it; in the first respect it furnishes a high school for theologians, in the last a preparatory school for pastors.

These two heterogeneous tasks may not be confused with one another; every such confusion occasions disorder. If, for example, at the Academy of Art, where lectures are indeed given on the classical works of antiquity, one were to go so thoroughly into learned investigations that out of sheer thoroughness one forgot the hearers' interest, so that one at last lectured for archaeologists instead of lecturing for artists, would the mistake not be conspicuous? Or if at the military academy, where among other things lectures are indeed also given on chemistry, one were now to hold these lectures so extraordinarily thoroughly that out of sheer thoroughness one forgot the aim, so that one was at bottom lecturing not for warriors-to-be but for learned natural scientists:

would the confusion not be striking? In every endeavor it is a matter of holding fast to the aim, the ultimate οὐ ἕνεκα, without which the endeavor must necessarily fail. Just as a philologist or a historian must arrange his lecture differently when his science is merely to be used as a higher means of cultivation than when he lectures for such as cultivate the science for its own sake, so the theologian too ought surely to give his lecture a different stamp when he lectures for students who use the theory only as a preparatory school than when he lectures for theologians by profession.

That, for example, isagogics, exegesis, hermeneutics, church history, and so on are lectured with the greatest possible fullness and the most thorough use of the whole literature belonging to them is in order when learned lectures are given for theologians-to-be; but it is by no means in order when propaedeutic lectures are given for pastors-to-be.

Propaedeutic lectures overloaded with too much material fail of their purpose: they take up too much time, they weaken the hearers' interest, they occasion a hidden discontent on both sides. It must constantly seem to the hearers as though the lecturer silently wished to force them against their interest to become learned, and that in such subjects as ought really only to serve their cultivation; and it seems in turn to the lecturer as though the hearers at the theoretical examination seldom or never furnished what he, after the rich compass of his thorough lecture, should think himself entitled to demand. The consequence is that the theoretical examination must be at one and the same time both too strict and too lax: too strict, in that one at bottom demands more than one can demand in accordance with the real aim; too lax, in that one must then on the other hand turn a blind eye to the candidate's weaknesses. Fate, chance, and blind luck are then also apt to play a part in all such qualifying examinations.

These defects fall away when the propaedeutic lectures are laid out so as to correspond exactly to their definite aim. The lectures given in the theological preparatory school on isagogics, exegesis, hermeneutics, church history, and so on ought by no means to be superficial or to confine themselves to insipid surveys and aphoristic remarks. On the contrary! precisely for that reason such lectures ought to be given by learned and thorough theologians, because the learned and thorough theologian best understands how to master the material, give the presentation its due stamp of character, and place the detail in the right spot, without wearying the hearers with fumbling remarks and rambling investigations. In this way the hearer would receive a fruitful impression of science's course and significance; in this way the student who really studies would be enabled to use science as a means to a freer cultivation; in this way the mass of knowledge would on the whole not become greater than that at the ensuing qualifying examination

one could demand, and demand with inviolable strictness, that the candidate now also had both the idea and the material in his power, and was able to develop each single point with the greatest exactness.

To such courses in the learned disciplines philosophical studies would have to attach themselves in a free and natural way. Suitable lectures on the history of philosophy, on metaphysics, and then especially on rational ethics and the philosophy of religion would surely in this connection be very fruitful.

Thus prepared in the theoretical preparatory school, the candidate now passes over into the practical school, the institution of formation that shows him his vocation, his real purpose, his life's ideal task — the institution of formation that must therefore for him become the true and proper "high school."

In this practical high school the various courses can again be laid out and arranged so that the transition from the preparatory theory to the consummating practice takes place as naturally as possible.

Practical theology must of course begin with the doctrine of the Church. In the doctrine of the Church, the Church's history is at once to be conceived from a new principal side, namely from faith's point of view. From this religious-ethical point of view the characters and events of church history appear otherwise than they do to objective scientific contemplation. For the believing conception of the Church's essence, symbolics and liturgics, the various types of doctrine with their corresponding rites, appear otherwise than in the theoretical presentation. The entering hearer meets here everywhere the old well-known facts; but these facts now show themselves to him at the same time in a new light; he sees the old become new again; he feels that he must begin over: he feels himself rejuvenated and refreshed, and begins with rising interest.

On the doctrine of the Church follows the religious-ethical interpretation of Holy Scripture. Here too the preliminary knowledge will come into application, here too the old will return: scientific interpretation together with the philosophy of religion and rational ethics will now at many points touch religious-ethical biblical interpretation; but the old becomes new in showing itself from a new side: religious-ethical interpretation will now first in earnest maintain its distinctive character, and Christian ethics be illuminated by rational ethics according to the well-known rule: *opposita juxta se posita magis illucescunt*.

To the interpretation of Scripture attach themselves catechetics and homiletics. One will already see from this how imagined existence strives out beyond itself toward the actual. In the religious-ethical interpretation of Holy Scripture the Christian concepts

are still developed in merely imagined existence, that is: without particular regard to the various human beings who are at once to translate these concepts into life. Catechesis and preaching, on the other hand, presuppose straightforwardly the presence of religious individuals, of individuals who must each for himself lay the revealed truth to heart, understand it for his own use, understand it in practical appropriation.

So the tasks rise as one approaches actual life. As pastoral theology at last concludes with an existential development of the fellowship of souls, the intimate relation that shall and ought to obtain between the pastor and the congregation — i.e. with everything that in a stricter sense belongs under the cure of souls — it at the same time points beyond itself, dissolves itself, and then sends the young preacher out from the school into life, where he must then in turn begin over with caring for his own soul, in becoming a curate of souls for others.

From this fleeting sketch it will surely be possible to discern how different practical education is from theoretical pre-formation. This difference presses forward from yet another side.

In the theoretical school the hearer is really too passive, insofar as he is merely contemplative, and he is contemplative insofar as he most immediately has only to think through and study up the disciplines that are immediately lectured to him; in the practical school the candidate is active: here he can be taught only in teaching himself as well; here he can appropriate the lecture only in trying himself as well in the practice corresponding to the lecture's direction. He learns to preach only in alternately hearing lectures on homiletics, hearing another preach, and therewith exercising himself in preaching; he learns to catechize only in alternately hearing catechetics' direction, hearing another catechize, and therewith exercising himself in catechizing.

The intimate union of theory and practice hereby presupposed brings it about at the same time that the actual qualifying examination in the practical school must be undergone in quite another way than in the theoretical. The theoretical examination settles everything at one stroke. After the hearer has for several years sat in contemplative concealment as an intelligence half unknown to the teacher — perhaps even to himself — there comes at last the day of examination, and this day of examination is then at one stroke to unveil to him the yield he has won, and make him manifest to himself and the world. It is otherwise with the practical examination. The material of learning here employed is not of so considerable a compass that it gives a hearer much to do with mere learning by heart for an examination. The candidate in the practical school is really, if you will, every day — indeed every moment — under examination. The quality by

which he is to know himself is then neither a strong memory nor a quick understanding — still less some single distinctive talent — for it is the religious sense. If he lacks this sense — that is, if the religious-ethical interest is not the fundamental interest governing his whole life — he will soon notice in himself that he does not belong in the circle of teachers of religion, and will then also be able to withdraw in time in order to strike out on another course. If, on the other hand, the candidate understands himself in the religious-ethical interest, if he works at his personal formation with all diligence and vigilance, then he will also recognize that the studies and exercises here laid down are precisely calculated to help him to the spiritual development he so inwardly desires. The proof of this is not postponed to a total reckoning at the end, but expresses itself in part every time he succeeds by a single test in displaying his diligence and ability. The candidate then does not sit in contemplative concealment as a doubtful quantity whose hidden qualities first come to light when the final experiment is undertaken; no, the candidate becomes from the beginning manifest in relation to his striving: he gets from the beginning the opportunity to test himself piece by piece, in that in his fellow students' presence he is piece by piece tested by his teachers.

If one now arranges these preliminary tests so that their result has due influence on the assessment of the final concluding examination, then one has a measure of the candidate's ability, a measure that is doubtless as objectively qualified as is well possible.

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Thus far have I thought it right to go in making practical theology's method intuitable, in order to determine its purpose and indicate its direction. But further I ought not to go in this connection either. I have set myself the task of shedding light on a principle, but by no means the task of putting forward any practical proposal or working at any outward alteration in the established order.

Why, in view of my attempts, there can in general be no thought of any outward alteration of the established order I must nevertheless explain a little more closely in conclusion, lest the whole should at last dissolve into a great misunderstanding.

If the religious-ethical idea is to acknowledge an outward alteration, this alteration may not at all be hastened by any outward consideration whatsoever, but must proceed from the idea itself alone. It is a difficult task to realize this idea's demand; if the execution then failed, the blunder would only be the more painful. It is almost unavoidable that practical formation, as I have here described it, should also in its own way, at least provisionally, take on the semblance of a theory. This theoretical semblance can be removed and done away with only by the most vigilant thinking, the most strenuous

dialectic. If the thinking that develops the theory does not at the same time have all the acuteness, maturity, and superiority necessarily required to dissolve the theory again in all directions, practical theory will retain its theoretical semblance, and this theoretical semblance will then work far more perniciously and be far more dangerous to religious practice than theoretical theory.

Theoretical theory stands, in accordance with its scientific character, in a merely mediate relation to actual existence. As this relation is now recognized for what it is, a merely mediate relation, the semblance is at the same time removed, and existence *eo ipso* freed from the theory. The theoretically formed man soon notices that it is something quite other to work in life than to read in school. Existence involuntarily compels him to begin over, and in beginning over he begins primitively with discovering the ethical laws and the conditions for practical formation. If, on the other hand, he is at the same time formed by a directly practical theory, a theory that gives itself the semblance of explaining existence itself to him without nevertheless being able to free him from the theoretical that clings to the explanation, then he is much exposed to confusing practical theory with actual practice, and finds his way with difficulty in existence's freedom. All the one-sided methods, all the mannerisms and bad habits that are usually carried over from the practical schools into practical life are as a rule explained by the fact that practical theory has lacked dialectical force to remove its theoretical semblance and thrust the disciple away from itself — out into existence.

An outward alteration really calculated on the religious-ethical idea may never be hastened by selfish impatience; such impatience is in evident contradiction with the idea itself. The religious-ethical principle is precisely inwardness's principle, and that in the very highest potency. True inwardness knows itself in this world always heterogeneous with any outward condition whatsoever. This heterogeneity is inwardness's burden; but inwardness is strengthened precisely by bearing its burden. There is no danger at all that true inwardness, where it has once been awakened, should be stifled and die under the pressure of the outward; on the contrary, it is much to be feared that an all too happy inwardness should all too happily expire in an all too happy harmony with its outward condition; such a happy harmony is always in this existence a more or less unhappy delusion of sense: true harmony is only in the blessed life. Under every tension with the outward, religious inwardness must know how to understand itself in its relation to eternity, and in this its relation to eternity be sufficient to itself. Everywhere that inwardness has not yet learned to be sufficient to itself, but restlessly and selfishly craves outward alterations, it is still only an immature awakening and no true inwardness; but

where true inwardness is not yet, there inwardness's true principle cannot be recognized either.

If, then, anyone understands the religious-ethical principle in such a way that in this understanding he now feels himself called and moved to prepare an outward objective defeat for objective theology, then he shows precisely thereby that his outward-turned consciousness still lacks true inwardness; and in thus, in a lamentable lack of true force of inwardness, setting all his hope on an outward alteration of conditions, he proves at the same time that he has not understood the principle at all.

As regards these lectures in particular, I must expressly remark that I should have felt obliged to lay them out on a quite different plan and to hold them in a different tone if it had been my intention to propose any outward practical alteration. I should then have had to lay upon myself a threefold obligation: partly to express myself at length on the particular manner in which theology is treated and lectured at this University; partly with respect to this to put forward my practical proposals in due detail; partly finally to treat the whole with all the caution, circumspection, and forbearance that so highly important and difficult a matter requires. None of these is here the case. I have not inveighed against any single theological school in particular; what I have here uttered against the prevailing theology touches the individual tendencies only insofar as it touches theology in general. Nor have I engaged in any final assessment of the theological practice followed among us (the difficulty of such an assessment I fully acknowledge); what I have said in the tenth lecture about the relation, or rather the disproportion, between theory and practice is exclusively calculated to make intuitable the difference of principle between theoretical and practical theology, but by no means calculated to hasten any outward, final alteration in the academic order introduced among us. Finally, these lectures, which I shall now conclude, are not exactly held with any particular regard to what one otherwise understands by caution, circumspection, and forbearance; on the contrary! they are even in a certain sense — I say it without regret — they are in a certain sense held as inconsiderately and unsparingly as possible.

Thus have I willed it with deliberate purpose. But I have nevertheless not willed it so because I for my part was so inwardly dissatisfied with the outward established order that I then knew nothing else to do than to see whether I might perhaps awaken the same dissatisfaction in others. Far from it! I acknowledge with all readiness that in our theological institution, as it now stands, there stir both sound and able forces, forces that can satisfy even a higher demand, if only the students study as they ought. I have, as a university teacher, no calling to put forward any public judgment on my most reverend

colleagues' official activity; but on the other hand I have as a disciple of this University a right to express my gratitude to my former teachers. The learned ability with which the various disciplines are lectured in our theological faculty is assuredly so great that it will surely be able to enable the student to penetrate into science's and cultivation's various directions, if only he himself seriously will, and does not — what perhaps is unhappily sometimes the case — sink into critical peevishness and self-satisfied indolence.

It is no personal discontent with the outward established order that has occasioned my objections to the prevailing theology. I have no ground for such discontent: no man has personally offended me; no theological tendency stands hindering in the way of my endeavors. If I am to express a personal feeling, then I am for my part inwardly grateful both to the University and to the state for my position, and find myself very well in my academic relation to the studying youth. I strive to the best of my ability to do my duty; my word has hitherto not lacked a well-disposed attention from the students' side: so I hope, then, on these terms to be able to attend to my own affairs, and feel not at all called upon to meddle in others' — which exceeds both my powers and my competence.

When I have nevertheless held these discourses as freely and inconsiderately as I hereby confess, then the reason is simply this: that I have so much wished to forget all outward finite considerations in one single exclusive consideration, in regard for the religious-ethical idea and the question of principle connected with it.

With exclusive regard to the idea it is entirely necessary to set aside all other irrelevant considerations, and that especially when it is a matter of laying bare the want of principle in existing theories. This freedom and inconsiderateness is besides, at humanity's and cultivation's present stage, bound up with so little danger that if anyone will do anything at all for the idea's sake, this is the very least he can do.

The inconsiderateness with which the principle disentangles itself from a prevailing delusion it then makes good again by the self-limitation it so strictly imposes on every individual who might in any degree feel an inclination to serve the idea: that he may not at all strive for any outward purpose or think of winning any outward victory. — But inwardness's law is nevertheless not that the inner should be indifferent to the outer, or a conviction of truth indifferent to its utterance. There can and must be striving for the idea's right, only that one always strive with the idea's weapons, and use for it nothing but ideal forces.

Should it ever come so far with this high school that both teachers and hearers at last became so weary of the idea that they did not even care to contend either for or against a principle: would this not then be a sorry sign that the spirit had departed, and

the whole instruction sunk down into an empty mechanism?

When the question is of the relation of principle between faith-knowledge and objective knowing, then the philosopher is surely as entitled to have his say as the theologian; and when a theological theory is charged with want of principle, then there are, so far as I can judge, only two ways out that satisfy the idea: the one is to come out with a vigorous defense, if the attack is unwarranted; the other is to admit one's fault, if the attack is warranted; for the third way out — namely to hush up the whole investigation and let the attack blow over, as a hailstorm blows over — is only worldly prudence's evasion, an evasion that can easily end with one's at last having to evade the idea.

In order now not to become an accomplice in such an evasion, I have here expressed myself as plainly as possible, feeling convinced that at this University one could still set a question of principle in motion without this inner ideal motion's occasioning any outward disturbance whatsoever in any way.

So I conclude these lectures with the confidence that, even if on one point or another they may have offended some, they shall nevertheless not confuse anyone or seduce anyone into untimely despondency over the existing theories.

It goes with the dazzling theories as with the insubstantial semblance: they infatuate only him who cannot see through them. He who sees through the semblance is not deceived by the semblance; he who sees through the theory is not infatuated by the theory. But when the theories have ceased to infatuate us, they first begin in a higher sense to form us. We then learn to study the theory with inner freedom and therewith at the same time with earnestness and thoroughness. When the theory has then done its part, existence comes to our aid with our personal formation, and does its part.

Theology's young devotees can then still, as before, study their theological sciences with pleasure and zeal; they can study — the freethinker's attack, the apologist's defense, the interpreter's rules, the dogmatician's speculations — they can study it all, and it shall all do them good, if only under all these studies they will at the same time remember what lies in this thought, this one simple thought, *that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*



Postscript

When I began to work out and deliver these lectures, I had (as the Preface indeed shows) a kind of feeling that a prolix, protracted, and momentous conflict surely lay before us about “the great problem of the age,” about “faith’s relation to knowledge,” “knowledge’s relation to faith”; but — strangely enough! — just as I have now finished the revision of the work and see my Preface in print, the thought suddenly dawns on me that here at bottom there is nothing at all to dispute about.

The question of faith’s relation to knowledge has by two masters preeminent in dialectic, Johannes *de silentio* and Johannes Climacus, already been sufficiently answered in the one proposition: *Faith is a paradox*. To sit down and wait for new contributions, further explanations, personal declarations, and other such things before one delivers one’s final verdict on this point may indeed be as tempting to the spectators’ indolence as it accords with their caution — they who attend not so much to the matter as to the circumstances; but it is nevertheless true that he who cannot now see from the documents already before him what the principle is will hardly ever come to see it.

It stays, then, in short, with the proposition: *Faith is a paradox*. But however contentious this proposition may look at first glance, it is least of all a literary proposition of dispute. If one accepts the proposition, there is nothing here to dispute about. If one refuses to accept the proposition, it must surely be either because one does not understand it rightly or because one understands it as incorrect: in neither of these cases is there here material for dispute.

If one dares not accept the proposition because one does not understand it rightly, it is assuredly far more sensible to turn to the dialecticians named above and in all quietness make use of their guidance than at once to take the field with unassailable opinions and doubtful objections, and enter into a dispute about something one does not yet rightly understand.

If one rejects the proposition because one understands (or at any rate supposes one understands) it as incorrect, the endeavor will of course be directed at explaining away “the paradox” and conserving faith; but neither shall this endeavor be able to occasion dispute. One can really, if only one seriously will, quite readily explain away the paradox without much bother with dialectic; the supervising dialectic makes in that case no objections, but merely sees to it that the undertaking really succeeds — that is to say, that the explaining-away is done in such a way that both Christianity and Judaism, both the apostles’ and Abraham’s faith, are exactly and

consistently — explained away at the same time.

The faith that then remains when the paradox has been explained away is therefore a paradox-free faith, a pure, general, essential faith of reason common to all human beings, a faith of reason that every reasonable, nobly thinking, and cultivated man can be known to defend without exposing himself to “science’s” taking it ill and accusing “the knight of faith” of superstition. — In what category the faith of reason, or the paradox-free reasonable faith, is for the rest to be conceived I shall however not be able to say, since, frankly spoken, I do not know it. There is, if I remember rightly, a German novel entitled “Der Bräutigam ohne Braut”; better still would it be if, on the occasion of the pure paradox-free faith of reason accessible to “science,” one could at last get a Danish novel entitled “The Knight of Faith without Faith.” But suppose even that so remarkable a result were attained — a knight of faith without faith would after all cut a strange, almost paradoxical figure in a literary dispute about faith.

If one finally, on at last seeing oneself compelled to concede the proposition’s unconditional validity, were so resolute as to give up the religious and cast away all faith, in order at least in that way to be rid of the paradox, the matter would at one stroke take so serious a turn that one could then least of all think of accomplishing anything by learned disputes about faith.

To dispute about faith is human; but to strive for faith — yes, that is in truth divine. Happy is he who then knows how to strive so that he does not dispute; blessed is he to whom the Spirit granted to strive as one ought — the true divine strife in faith for faith!

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